THE SEMESTER BOOKS

Book 1 · Company, Brand & Operating

Company · Brand · Operating

One of three books that together cover everything about Semester: Book 1 Company, Brand & Operating · Book 2 Product · Book 3 Design System & Building. Compiled from *The Main Semester design system*.

Edition of 21 October 2026 · Pre-seed, founder-led · Large figures are labelled sample data

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BOOK 1

Company, Brand & Operating

What Semester is and how the company is built, positioned, presented and run.

Executive summary

Semester describes itself as the student action platform: one daily workspace that turns a student's semester into the next clear step, with the source of every fact shown beside it. The README also calls it the native Student Operating System for the whole educational journey, with workspaces for faculty, advisors, registrars, finance and IT or security staff. "Student OS" is internal only, because it implies replacement. The product works alongside a school's official systems (SIS, LMS, identity provider). It reads from them, labels each fact as official, connected, personal or AI-assisted, and shows when it last synced.

The company is Harrison Rubin's: a solo-founder LLC at pre-seed, bootstrapped, with no revenue. Contractors work under signed IP assignments. As of October 2026 a first paid pilot is signed with Vanderbilt University, but pilot start and renewal-decision dates are not set. The Operating Pack lists six launch blockers that must close before real student records arrive: cyber insurance, E&O insurance, DPA/FERPA obligation mapping, HECVAT Full, SAML SSO and a VPAT/ACR. It counts 23 open P0 items. Of its 56 checklist items, only LLC formation, IP assignments and the signed pilot agreement are marked done.

The target customer is a four-year university of 5,000 to 30,000 students. The champion is a director of student success, advising or the registrar; the economic buyer is a VP of Student Success, the provost's office or the CIO. The wedge offer is the Registration Readiness Pilot: one term, one cohort, named success measures, SSO and a read-only SIS sync. It targets students surprised by holds and missed registration steps, and overloaded advisors. The GTM plan's strategy in one line: universities first, through one paid one-term pilot per institution, with a renewal decision date. Vanderbilt is pilot #1 and its results are meant to become the case study that sells pilots #2 to #5. Free pilots are not allowed.

The business model has several planned streams, all priced as planning assumptions, not published prices. The student workspace is free at participating schools; Student Premium is planned at $8.99 a month or $69 a year. The institution platform is planned at $18 per enrolled student per year with a $30,000 minimum. Other lines are implementation ($35,000 to $150,000, waived or credited for early pilots), premium support, AI overage and a 12% marketplace commission. The pilot fee is quoted per pilot and credited against year one if the institution converts within 60 days of results. No source states the Vanderbilt fee; the Finance Model leaves it as "[signed fee]".

Go-to-market is founder-led. The 12-month targets are a 40-account target list, 15 discovery conversations, 10 demos, 6 pilot designs, 5 security and legal reviews, 3 signed pilots (including Vanderbilt) and 2 annual conversions. The sources say plainly that these are founder planning numbers, sized to one person selling alongside delivery.

The company is meant to run on the discipline it sells. The Company OS defines 15 business functions, each with an owner, system of record, priority and next action, plus a cadence and a KPI tree whose north star is students who complete their next action each week in the pilot cohort. The founder owns all 15 today. Hiring is revenue-triggered: no role opens until its trigger is true and signed revenue covers its cost. The setup budget is $5,000 to $20,000; the Finance Model's three scenarios total $4,873, $12,430 and $19,910, with a run-rate of about $565 a month and a $0 founder salary.

The brand stance is calm, precise and source-aware: "a good registrar's assistant crossed with a precision instrument." The company states status, not certifications it does not hold (no "SOC 2 compliant", no "FERPA certified"). The visual system uses near-black Ink chrome, warm Parchment content and one restrained Semester blue for action; every status carries a glyph and a word. A standing product rule is that student records never reach an AI provider.

The strategy documents are labelled "design-stage evidence only" and score platform maturity at an average of 1.16 out of 5. Several handoff artefacts are described as not yet run or tested. This overview reports what the founder's documents plan and claim; it does not verify that any of it exists in running code.

Semester in numbers

Planning rows are assumptions the sources say are not published or quoted prices. Sample and illustrative rows are not real company data.

Fact	Value	Source file
Company stage	Pre-seed, no revenue, bootstrapping, solo founder, LLC	ui_kits/business/Operating Pack.html
Customer status	First paid pilot signed with Vanderbilt; dates not set	README.md; docs/brief/One-pager.html
Pilot fee (Vanderbilt)	Not stated ("[signed fee]")	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Launch blockers / open P0 items	6 / 23	ui_kits/business/Operating Pack.html
Master checklist size	56 items	ui_kits/business/Operating Pack.html
Setup total, lean / base / full	$4,873 / $12,430 / $19,910 (budget range $5,000 to $20,000)	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Monthly run-rate after launch	$565 (about $6,780 a year)	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Cash needed before pilot fee, lean / base / full	$6,568 / $14,125 / $21,605	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Hosting plus AI per institution; gross margin (estimates)	About $1,500 a year; about 95% before people	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Institution platform (planning)	$18 per enrolled student per year, $30,000 floor	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
Student Premium (planning)	$8.99 a month or $69 a year	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
Implementation (planning)	$35,000 to $150,000 one-time; waived or credited for early pilots	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
Premium support (planning)	15% of platform fee, $15,000 minimum	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
AI overage / marketplace commission (planning)	$30 per 1,000 governed requests / 12%	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
Pilot credit rule	Credited against year 1 if annual order signed within 60 days of results	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html; docs/legal/Order Form.html
Revenue scenarios, base / high (planning)	Signed fee + $45,000 / + $90,000	docs/run/Finance Model.html
Discount limits	Multi-year up to 10% per year; reference up to 5%; nothing below floor	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
Spend approval threshold	Founder approves spend above $500	docs/business/FINANCE_AND_CAPITAL_SYSTEM.md
12-month pipeline targets	40 accounts, 15 discovery, 10 demo, 6 design, 5 security/legal, 3 pilots, 2 annual	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html
US postsecondary enrollment, fall 2025	19.4 million; public four-year about 7.9 million	ui_kits/business/Market Research.html
Theoretical ceiling at $18 (arithmetic, not forecast)	About $349 M a year (all); about $142 M (public four-year)	ui_kits/business/Market Research.html
Incumbent pricing signal (indicative, competitor-sourced)	$50,000 to $300,000 a year	ui_kits/business/Market Research.html
Illustrative 13,000-student university	About $234 k a year at $18 (enrollment illustrative)	ui_kits/business/Market Research.html
Pilot SLOs (not contractual)	SSO and availability 99.5%; freshness 99% within 15 min; p95 reads under 800 ms; AI student-record leaks: 0	docs/operate/Operations Handbook.html

Fact	Value	Source file
Support response targets	S1 15 min; S2 30 min; S3 1 h; S4 same business day	docs/launch/Support Plan.html
Disaster recovery; patching	RPO 24 h, RTO 8 h; critical 7 days, high 30	docs/secure/Security Policies.html
Platform security review	11 findings (1 critical, 3 high); fixes in migration 050, not yet run	docs/secure/Platform Security Review.html
Platform maturity average	1.16 / 5 (design-stage)	docs/strategy/SEMESTER_PLATFORM_MATURITY_SCORECARD.md
Company OS functions; launch gates; cutover steps	15; 11; 11 (C1 to C11)	docs/business/COMPANY_OPERATING_SYSTEM.md; docs/launch/
Design catalogue breadth	64 student destinations; 673 screens; 51 roles	README.md; NEXT-SESSION.md
Design system components	49 (Operating Manual) vs 57 (NEXT-SESSION.md): sources differ	ui_kits/business/Operating Manual.html; NEXT-SESSION.md

How the company works

Operating system and cadence

The Company OS (dated 2026-10-05) covers 15 functions: governance and legal; finance and capital; product and engineering; trust (security, privacy, accessibility, compliance); revenue; marketing; customer success; support; partnerships; people; data and outcomes; vendors; risk and continuity; board and investors; and the operations command center. Every owner is the founder, sometimes paired with counsel, a bookkeeper or a fractional security lead. The principle: Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises institutions.

Everything is meant to run in Semester's own `/ops` console. Regulated systems stay external and embedded: bank, payment processor, payroll, the bookkeeper's ledger, e-signature, GitHub, Vercel and Supabase. The product database tracks quotes, orders, invoices and entitlements but is not the statutory ledger.

The cadence runs from daily operations triage to weekly reviews (revenue, product, customer success, security and reliability, marketing), monthly finance and trust reviews, and a quarterly OKR and board review. While solo, the weekly reviews collapse into one 60-minute operating review. The Operating Manual's week: Monday planning and pipeline review, Wednesday engineering review, Thursday pilot check-in with the champion, Friday metrics, cash and risks. Monthly there is a two-hour close with access and claims reviews; quarterly, a half-day reset and a tabletop exercise. Decisions are logged one per pull request in DECISIONS.md, yet the backlog still lists a company decisions log as a gap. The Master Backlog sorts functions P0 to P3 and adds a 90-day plan, a 12-month plan, a 36-month plan and a top-50 action list.

KPIs

The north star is students who complete their next action each week (pilot cohort). Seven branches sit beneath it: product (weekly actives, first meaningful action, readiness completion), revenue (pipeline, pilots, conversion, ARR, NRR), customer (activation, health, measures met), trust (controls with evidence, incidents), finance (cash, runway, margin, AI cost per workflow), reliability (SLO attainment, restore time) and people (capacity versus demand). The pilot one-pager names three example measures: students with no unresolved hold at registration time, advising appointments arriving with an agenda, and weekly active students completing a next action. Baselines and targets are "agreed at kickoff"; no source states them.

Finance and capital

Finance must answer cash and runway, committed versus collected revenue, per-customer profitability, the margin effect of AI and infrastructure, and what the company can afford next. The quote-to-cash flow runs quote, pricing-exception check, order form, invoice, reconciliation, entitlement, revenue-recognition review and renewal. Discounts need founder approval until a deal desk exists; credits and refunds need finance approval.

The Finance Model gives three setup scenarios, each with a 10% contingency; base is recommended. Line items are counsel review, cyber plus E&O premiums, accessibility testing, accounting setup, tools, hosting, AI usage and campus travel; a pen test appears only in the full scenario. The monthly run-rate is mostly insurance if paid monthly ($250), bookkeeping ($150) and AI usage ($50). The model assumes the pilot invoice is paid about three months after setup starts

and recommends asking for 50% at signature. Moving to Supabase Team for a vendor SOC 2 report would add about $574 a month. Fundraising is deferred until pilot results; an LLC-to-Delaware C-corp conversion is planned before any priced round. The documents flag that accounting, tax, legal and insurance content needs qualified professional review.

People and hiring

Only the founder exists today. Fractional counsel, an insurance broker and a bookkeeper (about two hours a month) are needed now, and an accessibility tester before launch. A founding full-stack engineer comes after the pilot fee arrives; an implementation and customer success lead after the second pilot; a fractional security lead after the first annual contract; an account executive and product designer after three annual contracts; a support specialist last. Six job descriptions and four contractor briefs are written. Every hire gets confidentiality and IP assignment before access, FERPA and security training, and least-privilege access reviewed quarterly. Twelve cultural standards include student agency over surveillance, evidence over hype, and every public claim has evidence. Gaps: handbook, equity plan, compensation bands.

Governance, legal and risk

No contract is signed without a template or counsel redline. Counsel is required for any contract with student data, liability above fees or non-standard indemnity. Draft MSA, Order Form, DPA, Terms, Privacy Policy, Cookie Notice, Accessibility Statement, Community Guidelines and Subprocessors exist, all awaiting attorney review. Gaps: SLA, SOW, security addendum, contractor templates, trademark filing and a policy register.

The Business Risk Register lists ten risks. Customer concentration (one pilot) and founder capacity are rated high on both likelihood and impact. The rest include pilot without insurance, runway shortfall, vendor breach, unsupported promises, accessibility complaints, prices too low to fund support and over-claiming. The key-person continuity plan is not yet written; the Security Policies describe a sealed emergency kit with a named backup contact. Every vendor needs a purpose, a review and an exit; reviews for Supabase, Vercel, the AI provider and the email provider are not yet recorded.

Go-to-market and revenue

Two engines: institutional (paid pilots, annual contracts, expansion, references) and student adoption (activation, retained use, institutional proof). The funnel has 15 stages with exit criteria, from Target to Closed lost. The GTM plan holds the ICP, six personas with promises and objections, a ten-line offer ladder, pipeline targets and a case-study plan: sign measures before launch, ask permission at the midpoint review, publish a two-page study within 30 days of results. Disqualifiers: no named champion, a need for SIS write-back during the pilot, or procurement over six months. Claim rule: say "in a paid pilot with one university" until there are more.

Market Research supports positioning, not forecasting. It names EAB Navigate360, Starfish, Civitas Learning and AI-native entrants, all with vendor-claimed scale, and positions Semester as complementing Navigate and Starfish on the staff side in year one rather than replacing them. Gaps: content calendar, SEO plan, account scoring, ROI calculator, battlecards, procurement FAQ, demo environment, win/loss log.

Customer success

Sales must hand off the signed scope, timeline, conversion date, sponsor, IT, security and procurement contacts, cohort, baseline and success criteria. A health score is proposed with example weights (student activation 20%, core workflow completion 20%, admin engagement 15%, first meaningful action 15%, and others), but its definition is a listed gap. The

strategy adds an implementation factory (tenant templates, LTI and OneRoster wizards, SSO/SCIM guide, reconciliation dashboard) promising launch in weeks, not years.

Partnerships

Partnerships are P3 and post-pilot. First partners are the pilot's own dependencies: SIS, LMS, identity provider and AI provider. Any data-sharing partner needs a DPA and review. The strategy sketches a developer platform, partner certification and a marketplace with governed installs.

Trust program

Trust is meant to be evidence-based: each control has an owner, policy, implementation, evidence, test and review date. A new subprocessor needs privacy review and 30 days' notice. The P0 next action is to bind insurance, submit HECVAT Full and complete vendor reviews. Security detail is in the operations section below.

Brand in brief

Positioning. The brand identity document says "Semester is the education operating system". The README and Operating Manual use "the student action platform" publicly. The sources do not reconcile this; the design system states it wins on conflicts. The intended student feeling is "I know what to do next."

Personality. Calm, not sterile; intelligent, not patronizing; ambitious, not inflated; academic, not bureaucratic; warm, not childish; human-centred, not surveillance-centred.

Voice rules, with the sources' examples.

- Use the status sentence: what is true, what it means for you, what you can do. "Your Canvas calendar hasn't updated since Tuesday. Deadlines below may have moved. Reconnect it, or check the course page."
- Prefer "helps you organise" to "revolutionises"; "alongside your school's systems" to "replaces" or "all-in-one"; "AI-assisted, source-linked" to "AI-powered" or "magic". Never claim "secure", "compliant" or "certified" without evidence.
- Say "student", not "user". Sentence case. No emoji, streaks, ranks, exclamation marks or confetti.
- State consequences before confirm: "You leave CHEM 101 and a W is recorded on your transcript. It cannot be undone here."
- Say what is safe in errors: "Your draft is safe on this device."
- Never call Semester the official gradebook, registrar or payment system. Label demo data "Sample".

Visual identity.

- *Colour.* Ink (#090a0e) for all chrome; Parchment (#f4f1ea) for content; Semester blue 700 (#416180) on light and 400 (#94bce3) on dark as the one action colour. Brass (#d8c79a) is editorial only; sterling (#d4d9e2) is the metal of the mark. Source hues are desaturated stones used as ink, hairline and 8% wash, never large fills.
- *Status glyphs.* ◆ official, ○ yours, ✦ AI, ⇄ connected or conflict, ? review, ! attention, ✓ done, ⊘ offline, … working, ◌ sample. Colour is never the only carrier.
- *Type.* Barlow body (16/1.55), Barlow Condensed 600 for headings and controls, Cinzel for rare editorial display and the wordmark, system mono for IDs. Tabular figures.
- *Shape and motion.* Corners 3/6/10 px; hairline first, shadow last. Motion 130 to 280 ms, zeroed by reduced-motion. No bounce, parallax or spinners.
- *Mark.* Three slabs on a 512 grid, shown as a lit silver mark on Ink. Never recolour it; in co-brand lockups Semester leads. No photography or AI imagery in-product. Icons: 108 glyphs, 1.5 px stroke.
- *Open decision.* The source PDF proposed indigo with emerald, amber and rose status hues; the design system kept blue and stone hues and flags this for the founder.

How Semester is operated

Support. Four tiers: self-help, the customer's own help channel (Vanderbilt's, named by its IT), Semester's support desk run by the founder, and vendors. Severities S1 to S4: S1 is possible student-data exposure; S2 is blocked (SSO down, SIS data wrong); S3 is degraded; S4 is a question. Targets are in the numbers table. Tickets never contain student record content; they use internal IDs. Reply macros cover sign-in, wrong-looking data, "Is AI reading my records?", not-in-pilot, known issues and accessibility barriers. Week-1 cover ends after no open S1 or S2, two days without a new S2, clean reconciliation and sponsor agreement.

On-call and SLOs. The founder is on-call lead until a first engineer joins. Escalation runs on-call, founder, vendor support, institution IT. More than two night pages in a week makes the next week reliability work. Error budget policy: above 50% remaining, normal releases; 0 to 50%, fixes only; exhausted, freeze and write a reliability plan. Ten alerts map to runbooks; for example, 5xx above 2% for 15 minutes is an S2 and rollback trigger, and an RLS-denial spike from one session is an S1.

Runbooks. Eight follow detect, stabilise, fix, verify, tell people, write it down: R1 bad release, R2 SSO outage, R3 SIS sync (mismatches are never auto-corrected; the registrar decides the right source), R4 backup and restore (to a scratch project first), R5 suspected exposure (cohort flag off first, preserve evidence, postmortem in 5 business days), R6 AI gateway, R7 capacity, R8 a student who cannot see data. Maintenance is weekly patching, a monthly restore drill, quarterly access review and tabletop, and yearly pen test, ACR re-test and HECVAT refresh.

Launch and cutover for the Vanderbilt pilot. All dates are relative to launch day (L). Eleven go/no-go gates must be green with evidence: DPA signed (L-45), HECVAT accepted, insurance bound and ACR delivered (L-30), SSO in staging (L-21), SIS reconciliation at zero unexplained mismatches, RLS tests and AI-gateway red-team (L-14), restore drill (L-10), incident contacts and signed success measures (L-7). Final go/no-go and code freeze at L-3. The cutover plan has eleven steps: production migrations and RLS tests, secrets, Vanderbilt's SAML service provider, institution configuration, first SIS sync, a registrar spot-check of 25 students, DNS and TLS, baseline backup, staff accounts, fresh sync, and finally the student cohort flag. Each step has a check and an undo. There is no point of no return: until the cohort flag is on students see nothing, and afterwards it turns everything off in under a minute without deleting data. Rollback triggers: suspected exposure, SSO down over 30 minutes, SIS data shown wrongly, error rate above 2% for 15 minutes. Welcome messages come from Vanderbilt; nothing is public until both sides approve.

Security readiness. The policy set (v0.1 draft) has ten policies: access, encryption, AI and student data, vendors, incident response, BCP/DR, retention, secure development, devices and logging. Key commitments: MFA on every company account, RLS on every student-data table tested in CI, an AI gateway that blocks student-record fields before any model call, and deletion within 30 days of contract end. The readiness tracker holds draft HECVAT Full answers across 14 sections (mostly in progress), a SOC 2 table (Type I planned after the pilot), a staging-only pen-test scope and an insurance checklist (cyber, E&O, general liability, certificate; all not started). The platform security review found 11 issues, including a critical one letting a tenant user insert themselves as an ops role. Fixes are written but unrun and need a qualified security engineer.

Compliance. Stated status: HECVAT Full in progress, SOC 2 not started, no pen test, insurance not bound, VPAT/ACR in preparation. The DPA draft makes Semester a FERPA "school official" with no sale, advertising, profiling or AI training on institution data.

Open decisions and risks

Gating items before real student records. Insurance is "not started" in the Operating Pack, readiness tracker and MSA draft, yet the pilot requires it. The DPA is "in review". HECVAT Full, SAML SSO and the VPAT/ACR are open. Also open: EIN and tax registrations, business bank account, accounting setup, subprocessor list, retention schedule, a tested AI boundary, data inventory and a tested restore.

Decisions not yet made.

- Pilot start and renewal dates, to be fixed in a mutual action plan.
- Pilot measures, baselines and targets, signed before launch.
- The Vanderbilt fee and invoice schedule (the Order Form offers 100% at signature, or 50% and 50%).
- Raise versus bootstrap, and C-corp conversion.
- Brand hues (blue and stone versus the PDF's indigo set).
- Whether to fund the pen test.
- When to publish prices, which wait for pilot results and counsel review.

Top risks. Customer concentration, founder capacity, runway before the pilot invoice, pilot without insurance, HECVAT delay, SSO readiness, student-record exposure (low likelihood, critical impact), VPAT gaps, a pilot drifting without a decision date, claims outrunning evidence, and prices too low to fund support. The Platform Risk Register adds cross-tenant exposure, AI receiving records and SIS data shown wrongly.

Gaps from audits and backlogs. The completion audit's top 25 include no production code for pilot paths, RLS untested, no monitoring, SIS connector unbuilt, AI red-team not run, no status page, no policy engine, no usability test, no 36-month model, no help centre, no event taxonomy and no decision log. The gap register lists 84 workflow steps without a screen. No maturity dimension scores above 2 of 5; developer ecosystem and global readiness score 0.

Where the sources disagree.

- *Accessibility standard.* The Operating Pack targets WCAG 2.1 AA for the ACR; the README, Accessibility Statement, MSA and GTM plan say 2.2 AA.
- *Launch blockers.* The Operating Pack's six differ from the launch kit's Command Center six (HECVAT, data agreement, SSO, accessibility, insurance as one item, and an incident plan).
- *Severity targets.* The Operating Manual uses P0 to P3 with 1 h, 4 h, 1 day and 2 day targets; the Support Plan uses S1 to S4 with 15 min, 30 min, 1 h and same day.
- *Restore drills.* Monthly in the Operations Handbook; quarterly in the Security Policies.
- *Breach notice.* 24 hours in Security Policies; a bracketed 72 hours in the DPA template.
- *Drafts versus "not started".* The Operating Pack lists the subprocessor list and a 12-month model as not started, though drafts exist in docs/legal and docs/run.
- *Pen-test timing.* After first renewal (Operating Pack) versus before the pilot goes broad (Security Policies).
- *First engineer.* After the pilot fee (Hiring Plan) versus after the second paid customer (Operating Manual).
- *Insurance risk.* Medium likelihood (Business Risk Register) versus High (Operating Pack).
- *Pilot term.* The Vanderbilt one-pager says "Fall 2026"; other documents say dates are not set.

- *Counts.* 49 versus 57 components.

Reader's guide

- **The company operating system.** The 15-function Company OS, systems of record, KPI tree, cadence, master backlog and top-50 actions.
- **Go-to-market, revenue and marketing.** Revenue operations, funnel stages, CRM fields, sales assets and the marketing and brand system.
- **GTM plan and price book.** ICP, personas, offer ladder, discount rules, pipeline targets, channels, case-study plan and claim rules.
- **Market and competitor research.** Enrollment base, sizing arithmetic, competitor landscape and positioning, with sources.
- **Finance and capital.** Finance questions, console, revenue streams, quote-to-cash, controls, KPIs and monthly close.
- **Finance model.** Setup scenarios, run-rate, revenue scenarios, runway, sourced vendor prices and unit economics.
- **People and hiring.** Org design, hiring sequence, cultural standards and the people system card.
- **Hiring plan.** Trigger-based plan, hiring process, six job descriptions and contractor briefs.
- **Governance, legal, risk and vendors.** Governance and legal operations, the business risk register, continuity, vendors and the trust program card.
- **Strategy.** Completion audit, maturity scorecard, moats, 36-month plan, AI and trust plans, implementation and migration factories, outcome proof.
- **Operating manual.** "How to run Semester": the company function by function, with cadence and scorecard.
- **Company operating pack.** The pre-records checklist: open P0 gaps, 56-item checklist, 90-day roadmap, pilot checklist, risks.
- **The decks.** Deck templates named in the README. Their slide text was not reviewed for this overview.
- **Company workspaces.** The business workspace, twelve role-gated `/ops` consoles and staff workspaces, all labelled sample data. The staff workspaces page is script-rendered and was not read as text.
- **Legal documents.** Draft MSA, Order Form, DPA, Terms, Privacy Policy, Cookie Notice, Accessibility Statement, Community Guidelines, Subprocessors.
- **Brand chapters.** Content fundamentals, visual foundations, iconography, brand identity, visual language and the launch kit.
- **Operating chapters.** Operations Handbook, Runbooks, launch runbook, cutover plan, support plan, security policies, readiness tracker and security review.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Semester	The student action platform; company and product.
Student OS	Internal name; avoided publicly because it implies replacing school systems.
Ask Semester	The AI assistant; no human persona, always labelled AI-assisted, never receives student records.
Today	The student home destination; the spine is Today, My Path, Search, Plan, Me.
Status sentence	Voice unit: what is true, what it means, what you can do.
Provenance labels	Source vocabulary: official, connected, yours, AI-assisted, estimated.
Registration Readiness Pilot	Wedge offer: one term, one cohort, named measures, SSO, read-only SIS sync.
Success measures sheet	One-page signed baseline and target for each pilot measure.
Mutual action plan	Shared plan with a named economic buyer and decision date.
Champion	Institution person who owns the outcome and runs the pilot.
Economic buyer	Person who can fund the pilot (VP Student Success, provost office, CIO).
ICP	Ideal customer profile: four-year university, 5,000 to 30,000 students.
Price book	The GTM plan's offer ladder and discount rules; planning prices only.
Floor	Minimum price ($30,000 platform; $15,000 premium support).
ACV / NRR	Annual contract value; net revenue retention.
Claims register	Register where every public claim or number needs a source.
Status, not certifications	Rule to state control status, never a certification not held.
Company OS	The 15-function operating system for the company.
/ops	Semester's operations console, intended to run the company.
System of record	The authoritative system for a domain.
SIS / LMS	Student information system / learning management system.
LTI 1.3 / OneRoster	Interoperability standards for LMS connection and roster import.
IdP / SAML SSO	Identity provider / single sign-on required by the pilot.
RLS	Postgres row-level security, used for tenant isolation.
Tenant	One institution's isolated slice of the platform.
AI gateway	Server component that scopes, scans, routes, logs and blocks student-record fields.
Policy engine	Deterministic rules component: the AI explains a rule, the engine decides it.
HECVAT	Higher-education vendor security questionnaire; Full required by the pilot.
VPAT / ACR	Accessibility conformance template / completed report.
DPA / FERPA addendum	Data protection terms making Semester a "school official".
E&O	Errors and omissions (technology professional liability) insurance.
Go/no-go gate	Evidence-backed readiness check required before launch.
Launch day (L)	Reference for relative dates, as actual pilot dates are unset.

Term	Meaning
Cohort flag	Feature switch turning the pilot cohort on or off in under a minute.
Cutover (C1 to C11)	Eleven-step production move, each with a check and undo.
Reconciliation	Comparing synced data with the registrar extract; goal zero unexplained mismatches.
SLO / error budget	Service target and allowed failure that drives release policy.
S1 to S4 / P0 to P3	Incident severities / backlog priorities.
Implementation factory	Planned repeatable path from sales hand-off to launch.
Migration factory	Planned reusable migration product; replacement only with reconciliation evidence.
Health score	Proposed customer health metric; definition still open.
Ink / Parchment	Near-black chrome ground / warm off-white content ground.
Semester blue	The single action colour (#416180 light, #94bce3 dark).
Sample data	Figures labelled illustrative, not real company or student data.

PART 1

Company

What Semester is, who it serves, how the company is run, financed, staffed and governed — and the strategy for winning.

Semester at a glance

Semester is the native Student Operating System for the complete educational journey — one governed, accessible platform for a student's academic, personal, campus, financial, career and lifelong life, plus the institutional workspaces (faculty, advisor, registrar, finance, IT/security) that serve them. Surfaces include Student Today, Calendar, Tasks, Courses, Study, Write, Degree, Registration, Grades, Campus, Dining, Housing, Family, Career, Billing, Support, the AI Assistant, and the Institution Console.

The system is calm, scholarly and source-aware: near-black chrome, warm off-white content, restrained Semester blue for action and focus, and a controlled vocabulary that keeps **official, connected, personal and AI-generated** information visibly distinct.

Status (Oct 2026): pre-seed, founder-led, bootstrapped; first paid pilot signed with Vanderbilt University (dates not set). HECVAT Full, VPAT/ACR, SAML SSO and insurance are in progress. Large figures anywhere in this system are labelled sample data.

Sources

- **Codebase (ground truth):** https://github.com/harrisonjrubin7-cmyk/semester (branch `main`). Key files read: `DESIGN-SYSTEM-GUIDE.md`, `docs/COLOR-AND-DARK-MODE-SPEC.md`, `app/src/styles/{tokens,typefaces,industry,unity}.css`, `app/src/lib/{look,status,source}.ts`, `app/src/components/{Brand,Icons,icons.data,mark.data,SourceBadge,StatusNotice,StartToday}.tsx`, `app/src/components/unity/*`, `app/src/components/console/*`. Also read: `docs/BRAND-PLATFORM.md` (voice, naming, Source Line), `enrollment/StudentRegistration.tsx`, `gradebook/StudentGrades.tsx`, `AdvisorMeeting.tsx`. Explore the repo further — especially `docs/design/`, `company-site/` and `app/src/components/` — to build closer to the real product.
- **Uploads:** `uploads/download-1.png` (lit silver logo mark on Ink), `uploads/Semester build Architecture.pdf`, `uploads/audit [...].pdf/.md` (repo audit).
- **Brief:** the user's written design direction (source-status hues, Semester blue, warm off-white content). Where it diverges from the code it is noted below.

Reconciling brief and code

The app's own rule is "one colour for attention, the rest in words and glyphs", with a sterling/brass metal accent. The brief asks for a Semester blue action colour and distinct source hues. This system **keeps the code's grounds, type, radii, motion, glyph+word status vocabulary and contrast floors**, and **adopts the brief's palette** using hues pulled from the code's own measured ramps (Industry blue → Semester blue; Jade/Moss/Indigo/Old gold → teal/green/violet/amber). Every chip still carries a glyph and a word; colour is never the only carrier.



The system cover

The company operating system

docs/business/README.md

docs/business

Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

- CORPORATE_GOVERNANCE_AND_LEGAL_OPS.md
- FINANCE_AND_CAPITAL_SYSTEM.md
- PRODUCT_AND_ENGINEERING_OPERATIONS.md
- TRUST_PROGRAM.md
- REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md
- MARKETING_AND_BRAND_SYSTEM.md
- CUSTOMER_SUCCESS_AND_IMPLEMENTATION.md
- SUPPORT_AND_SERVICE_OPERATIONS.md
- PARTNERSHIPS_AND_MARKETPLACE.md
- PEOPLE_AND_HIRING_SYSTEM.md
- DATA_RESEARCH_AND_OUTCOMES.md
- VENDOR_AND_PROCUREMENT_SYSTEM.md
- RISK_RESILIENCE_AND_CONTINUITY.md
- BOARD_AND_INVESTOR_OPERATIONS.md
- OPERATIONS_COMMAND_CENTER.md
- COMPANY_OPERATING_SYSTEM.md
- GTM_AND_SALES_SYSTEM.md
- COMPANY_KPI_TREE.md
- COMPANY_OPERATING_CADENCE.md
- BUSINESS_MASTER_BACKLOG.md

Five connected systems

- finance/FINANCE_AND_ACCOUNTING_OPERATIONS.md
- revenue/GTM_AND_REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md
- trust/SECURITY_PRIVACY_ACCESSIBILITY_COMPLIANCE.md
- customer/CUSTOMER_SUCCESS_AND_IMPLEMENTATION.md
- people/PEOPLE_HIRING_AND_CULTURE.md
- BUSINESS_SYSTEMS_OF_RECORD.md
- BUSINESS_RISK_REGISTER.md

Interactive: ui_kits/company-os/index.html

Company operating system

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Function	Owner	System of record	Priority	Next action	Doc
Corporate governance and legal	Founder + fractional counsel	Contracts register in /ops legal; corporate records folder	P0	Counsel review of MSA, DPA and order form before pilot launch	CORPORATE_GOVERNANCE_AND_LEGAL_OPS.md
Finance, accounting and capital	Founder + bookkeeper	/ops finance (invoices, AR, dunning); accounting ledger (bookkeeper); bank	P0	Open business bank account and accounting ledger; set the monthly close date	FINANCE_AND_CAPITAL_SYSTEM.md
Product and engineering operations	Founder → founding engineer	GitHub (code, PRs), /ops product operations (backlog, flags, releases)	P1	Run execute stream 00 and approve the design-system baseline	PRODUCT_AND_ENGINEERING_OPERATIONS.md
Security, privacy, accessibility and compliance	Founder + fractional security lead	/ops trust & compliance (controls, evidence, HECVAT, data requests)	P0	Bind insurance; submit HECVAT Full; complete vendor reviews for Supabase, Vercel, AI provider	TRUST_PROGRAM.md
Go-to-market and revenue operations	Founder	/ops GTM pipeline (CRM)	P1	Build the 40-account target list in /ops	REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md
Marketing, brand and communications	Founder	Company site + content register; /ops social	P2	Publish pilot, pricing and trust pages	MARKETING_AND_BRAND_SYSTEM.md
Customer success and implementation	Founder → implementation lead	/ops customer success (implementation, health, QBR)	P0	Kick off Vanderbilt implementation with the mutual action plan	CUSTOMER_SUCCESS_AND_IMPLEMENTATION.md
Support and service operations	Founder → support specialist	/ops support desk	P1	Write the first 10 KB articles from the pilot paths	SUPPORT_AND_SERVICE_OPERATIONS.md
Partnerships, marketplace and developer relations	Founder	/ops partnerships	P3	List the integration partners the pilot depends on (SIS, LMS, IdP, AI provider)	PARTNERSHIPS_AND_MARKETPLACE.md
People, hiring and culture	Founder	/ops people (hiring, onboarding); payroll provider (embedded)	P2	Engage counsel and bookkeeper as the first contractors	PEOPLE_AND_HIRING_SYSTEM.md
Data, research and outcomes	Founder	Analytics (aggregate), research repository	P1	Define the pilot event taxonomy (no PII)	DATA_RESEARCH_AND_OUTCOMES.md
Procurement, vendors and supply chain	Founder	/ops vendors	P1	Record reviews for Supabase, Vercel, AI provider, email provider	VENDOR_AND_PROCUREMENT_SYSTEM.md
Risk, resilience and continuity	Founder	/ops risk register, incidents, SLOs	P1	Write the key-person continuity plan (credentials escrow, runbooks, counsel contact)	RISK_RESILIENCE_AND_CONTINUITY.md
Board, investor and stakeholder operations	Founder	/ops board/investor reports; investor portal	P3	Draft the data room index (deferred)	BOARD_AND_INVESTOR_OPERATIONS.md
Operations command center	Founder	/ops	P1	Start the weekly operating review from the executive overview	OPERATIONS_COMMAND_CENTER.md

Systems-of-record map

Everything runs in Semester's /ops console (see ui_kits/one-place). Regulated systems stay external and embedded: bank, payment processor, payroll, accounting ledger (bookkeeper), e-sign provider, GitHub, Vercel, Supabase.

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docs/business/COMPANY_OPERATING_CADENCE.md

Company operating cadence

Semester business operations · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/Show the finance and accounting operations section.pdf. ***Accounting, tax, legal, insurance, privacy, security, accessibility and compliance content needs qualified professional review before use.***

> Every customer promise connects to a financial owner, delivery owner, support process, security/privacy control, product capability and evidence trail.

Cadence	Review	Required output
Daily	Operations triage	P0/P1 issues, customer blockers, incident decisions
Weekly	Revenue	Pipeline, deals, pilots, forecast, next steps
Weekly	Product/engineering	Releases, quality, tech debt, feedback
Weekly	Customer success	Adoption, support, health, renewal risk
Weekly	Security/reliability	Vulnerabilities, incidents, SLOs, access, changes
Weekly	Marketing/growth	Funnel, content, campaigns, activation
Monthly	Finance	P&L, cash, burn, runway, variance, collections
Monthly	Trust/compliance	Evidence, reviews, vendor risk, HECVAT, privacy
Monthly	Leadership	KPIs, decisions, hiring, risks
Quarterly	OKR/board	Strategy, roadmap, capital, performance, risk, priorities

While solo, the weekly reviews run as one 60-minute operating review with five sections.

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docs/business/COMPANY_KPI_TREE.md

Company KPI tree

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

North star: students who complete their next action each week (pilot cohort)

- Product
- Weekly actives
- First meaningful action
- Readiness completion
- Support load

- Revenue
- Pipeline
- Pilots signed
- Pilot-to-annual conversion
- ARR
- NRR
- Customer
- Activation
- Health
- Measures met
- References
- Trust
- Controls with evidence
- Incidents
- Questionnaire turnaround
- Finance
- Cash
- Runway
- Gross margin
- AI cost per workflow
- Reliability
- SLO attainment
- Error budget
- Restore time
- People
- Capacity vs demand
- Hires on trigger

`docs/business/BUSINESS_SYSTEMS_OF_RECORD.md`

Business systems of record

Semester business operations · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/Show the finance and accounting operations section.pdf.
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> Every customer promise connects to a financial owner, delivery owner, support process, security/privacy control, product capability and evidence trail.

Domain	System of record	Shown in Semester
CRM, pipeline, quotes	/ops GTM	Native
Contracts and obligations	/ops legal register	Native; e-sign embedded
Invoices, subscriptions, entitlements, dunning	/ops finance	Native

Domain	System of record	Shown in Semester
Statutory ledger	Accounting software (accountant-designed)	Embedded view
Bank and payments	Bank + payment processor	Embedded balances and payouts
Payroll	Payroll provider	Embedded status
Support tickets	/ops support desk	Native
Incidents, SLOs, status	/ops incidents + status page	Native
Controls and evidence	/ops trust & compliance	Native, links to GitHub/Supabase/Vercel
Code, CI, deploys	GitHub + Vercel	Embedded status
Database	Supabase	Embedded health
Hiring and onboarding	/ops people	Native
Docs, sheets, decks	Semester Write/Sheets/Decks	Native

`docs/business/OPERATIONS_COMMAND_CENTER.md`

Operations command center

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Field	Value
Mission	Run the platform and the company from one place.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Every function above
System of record	/ops
KPIs	Decisions with owner and date; Approvals in SLA
Reports	Executive overview
Meeting cadence	Daily glance; weekly operating review
Risk controls	Business data only; two-person approvals
Approval thresholds	See approvals matrix
Required documents	Operating manual
Required integrations	All company modules
Current status	ui_kits/ops/ (12 consoles), templates/command-center/, ui_kits/one-place/
Gaps	Decisions log, work items
Priority	P1
Next action	Start the weekly operating review from the executive overview

Workflows

- Request → evidence → approval → impact preview → execution → audit → read-model refresh → operator review

Go-to-market, revenue and marketing

docs/business/GTM_AND_SALES_SYSTEM.md

GTM and sales system

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

See REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md and docs/grow/GTM Plan.html for ICP, personas, offers, prices and pipeline targets.

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docs/business/revenue/GTM_AND_REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md

GTM and revenue operations

Semester business operations · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/Show the finance and accounting operations section.pdf.
Accounting, tax, legal, insurance, privacy, security, accessibility and compliance content needs qualified professional review before use.

> Every customer promise connects to a financial owner, delivery owner, support process, security/privacy control, product capability and evidence trail.

Two engines: **institutional** (paid pilots → annual contracts → expansion → references) and **student adoption** (value → activation → retained use → institutional proof → referrals).

Funnel

Target accounts → researched → personalized outreach → replies/referrals → discovery → qualified → role demos → pilot design → security/privacy/procurement → pilot proposal → paid pilot signed → implementation → activation → measured success → annual conversion → expansion/renewal/reference.

CRM data

Account: name, segment, enrollment range, system type, geography, tech stack, priority score, trigger event, champion, economic buyer, technical buyer, security reviewer, procurement contact, stage, estimated ACV, pilot value, annual potential, probability, close date, risks, next step, owner.

Opportunity: problem, current workflow, scope, cohort, buyer goals, baseline and success metrics, security requirements, integration needs, terms, mutual action plan, decision process, competitors, objections, win/loss reason.

Stages and exit criteria

Stage	Exit criteria
Target	Account researched and scored
Contacted	Relevant stakeholder reached with a personalized message
Discovery	Pain, champion, timeline and buyer path documented
Qualified	Problem, budget path, decision process, feasibility confirmed
Demo	Use case shown to required stakeholders
Pilot design	Cohort, scope, baseline, success criteria agreed
Procurement/security	Review owners, artifacts, decision path identified
Proposal	Price, terms, conversion path, decision date delivered
Contracting	Legal/procurement reviewing
Closed won: pilot	Executed; kickoff scheduled
Pilot active	Cohort launched; metrics measured
Conversion	Annual decision in process
Closed won: annual	Annual agreement active
Expansion	New campus, department, module or users identified
Closed lost	Reason, competitor, re-engagement path recorded

Sales assets

ICP, persona library, account scoring, discovery script, qualification scorecard, demo script and environment, pilot design agenda, proposal, mutual action plan, ROI and pricing calculators, quote template, order-form intake, security overview, HECVAT roadmap, DPA/SLA process, accessibility response, procurement FAQ, battlecards, objection library, case-study template, reference guide, renewal/expansion deck.

Have: GTM plan, personas, objections, mutual action plan, sales process (ui_kits/business), order form, decks (templates/).
Gaps: account scoring model, ROI calculator, battlecards, procurement FAQ, demo environment.

Marketing and lifecycle

Site (home, product, pilot, pricing, demo request, Trust Center, resources, SEO pages, case studies, contact); content (LinkedIn, YouTube, webinars, newsletter, guides, research, founder, student, partner); lifecycle (nurture, demo and webinar follow-up, pilot nurture, onboarding, student activation, retention, renewal, referral).

`docs/business/REVENUE_OPERATIONS.md`

Go-to-market and revenue operations

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Field	Value
Mission	A predictable path from target account to annual contract.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	ICP, target list, conversations, pilot results
System of record	/ops GTM pipeline (CRM)
KPIs	Target accounts, replies, discovery meetings; Qualified opportunities, demos, pilot designs; Pilots signed, activation, KPI attainment; Pilot-to-annual conversion, ACV, NRR; Sales cycle, win/loss, CAC, payback
Reports	Weekly pipeline; monthly forecast
Meeting cadence	Weekly pipeline review
Risk controls	Price book and discount rules; claims register for every deck
Approval thresholds	Below floor not allowed; discounts per GTM plan
Required documents	GTM plan, Buyer map, Mutual action plan, Proposal template, Order form
Required integrations	Email and calendar inside Semester
Current status	docs/grow/GTM Plan.html, ui_kits/business (GTM), templates (decks)
Gaps	Target list built, win/loss log
Priority	P1
Next action	Build the 40-account target list in /ops

Workflows

- Target → outreach → discovery → qualified → role demo → pilot design → security/procurement → proposal → mutual action plan → contract → implementation → activation → outcome report → annual conversion → expansion/reference

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`docs/business/MARKETING_AND_BRAND_SYSTEM.md`

Marketing, brand and communications

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Field	Value
Mission	Explain Semester honestly and earn buyer and student trust.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Positioning, proof, product releases

Field	Value
System of record	Company site + content register; /ops social
KPIs	Qualified site requests; Trust Center visits; Content published per month; Ambassador activations (later)
Reports	Monthly marketing summary
Meeting cadence	Monthly content plan
Risk controls	Every claim sourced in the claims register; status, not certifications
Approval thresholds	Customer names or quotes → written approval
Required documents	Brand system, Messaging, Claims register, Content calendar
Required integrations	Site CMS, social channels (embedded scheduling)
Current status	ui_kits/company-site/ (10 pages), design system, ui_kits/ops (social, marketing)
Gaps	Content calendar, SEO plan, webinar plan
Priority	P2
Next action	Publish pilot, pricing and trust pages

Workflows

- Plan → draft → claims check → approve → publish → measure

`docs/business/PARTNERSHIPS_AND_MARKETPLACE.md`

Partnerships, marketplace and developer relations

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Requires qualified professional review before use.

Field	Value
Mission	Borrow trust and distribution; let others build on Semester safely.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Partner targets, integration needs
System of record	/ops partnerships
KPIs	Active partners; Certified integrations; Partner-sourced pipeline
Reports	Quarterly partner review
Meeting cadence	Quarterly
Risk controls	Security/privacy approval before any data access
Approval thresholds	Any data-sharing partner → DPA + review
Required documents	Partner agreement, Publisher agreement, Certification checklist
Required integrations	Developer platform (later)

Field	Value
Current status	ui_kits/workflow-runner (Developer platform workflow)
Gaps	Partner list, agreements
Priority	P3
Next action	List the integration partners the pilot depends on (SIS, LMS, IdP, AI provider)

Workflows

- Target → qualify → due diligence → value proposition → agreement → technical integration → security/privacy approval → GTM plan → launch → measure → co-sell → renew → offboard

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`docs/business/CUSTOMER_SUCCESS_AND_IMPLEMENTATION.md`

Customer success and implementation

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Field	Value
Mission	Every customer launches cleanly and can prove value.
Owner	Founder → implementation lead
Inputs	Signed order form, measures sheet, contacts
System of record	/ops customer success (implementation, health, QBR)
KPIs	Days signature-to-launch; Activation; Health score; Renewal rate
Reports	Weekly sponsor update; results report
Meeting cadence	Weekly during pilot; quarterly QBR after
Risk controls	Go/no-go gates with evidence
Approval thresholds	Scope change → order form amendment
Required documents	Launch runbook, Cutover plan, Support plan, Results report template
Required integrations	Tenant health from the platform
Current status	docs/launch/, templates/pilot-results-report/
Gaps	Health score definition, customer advisory board
Priority	P0
Next action	Kick off Vanderbilt implementation with the mutual action plan

Workflows

- Signed → sales-to-CS hand-off → kickoff → implementation → data readiness → admin setup → training → launch → activation → adoption → weekly review → midpoint → value report → conversion → QBR → renewal → expansion → reference

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`docs/business/customer/CUSTOMER_SUCCESS_AND_IMPLEMENTATION.md`

Customer success and implementation

Semester business operations · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/Show the finance and accounting operations section.pdf. ***Accounting, tax, legal, insurance, privacy, security, accessibility and compliance content needs qualified professional review before use.***

> Every customer promise connects to a financial owner, delivery owner, support process, security/privacy control, product capability and evidence trail.

Sales-to-CS hand-off (sales must deliver)

Signed agreement, commercial and implementation scope, pilot timeline, conversion date, executive sponsor, compliance evidence record, economic buyer, champion, IT contact, security/privacy/procurement contacts, cohort, workflow, baseline, success criteria, promised integrations, data categories, known risks, commitments on both sides, decision process.

Implementation workspace

Project plan, RACI, milestones, dependencies, data and integration readiness, tenant and role setup, training, launch communications, risk register, issue tracker, status report, acceptance testing, go-live gate, transition to success.

Customer health score (example weights)

Signal	Weight
Admin engagement	15%
Student/user activation	20%
First meaningful action	15%
Core workflow completion	20%
Weekly active use	10%
Support sentiment	5%
Executive engagement	5%
Pilot/renewal outcome trend	10%

Assets

Welcome sequence, kickoff deck, implementation plan, RACI, data readiness checklist, admin setup guide, training curriculum, office hours, student launch kit, support policy, escalation matrix, weekly pilot report, midpoint review, final value report, QBR, renewal and expansion plans, churn playbook, case-study consent, reference process, advisory board charter.

Have: docs/launch/ (runbook, cutover, support plan), templates/pilot-results-report/, role onboarding templates. **Gaps:** RACI, kickoff deck, data readiness checklist, admin setup guide, health score in /ops.

SEMESTER

Go-to-market plan and price book

Owner: founder. Status: draft, October 2026. Prices are planning assumptions, not published prices, until the pilot results and counsel review are in. External numbers come from Market Research, where each is sourced.

Strategy in one line: universities first, through one paid one-term pilot per institution, with named success measures and a renewal decision date. Vanderbilt is pilot #1; its results become the case study that sells pilot #2–#5.

1. Ideal customer profile

Attribute	Fit	Why
Institution type	Four-year university, 5,000–30,000 students	Public four-year schools are the largest class (~7.9 M students, Market Research §1); research universities have the registration complexity Semester solves
Pain	Students surprised by holds, missed registration steps, advisors overloaded	The Registration Readiness Pilot targets exactly this
Champion	AVP / Director of Student Success, Advising or Registrar	Owns the outcome and can run a one-term pilot
Economic buyer	VP Student Success, Provost office or CIO	Can fund a pilot from discretionary budget
Systems	SIS with a read API or extract; SAML IdP; LMS with LTI 1.3	Read-only connection is enough for the pilot
Disqualifiers	No named champion; needs write-back to SIS in the pilot; procurement over 6 months for a pilot	Too slow for a solo founder

2. Personas and promises

Persona	Cares about	Promise	Top objection → answer
VP Student Success	Retention, on-time progress	Fewer students surprised by holds and deadlines	More advisor work? → Advisors see only what students share; no new queue
Registrar	Accurate records	Students arrive at registration ready	Changes records? → Read-only; your SIS stays authoritative
CIO / IT	Security, integration load	One governed integration, SSO, audit	Another system to secure? → HECVAT Full, SAML SSO, tenant isolation, subprocessor list

Persona	Cares about	Promise	Top objection → answer
Accessibility office	WCAG 2.2 AA	Accessible by design, ACR provided	VPAT? → ACR in preparation; test protocol shared
Procurement / counsel	Risk and terms	Standard DPA/FERPA, insurance, SLA	FERPA and AI? → Student records never reach an AI provider
Students	What do I do next?	One clear next step, with its source	Tracking me? → You decide what is shared; export or delete any time

3. Offer ladder

Offer	What it is	Price (planning)	Commitment
Student workspace	Planning workspace, Today, sharing	Free to students	None
Student Premium	Optional extras for individual students	$8.99 / month or $69 / year	Monthly or annual
Registration Readiness Pilot	One term, one cohort, named measures, SSO, read-only SIS sync	Fixed fee, quoted per pilot; credited against year 1 if converting within 60 days of results	One term
Department	One school or department, advisor workflows	$18 per enrolled student per year, floor $30,000	Annual
Institution	Whole campus, console, integrations, SSO	$18 per enrolled student per year, floor $30,000	Annual, 1–3 years
Enterprise / multi-campus	Advanced controls, multiple tenants	Quoted	Multi-year
Premium support	Named contact, faster response, quarterly reviews	15% of platform fee, floor $15,000	Annual add-on
Implementation	SSO, SIS/LMS connection, training	$35,000–$150,000 one-time by scope; waived or credited for early pilots	One-time
AI overage	Governed AI requests above the plan allowance	$30 per 1,000 requests	Usage
Marketplace commission	Partner apps sold through Semester (later)	12%, separate from core viability	Per transaction

The $18 per student and the floors are planning assumptions from the GTM playbook. Third-party estimates of incumbent student-success platforms run $50,000–$300,000 a year (Market Research §3, indicative only), so the floor sits at the low end on purpose.

4. Discount and approval rules

Lever	Allowed	Approval
Multi-year (2–3 years)	Up to 10% per year committed	Founder
Early conversion (signed within 60 days of results)	Pilot fee credited	Pre-approved
Reference + case study	Up to 5%	Founder; written reference agreement
Below floor	Not allowed	—
Free pilot	Not allowed: paid pilots qualify buyers	—

5. Pipeline and targets (first 12 months)

Stage	Exit criteria	Target
Target list	Tier-1 list of named institutions with a named champion	40 accounts
Discovery	Pain, owner, budget, timeline confirmed	15
Demo	Role-specific demo of the exact workflow	10
Pilot design	Measures, scope and data agreed	6
Security / legal	HECVAT, DPA, ACR path agreed	5
Pilot signed	Order form signed	3 (including Vanderbilt)
Annual conversion	Results report, annual order form	2

Targets are founder planning numbers, sized to one person doing sales alongside delivery. Revisit after Vanderbilt’s midpoint review.

6. Channels

Channel	Use	Cost
Founder outbound	Named champions at tier-1 accounts, referencing the pilot	Time only
Warm intros	Vanderbilt sponsor references (after results, with permission)	Time only
Conferences	Attend one student-success or registrar conference in year 1; no booth	Registration + travel, within setup budget
Company site	Pilot page, Trust Center, pricing, request-a-pilot form	Hosting only
Content	One article a month from real pilot learning; no claims we can’t prove	Time only

7. Case study plan (from the pilot)

Step	When	Output
Agree measures and baseline	Before launch (runbook gate)	Signed measures sheet
Ask for case-study permission in writing	At midpoint review	Signed permission, wording approval rights for Vanderbilt
Results report	End of term	templates/pilot-results-report
Case study	Within 30 days of results	Two-page PDF and site page, approved by Vanderbilt
Reference call	After case study	Sponsor agrees to two calls a quarter

8. 90-day GTM plan

Days	Do
1–30	Finish pilot launch blockers; build the tier-1 list (40); write the price book into the order-form template
31–60	Ten discovery calls; three demos; publish pilot and pricing pages on the site
61–90	Two pilot designs in security/legal review; midpoint review at Vanderbilt; ask for case-study permission

9. Metrics

Metric	Definition
Qualified pipeline	Accounts past discovery with champion and buyer named
Pilot KPI attainment	Share of agreed measures met at end of term
Pilot-to-annual conversion	Pilots that sign annual within 90 days of results
Sales cycle	First call to signed pilot, in days
Net revenue retention	Year-2 revenue from year-1 customers ÷ year-1 revenue

10. Claim rules

Say “in a paid pilot with one university” until there are more. State status, not certifications we don’t hold (no “SOC 2 compliant”, no “FERPA certified”). Every number on the site or in a deck needs a source in the public claims register.

SEMESTER · RESEARCH · 5 OCT 2026

Market and competitor research

Web research for the company deck’s market slide and for sales positioning. Every number cites its source. Sizing below is arithmetic on public enrollment and Semester’s planning price — not a forecast.

1. The enrollment base

MEASURE	VALUE	SOURCE
Total US postsecondary enrollment, fall 2025	19.4 million (+1.0% YoY)	National Student Clearinghouse Research Center, via EssayPro / High5 summaries
Undergraduate / graduate, fall 2025	16.2 M / 3.2 M	NSCRC, via Bryan Alexander
Public four-year universities	~7.9 M students (~41%)	High5 summary of NSCRC/NCES
Trend	Community colleges +3.0%; public 4-year +1.4%; private nonprofit 4-year −1.6%	NSCRC, via Bryan Alexander

2. Sizing arithmetic (planning, not forecast)

SCOPE	STUDENTS	× $18 / STUDENT / YR
All US postsecondary	19.4 M	≈ $349 M / yr theoretical ceiling
Public four-year universities (beachhead class)	~7.9 M	≈ $142 M / yr
One 13,000-student research university (e.g. pilot scale)	13,000	≈ $234 k / yr (above the $30 k floor)

$18 is Semester’s planning assumption from the GTM playbook, not a published price. The last row’s enrollment is illustrative — confirm Vanderbilt’s actual headcount before using it externally.

3. Landscape — student success platforms

PLAYER	WHAT IT IS	SCALE (AS CLAIMED)	NOTE
EAB Navigate360	Student-lifecycle CRM: advising, early alerts, student self-service	EAB says 850+ partner institutions and 10M+ students supported	Vendor claims; graduation-rate gains of 3–15% are EAB’s own case-study figures
Starfish (EAB)	Early alert, care networks, advising	“Nearly 500 colleges and universities” (Starfish)	Acquired by EAB from Hobsons in Feb 2021; Penn State announced moving from Starfish to Navigate360 for 2027–28

PLAYER	WHAT IT IS	SCALE (AS CLAIMED)	NOTE
Civitas Learning	Predictive analytics for student success	—	Listed alongside Navigate and Starfish in third-party comparisons
AI-native entrants (e.g. ibl.ai)	Course-aware AI tutors and agents	—	Position on AI tutoring, which incumbents lack

Pricing signal. One third-party estimate puts Navigate software at $50,000–$300,000 per year depending on size, with bundles above $500,000 for large universities. That estimate comes from a competitor's comparison page (ibl.ai) — treat it as indicative only.

4. Where Semester fits

INCUMBENTS OPTIMISE FOR	SEMESTER OPTIMISES FOR
Staff: alerts, caseloads, dashboards	The student's next action, ranked by what blocks them
Risk scores	Provenance: official / connected / yours / AI-assisted on every fact
AI as a feature (or absent)	AI governed by course policy; student records never reach a model
Replacing workflows	Sitting beside the SIS/LMS in a bounded, paid pilot

Positioning line: *complements* Navigate/Starfish (staff side) rather than replacing them in year one — the pilot does not ask a school to rip anything out.

5. Sources

- EssayPro, "Postsecondary Enrollment Statistics: Changes From Fall 2025" (NSCRC data)
- Bryan Alexander, "Fall 2025 enrollment data: uneven growth, emerging trends"
- High5Test, "40+ College Enrollment Statistics (2024–2025)"
- EAB, "Student Success and Retention" solutions page
- Starfish, a part of EAB (LinkedIn showcase)
- EAB press release, "EAB to Enhance Its Student Success Collaborative by Acquiring Starfish," Feb 18 2021
- Penn State Starfish info site, Navigate360 transition update
- ibl.ai, "EAB Navigate Alternatives: Student Success Platforms for 2026" (competitor source)

Finance and capital

docs/business/FINANCE_AND_CAPITAL_SYSTEM.md

Finance, accounting and capital

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Requires qualified professional review before use.

Field	Value
Mission	Know cash, runway and unit economics every month; bill accurately and collect on time.
Owner	Founder + bookkeeper
Inputs	Bank and card feeds, invoices, contracts, payroll/contractor costs, vendor bills
System of record	/ops finance (invoices, AR, dunning); accounting ledger (bookkeeper); bank
KPIs	Cash, burn, runway; ARR, pilot revenue; Gross margin incl. AI and cloud cost; DSO; Forecast variance
Reports	Monthly close pack; dashboards: cash, revenue, pipeline, margin, CAC, retention, spend, forecast (conservative/base/ambitious/downside)
Meeting cadence	Monthly close (1 h); weekly cash check
Risk controls	Founder approves spend above $500; separation of invoicing and payment where possible
Approval thresholds	Spend > $500 → founder; discounts per price book; anything off price book → founder
Required documents	Chart of accounts, Expense policy, Tax calendar, Price book, Discount policy, Finance model
Required integrations	Bank, payment processor, accounting software (embedded views)
Current status	docs/run/Finance Model.html, docs/grow/GTM Plan.html (price book), ui_kits/ops (finance console)
Gaps	36-month model, AI cost per workflow, revenue recognition review, tax calendar
Priority	P0
Next action	Open business bank account and accounting ledger; set the monthly close date

Workflows

- Month ends → invoices and payments reconciled → expenses categorized → payroll posted → vendor costs reviewed → revenue/deferred revenue reviewed → P&L → balance sheet → cash flow → runway → forecast variance → executive review → investor summary

docs/business/finance/FINANCE_AND_ACCOUNTING_OPERATIONS.md

Finance and accounting operations

Semester business operations · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/Show the finance and accounting operations section.pdf.
Accounting, tax, legal, insurance, privacy, security, accessibility and compliance content needs qualified professional review before use.

> Every customer promise connects to a financial owner, delivery owner, support process, security/privacy control, product capability and evidence trail.

Questions the system must answer any time

- How much cash do we have, and how long is the runway?
- What is committed revenue, and what is actually collected?
- Which contracts and pilots are profitable; what does each customer cost to serve?
- What is the margin impact of AI and infrastructure?
- What can we afford to hire or build next?

Console: /ops/finance

- Cash, runway, revenue dashboards and revenue forecast
- P&L, balance sheet, cash-flow views; budget vs actual
- Expense categories, vendor spend, payroll and contractor forecast
- Unit economics, customer profitability, AI cost and cloud cost dashboards
- Pricing calculator, discount approvals, finance risk alerts
- Collections/dunning, invoices, payment reconciliation
- Tax calendar, insurance tracker, board finance pack, forecast scenarios

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Data model (commercial and billing state only)

Accounting periods, accounts, journal-entry references, bank accounts, cash snapshots, budgets, forecast scenarios, revenue and expense plans, cost centers, customers, contracts, orders, subscriptions, invoices and lines, payments, credits/refunds, dunning cases, vendor contracts, purchase orders, expenses, payroll and contractor costs, cloud costs, AI costs, security/compliance costs, reporting snapshots.

The product database tracks quotes, orders, subscriptions, invoices, entitlements, payment events, dunning and profitability. It is not the statutory ledger. The ledger lives in accounting software designed with the accountant; /ops shows it embedded.

Revenue streams

Paid pilots; implementation fees; annual platform licenses (per enrolled student); premium support; AI usage overages; Student Premium; department, enterprise and multi-campus plans; marketplace commissions; partner revenue; professional, training and migration services.

Planning prices (assumptions, not published)

Item	Planning price
Student workspace	Free at participating schools
Student Premium	$8.99 / month or $69 / year
Institution platform	$18 per enrolled student per year, $30,000 annual minimum
AI overage	$30 per 1,000 governed requests
Implementation	$35,000–$150,000 one-time (waived or credited for the first pilots)
Premium support	15% of annual platform fee, $15,000 minimum
Marketplace / partner commission	12%, optional and separate from core viability

Quote-to-cash

Quote → pricing exception check → approval if required → order form accepted → contract active → invoice → payment collected and reconciled → entitlement granted → revenue recognized/reviewed → renewal tracked → expansion, cancellation or dunning → profitability reviewed.

Controls

Action	Required control
Create draft quote	Revenue operations role
Approve discount	Deal desk by margin/ACV threshold (founder until a deal desk exists)
Send final quote	Revenue approval
Change commercial plan	Approval + entitlement impact review
Issue credit/refund	Finance approval + invoice/payment reference
Write off receivable	Finance + executive approval above threshold
Change billing account	Verified customer authority
Change bank/payment settings	Strong authentication + finance approval
Publish forecast	Finance owner review
Board/investor reporting	Founder/finance approval
Create vendor commitment	Budget owner approval

KPIs

Cash, burn, runway, committed ARR, recognized revenue, collected cash, MRR, ARR, pilot/implementation/expansion revenue, gross and contribution margin, AI and cloud cost per active user, support cost per customer, implementation cost per pilot, CAC, payback, LTV sensitivity, gross retention, NRR, ACV, sales cycle, invoice aging, collections rate, dunning recovery, budget variance, headcount cost, revenue per employee.

Monthly close

Calendar opens → invoices reviewed → payments reconciled → vendor invoices recorded → payroll and contractor costs recorded → cloud and AI costs allocated → expenses categorized → deferred revenue reviewed → P&L → balance sheet → cash flow → forecast variance explained → runway updated → executive review → board/investor summary.

Processes

Process	Trigger	Owner	System of record	Approval	Output	KPI	Failure → escalation
Monthly close	Calendar day 5	Founder + bookkeeper	Ledger	Founder	Close pack	Close on time	Late → founder same week
Invoice	Order form signed / milestone	Founder	/ops invoices	—	Invoice sent	DSO	Unpaid 30 days → dunning
Discount	Quote below list	Founder	/ops quotes	Founder	Approved quote	Avg discount	Below floor → reject
Refund/credit	Customer request	Founder	/ops payments	Finance	Credit note	Refund rate	Dispute → counsel

Status and gaps

- Have: docs/run/Finance Model.html, docs/grow/GTM Plan.html, ui_kits/ops finance console.
- Gaps (P0): bank account, ledger and chart of accounts with the accountant, tax registrations, invoice the pilot. (P1): AI cost allocation, customer profitability, 36-month model.

`docs/business/BOARD_AND_INVESTOR_OPERATIONS.md`

Board, investor and stakeholder operations

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

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Field	Value
Mission	Clear, honest updates when there are stakeholders to update.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	KPI tree, finance, pipeline, risks
System of record	/ops board/investor reports; investor portal
KPIs	Updates sent on time
Reports	Monthly founder update
Meeting cadence	Monthly (deferred while bootstrapped)
Risk controls	Numbers from the close pack only
Approval thresholds	Fundraising deferred until pilot results
Required documents	Investor deck, Data room index, Cap table
Required integrations	—
Current status	templates/investor-deck/, ui_kits/investor/
Gaps	Data room index
Priority	P3
Next action	Draft the data room index (deferred)

Workflows

- Monthly update → board deck (when a board exists) → decisions → follow-ups

SEMESTER

Finance model · pre-revenue to first annual contract

Owner: founder. Status: draft, October 2026. All cost lines are estimates to confirm with quotes, except hosting list prices, which are sourced in §5. Founder salary is $0 in every scenario.

Budget rule: setup must fit the $5,000–$20,000 range. Spend in launch-gate order (insurance, counsel, accessibility, security) before anything else. The pilot fee is the first revenue; nothing below assumes outside money.

1. Setup budget: three scenarios

Item	Basis	Lean	Base	Full
Counsel review: MSA, DPA, order form, terms, privacy	Quote from counsel	$1,500	$4,000	$6,000
Cyber + E&O insurance, first-year premium	Broker quote (launch gate)	$1,500	$3,000	$4,500
Accessibility: ACR test pass	Self-test / partial audit / third-party audit	$0	$1,500	$2,500
Penetration test	Not in lean or base; scope in Security Readiness	$0	$0	$2,000
Accounting setup, tax registrations	Accountant quote	$300	$800	$1,000
Domain, email, password manager, tools	Vendor list prices	$200	$300	$500
Hosting, first 6 months (Supabase Pro + staging, Vercel Pro)	See §5 sources	$330	$400	$600
AI provider usage, first 6 months	Gateway spend cap	$100	$300	$500
Travel to campus (setup, launch)	Estimate	$500	$1,000	$500
Subtotal		$4,430	$11,300	$18,100
Contingency 10%		$443	$1,130	$1,810
Total setup		**$4,873**	**$12,430**	**$19,910**

Lean meets the contract minimum with self-testing and the smallest legal scope. **Base** is the recommendation: counsel reviews every institution document and accessibility gets a partial outside audit. **Full** adds a third-party pen test and full accessibility audit, which strengthens HECVAT answers for pilot #2.

2. Monthly run-rate after launch

Line	Per month
Supabase Pro (production)	$25
Supabase staging project	$10
Vercel Pro, 1 seat	$20
Email and tools	$60
AI provider usage (capped)	$50
Bookkeeping	$150
Insurance, if paid monthly	$250
Total	**$565**

That's about $6,780 a year. Hosting stays under $100 a month at pilot scale. When an institution asks for the hosting vendor's own SOC 2 report through Semester, budget the Supabase Team plan (§5) as a step change: +$574 a month.

3. Revenue scenarios (first 12 months)

Scenario	Pilot fee (Vanderbilt)	Pilots #2–#3	Annual conversions	12-month revenue
Low	[signed fee]	0	0	[signed fee]
Base	[signed fee]	1 × $15,000	1 × $30,000 (floor)	[signed fee] + $45,000
High	[signed fee]	2 × $15,000	2 × $30,000	[signed fee] + $90,000

The Vanderbilt fee is in the signed order form; fill it in. Pilot #2–#3 fees and annual prices are planning assumptions from the GTM plan ($18 per student per year, $30,000 floor), not quotes. Pilot fees credited against year 1 are revenue once, not twice.

4. Cash and runway

Measure	Lean	Base	Full
Setup spend	$4,873	$12,430	$19,910
Run-rate, 12 months	$6,780	$6,780	$6,780
Cash needed before pilot fee arrives	$6,568	$14,125	$21,605
Break-even point	Pilot fee ≥ setup + 3 months	Pilot fee ≥ setup + 3 months	Pilot fee ≥ setup + 3 months

"Cash needed" assumes the pilot invoice is paid about three months after setup starts. Ask for 50% at signature in the order form to shorten that.

5. Sourced prices (checked 5 Oct 2026)

Vendor	Price used	Source
Supabase Pro	$25 a month per organization, includes a Micro compute credit; extra projects about $10 a month	makerkit.dev and flexprice.io Supabase pricing guides, 2026
Supabase Team	$599 a month (SOC 2, SLA)	flexprice.io and costbench.com, 2026
Vercel Pro	$20 per user a month billed annually, $24 monthly	vendr.com Vercel pricing, 2026

Re-check on the vendors' own pricing pages before each budget review; third-party summaries can lag.

6. Unit economics at the planning price

Measure	Value	Note
Annual contract (floor)	$30,000	Planning assumption
Hosting + AI per institution	≈ $1,500 a year	Estimate at pilot scale
Support time	Founder hours	Not costed while salary is $0
Gross margin before people	≈ 95%	Falls when support and engineering are hired

7. Monthly close (one hour)

1. Reconcile bank and card.
2. Categorize spend against the lines above.
3. Update cash, run-rate and runway.
4. Compare actual setup spend to the chosen scenario; flag any line over 20%.
5. Note any contract, insurance or renewal dates in the next 60 days.

People and hiring

docs/business/PEOPLE_AND_HIRING_SYSTEM.md

People, hiring and culture

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

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Field	Value
Mission	Hire on triggers, onboard safely, keep the culture evidence-first.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Hiring triggers, revenue
System of record	/ops people (hiring, onboarding); payroll provider (embedded)
KPIs	Time to hire; Onboarding checklist completion; Access revoked same day on exit
Reports	Quarterly workforce plan
Meeting cadence	Quarterly
Risk controls	IP + confidentiality before access; FERPA/security training
Approval thresholds	Every hire tied to signed revenue
Required documents	Hiring plan, Job descriptions, Handbook, Equity plan
Required integrations	Payroll provider, identity provider
Current status	docs/run/Hiring Plan.html
Gaps	Handbook, equity plan, compensation bands
Priority	P2
Next action	Engage counsel and bookkeeper as the first contractors

Workflows

- Trigger → scorecard → recruit → loop → references → offer → onboarding → access provisioning → 90-day review → offboarding → access revocation

docs/business/people/PEOPLE_HIRING_AND_CULTURE.md

People, hiring and culture

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Org design

Founder/CEO → product and design; engineering and platform; learning and academic operations; student success and implementation; sales and GTM; customer success and support; security, privacy, compliance and legal ops; finance and business operations; partnerships and developer ecosystem; people and culture.

Hiring sequence

Stage	First priority hires
Prototype to pilot	Full-stack/platform engineer, product designer, implementation/CS lead
First paid pilots	Institutional sales lead, security/compliance adviser, support/implementation capacity
Pilot conversion	Product manager, data/analytics, registrar/academic operations expert
Expansion	Platform/SRE, partnerships/integrations, marketing/content, finance/operations
Platform scale	Developer relations, marketplace/partner team, regional operations, research/outcomes

Every hire still waits for its revenue trigger (docs/run/Hiring Plan.html).

Every role has

Mission, outcomes, competencies, technical/domain requirements, decision rights, metrics, interview process, references, compensation and equity range, onboarding plan, 30/60/90 deliverables, access needed, security/privacy training, review expectations.

Cultural standards

- Student agency over surveillance
- Evidence over hype
- Accessibility by default
- Trust before shortcuts
- Interoperability over lock-in
- Human judgment in high-stakes decisions
- Reliability before vanity features
- Documentation is part of the product
- Every critical workflow has a rollback
- Every public claim has evidence
- Every customer promise has an owner

- Every incident creates a learning loop

SEMESTER

Hiring plan and job descriptions

Owner: founder. Status: draft, October 2026. Semester is bootstrapped: every hire is triggered by revenue or by a contract obligation, never by a calendar date.

Rule: no role is opened until its trigger is true and its cost is covered by signed revenue. Anyone touching student data signs confidentiality terms, completes FERPA and security training, and gets least-privilege access, reviewed quarterly.

1. Plan

When	Role	Type	Trigger	Paid from
Now	Fractional counsel	Contract	Pilot paper (MSA, DPA, order form) needs review	Covered in finance model setup
Now	Insurance broker	Vendor	Cyber + E&O required by the pilot contract	Commission-based
Now	Bookkeeper	Contract, ~2 h/month	Pilot invoice and monthly close	In run-rate
Before launch	Accessibility tester	Contract, per engagement	ACR test log for the pilot	Base / full scenario
After pilot fee	Founding full-stack engineer	Contract-to-hire	Two pilots in delivery, or founder spending >50% of time on engineering	Paid from pilot revenue only
After 2nd pilot	Implementation & customer success lead	Part-time → full-time	Two concurrent institutions in setup or live	Paid from contracted revenue
After 1st annual	Security & compliance lead (fractional)	Fractional	SOC 2 readiness, or a buyer requiring it	Per engagement
After 3 annuals	Account executive (higher ed)	Full-time	Founder can no longer run all discovery calls	Base + commission
After 3 annuals	Product designer	Full-time	Design debt slowing releases; design system needs an owner	—
Later	Support specialist	Part-time	Tickets exceed founder capacity during pilot hours	—

2. How we hire

1. Write the job description from this document; post with a salary range.

2. 30-minute screen: motivation and the role's must-haves.
3. Paid work sample (2–4 hours, real but not production work, no student data).
4. Two references, one a former manager.
5. Offer with IP assignment, confidentiality and a background check where the institution contract requires it.

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3. Onboarding (every hire)

Week	Do
1	Accounts with MFA, read the operating manual, design system readme, security policies and acceptable use
1	FERPA and security training; sign confidentiality and acceptable-use
2	Shadow a support shift and a customer call
2–4	First owned deliverable with a named reviewer
12	90-day review against the role's first-90 list

Job descriptions

Founding full-stack engineer

Contract-to-hire · remote (US) · reports to founder

Build Semester with the founder: the student app, staff workspaces and the data layer that keeps every institution's records isolated.

You'll own

- Features end to end in React + TypeScript on Supabase (Postgres, RLS, Auth) and Vercel
- Row-level security policies and the tests that prove them
- SIS and LMS read integrations (SAML SSO, LTI 1.3, OneRoster)
- CI, releases and on-call rotation with the founder

First 90 days

- Ship the SAML SSO and SIS read sync for the pilot
- Land RLS test coverage on every student table
- Take one on-call week with the support plan

You have

- 3+ years shipping production web apps in TypeScript
- Postgres you can reason about: schemas, indexes, policies
- Care for accessibility and plain interfaces
- Comfort working directly with a founder and with customers

Good to have

- Higher-ed systems (Banner, Workday Student, Canvas)
- Supabase or row-level security in production
- Security reviews (HECVAT, SOC 2)

This role is not a role where you only take tickets. You'll make product calls.

Implementation & customer success lead

Part-time to full-time · remote (US) with campus travel · reports to founder

Get each institution live and make the pilot succeed against the measures it agreed.

You'll own

- Implementation plans from signature to launch
- Weekly sponsor updates and the week-1 review
- Staff training for advisors, registrar and student affairs
- Results reports and the annual conversion conversation

First 90 days

- Run setup for pilot #2 using the launch runbook
- Own day-1 / week-1 support for one launch
- Draft the case study from the Vanderbilt pilot

You have

- Experience implementing software at colleges or universities
- Clear writing to executives and to front-line staff
- Comfort with data mapping and spreadsheets

Good to have

- Advising, registrar or student success background
- FERPA training

Security & compliance lead (fractional)

Fractional · remote · reports to founder

Turn Semester's security policies into evidence that institutions and auditors accept.

You'll own

- HECVAT responses and the evidence register
- SOC 2 readiness plan and vendor management
- Access reviews, incident response exercises and the restore drill
- Pen-test scoping and remediation tracking

First 90 days

- Review the HECVAT Full answers against real controls
- Run one tabletop incident exercise
- Produce a SOC 2 gap list with costs

You have

- Security program experience at a SaaS company
- Familiarity with FERPA and higher-ed security reviews
- Practical, evidence-first approach

Good to have

- CISSP, CISM or similar

This role is not a full-time hire yet.

Account executive, higher education

Full-time · remote (US) · base + commission · reports to founder

Find and close the next universities, using the pilot motion that worked.

You'll own

- Pipeline from target list to signed pilot
- Discovery, demos and mutual action plans
- Security and legal review coordination with the founder
- Forecast in the weekly metrics review

First 90 days

- Learn the GTM plan, price book and claim rules
- Run 15 discovery calls
- Bring two pilots to security / legal review

You have

- Track record selling software to colleges or universities
- Comfort with long, multi-stakeholder sales
- Honest selling: status, not promises

Good to have

- Student success or registrar buyers

Product designer

Full-time · remote (US) · reports to founder

Own the Semester design system and the product experience for students and staff.

You'll own

- The design system: tokens, components, patterns, templates
- Flows for new workflows from the catalog
- Accessibility review on every release
- Research sessions with students and staff

First 90 days

- Audit the design system against the shipped app
- Redesign one high-traffic flow with research
- Set up the accessibility review in the release checklist

You have

- Portfolio of shipped product work, including complex data or forms

- Working knowledge of WCAG 2.2
- Can prototype in code or work closely with engineers who do

Good to have

- Higher-ed or civic product experience

Support specialist

Part-time · remote (US), pilot hours · reports to implementation lead

Answer staff and escalated student questions quickly and route the rest to the right place.

You'll own

- The support queue during pilot hours
- Known-issues notes and reply macros
- Ticket tagging that feeds the product backlog

First 90 days

- Learn the support plan and severities
- Handle a launch week alongside the implementation lead

You have

- Support experience, ideally software or a campus help desk
- Calm, plain writing

This role is not access to raw student records: tickets reference internal IDs only.

Contractor briefs

Role	Brief	Deliverable
Fractional counsel	Review MSA, DPA, order form, terms, privacy; advise on liability caps and institution paper	Redlines and a fallback position memo
Insurance broker	Quote cyber + E&O at the limits in the pilot contract	Bound policies and certificates
Bookkeeper	Monthly close per the finance model; invoices and receivables	Monthly P&L and cash report
Accessibility tester	Manual and assistive-technology testing on pilot paths	Test log and ACR draft

Governance, legal, risk and vendors

docs/business/CORPORATE_GOVERNANCE_AND_LEGAL_OPS.md

Corporate governance and legal

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Requires qualified professional review before use.

Field	Value
Mission	Keep the company legally sound, its IP owned, and every contract and obligation tracked.
Owner	Founder + fractional counsel
Inputs	Formation documents, contracts, policies, counsel advice
System of record	Contracts register in /ops legal; corporate records folder
KPIs	Contracts with obligations logged; Days to signature; Renewals missed (0)
Reports	Monthly legal queue and obligations calendar
Meeting cadence	Weekly legal queue review (15 min)
Risk controls	No signature without template or counsel redline; IP assignment for every contributor
Approval thresholds	Any contract with student data, liability above fees, or non-standard indemnity → counsel
Required documents	Operating agreement, IP assignment, NDA, MSA, Order form, DPA, SLA, Terms, Privacy, Acceptable use, Cookie notice, Accessibility statement, Security addendum, Contractor / employee / advisor templates, Marketplace publisher agreement, Trademark register
Required integrations	E-sign (embedded), contracts register
Current status	docs/legal/ (MSA, order form, DPA, terms, privacy, cookie, accessibility, community, subprocessors)
Gaps	SLA, SOW, security addendum, contractor/advisor templates, trademark filing, policy register
Priority	P0
Next action	Counsel review of MSA, DPA and order form before pilot launch

Workflows

- Request → classify → business owner → legal owner → risk rating → template → redline → approval → signature → obligations extracted → renewal reminder → evidence → amendment/termination

docs/business/BUSINESS_RISK_REGISTER.md

Business risk register

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Risk	Category	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation	Owner
Pilot starts without insurance	Legal/compliance	Medium	High	Bind before go/no-go	Founder
Customer concentration (one pilot)	Financial	High	High	Pipeline of 40 targets; conversion plan	Founder
Runway shortfall before pilot invoice paid	Financial	Medium	High	50% at signature; lean setup	Founder
Founder capacity	People	High	High	Revenue-triggered hires; contractors; runbooks	Founder
Vendor breach (hosting/AI)	Vendor	Low	High	Reviews, DPAs, breach plan	Founder
Unsupported promise in a deal	Revenue	Medium	Medium	Claims register; scope in order form	Founder
Ledger built in product DB	Finance	Low	Medium	Accountant-designed ledger	Bookkeeper
Accessibility complaint	Compliance	Medium	High	ACR, barrier process	Founder
Price too low to fund support	Financial	Medium	Medium	Floors, premium support, overage	Founder
Reputation from over-claiming	Reputation	Low	High	Status not certifications	Founder

docs/business/RISK_RESILIENCE_AND_CONTINUITY.md

Risk, resilience and continuity

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Field	Value
Mission	See risks early and recover fast.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Risk register, incidents, SLO data
System of record	/ops risk register, incidents, SLOs
KPIs	Risks with owners; Restore drill time; Postmortems on time
Reports	Monthly risk review
Meeting cadence	Monthly
Risk controls	Error budget policy; key-person continuity plan
Approval thresholds	P0 risks reviewed weekly
Required documents	Risk register, BCP/DR, Runbooks, Platform risk register
Required integrations	Monitoring

Field	Value
Current status	ui_kits/business (risks), docs/operate/, docs/platform/PLATFORM_RISK_REGISTER.md
Gaps	Key-person continuity plan, customer concentration plan
Priority	P1
Next action	Write the key-person continuity plan (credentials escrow, runbooks, counsel contact)

Workflows

- Identify → rate → owner → mitigation → review

`docs/business/VENDOR_AND_PROCUREMENT_SYSTEM.md`

Procurement, vendors and supply chain

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Requires qualified professional review before use.

Field	Value
Mission	Every vendor has a purpose, a review and an exit.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Vendor requests
System of record	/ops vendors
KPIs	Vendors reviewed; Vendors with DPA; Renewals reviewed before date
Reports	Subprocessor list (public)
Meeting cadence	Annual vendor review
Risk controls	Need-to-know access, MFA, encryption, breach plan
Approval thresholds	Student-data vendors → subprocessor notice
Required documents	Vendor risk policy, Subprocessors
Required integrations	—
Current status	docs/legal/Subprocessors.html, docs/secure/
Gaps	Vendor review records
Priority	P1
Next action	Record reviews for Supabase, Vercel, AI provider, email provider

Workflows

- Intake → purpose → data classification → security/privacy review → contract terms → access scope → onboarding → periodic review → incident escalation → renewal → offboarding

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docs/business/DATA_RESEARCH_AND_OUTCOMES.md

Data, research and outcomes

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

> Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

Requires qualified professional review before use.

Field	Value
Mission	Prove outcomes with privacy-safe evidence.
Owner	Founder
Inputs	Event taxonomy, cohorts, measures
System of record	Analytics (aggregate), research repository
KPIs	Pilots with baseline; Measures met; Claims approved with evidence
Reports	Pilot results report
Meeting cadence	Per term
Risk controls	Minimum cell size; no row-level export; research governance
Approval thresholds	Any publication → institution approval
Required documents	Event taxonomy, Metric definitions, Research governance
Required integrations	Warehouse (later)
Current status	templates/pilot-results-report/, docs/platform/RESEARCH_AND_OUTCOMES_ENGINE.md
Gaps	Event taxonomy, metric definitions
Priority	P1
Next action	Define the pilot event taxonomy (no PII)

Workflows

- Hypothesis → baseline → cohort → intervention → measurement → analysis → evidence review → customer validation → claim approval → iteration

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docs/business/BUSINESS_MASTER_BACKLOG.md

Business master backlog

Semester Company OS · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/what else on the bussnius and opprations site also.pdf.

Semester must operate with the same coherence, evidence, reliability and trust it promises to institutions.

P0

- **Corporate governance and legal:** Counsel review of MSA, DPA and order form before pilot launch *(gaps: SLA, SOW, security addendum, contractor/advisor templates, trademark filing, policy register)*
- **Finance, accounting and capital:** Open business bank account and accounting ledger; set the monthly close date *(gaps: 36-month model, AI cost per workflow, revenue recognition review, tax calendar)*
- **Security, privacy, accessibility and compliance:** Bind insurance; submit HECVAT Full; complete vendor reviews for Supabase, Vercel, AI provider *(gaps: HECVAT submitted, insurance bound, ACR, vendor reviews documented)*
- **Customer success and implementation:** Kick off Vanderbilt implementation with the mutual action plan *(gaps: Health score definition, customer advisory board)*

P1

- **Product and engineering operations:** Run execute stream 00 and approve the design-system baseline *(gaps: PRD template, ADR log, experiment registry)*
- **Go-to-market and revenue operations:** Build the 40-account target list in /ops *(gaps: Target list built, win/loss log)*
- **Support and service operations:** Write the first 10 KB articles from the pilot paths *(gaps: Help center, KB articles, feature-request taxonomy)*
- **Data, research and outcomes:** Define the pilot event taxonomy (no PII) *(gaps: Event taxonomy, metric definitions)*
- **Procurement, vendors and supply chain:** Record reviews for Supabase, Vercel, AI provider, email provider *(gaps: Vendor review records)*
- **Risk, resilience and continuity:** Write the key-person continuity plan (credentials escrow, runbooks, counsel contact) *(gaps: Key-person continuity plan, customer concentration plan)*
- **Operations command center:** Start the weekly operating review from the executive overview *(gaps: Decisions log, work items)*

P2

- **Marketing, brand and communications:** Publish pilot, pricing and trust pages *(gaps: Content calendar, SEO plan, webinar plan)*
- **People, hiring and culture:** Engage counsel and bookkeeper as the first contractors *(gaps: Handbook, equity plan, compensation bands)*

P3

- **Partnerships, marketplace and developer relations:** List the integration partners the pilot depends on (SIS, LMS, IdP, AI provider) *(gaps: Partner list, agreements)*
- **Board, investor and stakeholder operations:** Draft the data room index (deferred) *(gaps: Data room index)*

90-day plan

- Sellable pilot package complete (contracts reviewed, insurance bound)
- Finance: bank, ledger, monthly close
- Trust: HECVAT, vendor reviews, ACR in progress
- Pipeline: 40 targets, 10 discovery calls
- Implementation: Vanderbilt launched with support plan
- Reliability: monitoring, restore drill

12-month plan

- Pilot results and annual conversion
- Pilots #2–#3
- First engineer and implementation lead
- KB and help center
- Event taxonomy and results reporting
- SOC 2 readiness plan

36-month plan

- Repeatable implementation factory
- Platform maturity stages 2–4
- Partner program and certified integrations
- Board and investor operations if raising
- Multi-campus customers
- Published outcomes research

Budget and capacity

See docs/run/Finance Model.html (setup $4,873 / $12,430 / $19,910; run-rate ≈ $565/mo) and docs/run/Hiring Plan.html.

Top 50 business and operations actions

1. Counsel review: MSA, DPA, order form
2. Bind cyber + E&O insurance
3. Open business bank account
4. Set up accounting ledger and chart of accounts
5. Register for state/local taxes (accountant)

6. Sign Vanderbilt DPA
7. Submit HECVAT Full
8. Record vendor reviews (Supabase, Vercel, AI, email)
9. Publish subprocessor list
10. Sign success-measures sheet
11. Kickoff with mutual action plan
12. Name Vanderbilt contacts
13. Set monthly close date
14. Invoice the pilot (50% at signature if possible)
15. Start weekly operating review
16. Create contracts register with obligations
17. Create decisions log
18. Write key-person continuity plan
19. Escrow credentials and runbooks
20. Define pilot event taxonomy
21. Write 10 KB articles
22. Set up status page
23. Run support plan on launch
24. Build 40-account target list
25. Book 10 discovery calls
26. Publish pilot, pricing, trust pages
27. Claims register review of site and decks
28. Write SLA document
29. Write SOW template
30. Write security addendum
31. Contractor and advisor templates
32. File trademark search (counsel)
33. Draft employee handbook (counsel)
34. Midpoint review
35. Case-study permission
36. Results report
37. Annual conversion proposal
38. Extend finance model to 36 months
39. AI cost per workflow model
40. Health score definition
41. Win/loss log
42. Content calendar
43. Partner list for pilot dependencies
44. Policy register
45. Quarterly access review
46. Tabletop incident exercise

47. Restore drill
48. Hiring trigger review
49. Data room index (deferred)
50. Quarterly scorecard and plan refresh

Strategy

The competitive plan, moats, AI differentiation, ecosystem, implementation and outcome-proof programs.

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docs/strategy/README.md

docs/strategy

Become the platform hardest to leave because it makes education clearer for students, more effective for educators, safer for institutions, more open for partners and more reliable for everyone.

- SEMESTER_COMPETITIVE_COMPLETION_AUDIT.md
- SEMESTER_PLATFORM_MATURITY_SCORECARD.md
- SEMESTER_COMPETITIVE_MOAT_PLAN.md
- SEMESTER_GLOBAL_PLATFORM_ROADMAP.md
- SEMESTER_OUTCOME_PROOF_PROGRAM.md
- SEMESTER_IMPLEMENTATION_FACTORY.md
- SEMESTER_MIGRATION_FACTORY.md
- SEMESTER_ECOSYSTEM_AND_MARKETPLACE_PLAN.md
- SEMESTER_MOBILE_EXCELLENCE_PLAN.md
- SEMESTER_AI_DIFFERENTIATION_PLAN.md
- SEMESTER_TRUST_ADVANTAGE_PLAN.md
- SEMESTER_36_MONTH_COMPETITIVE_PLAN.md

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docs/strategy/SEMESTER_36_MONTH_COMPETITIVE_PLAN.md

36-month competitive plan

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

0–6 months · Prove the pilot

- Close six launch blockers
- Ship SSO, SIS read sync, Today, registration readiness, governed AI
- Run the Vanderbilt pilot with signed measures
- Monitoring, runbooks, restore drill live

6–12 months · Convert and repeat

- Results report and case study
- Annual conversion
- Pilots #2–#3 via the implementation factory
- First engineer and implementation lead

12–24 months · Become the operating layer

- Course Studio, advising, registrar desk in production
- Migration factory runs first real domain migration
- SOC 2 readiness; pen test
- Public API beta and first certified partner

24–36 months · Platform and ecosystem

- Marketplace with governed installs
- Multi-campus and system offices
- First non-US or K–12 model
- Published outcome research

Growth loop

Pilot → student activation → measured outcomes → annual conversion → expansion → reference → new pipeline → partner interest → ecosystem.

Acquisition engines

Engine	Goal
Institutional sales	Paid pilots, annual contracts
Student adoption	Daily use, internal proof
Faculty/advisor champions	Trusted workflow adoption
Campus ambassadors	Peer activation
SEO/resources	Inbound demand
Content/webinars	Category authority
Partnerships	Borrowed trust
Developers/marketplace	Ecosystem distribution

Engine	Goal
Alumni/employers	Career network value
References	Enterprise credibility

Repeatability

Sell → contract → implement → support → measure → renew → expand → migrate → govern → improve, without founder memory or heroics.

Budget, team, partners, trust

Budget: docs/run/Finance Model.html. Team: docs/run/Hiring Plan.html and docs/business/people/. Partners: SIS, LMS, IdP, AI provider first. Trust: SEMESTER_TRUST_ADVANTAGE_PLAN.md.

Exact next 50 actions

1. Bind cyber + E&O insurance
2. Get counsel review of MSA, DPA, order form
3. Sign the DPA/FERPA addendum
4. Submit HECVAT Full
5. Name Vanderbilt IT, registrar and sponsor contacts
6. Sign the success-measures sheet and baseline
7. Run stream 00 (repo audit, toolkit, CI)
8. Approve the design-system baseline
9. Run stream 01 (migrations, RLS tests)
10. Prove every RLS policy red-then-green
11. Install semester-core and pass its tests
12. Set up staging Supabase + Vercel projects
13. Configure staging SAML with the test IdP
14. Map IdP attributes to pilot roles
15. Build the SIS read connector for the pilot extract
16. Build the reconciliation report
17. Reach 0 unexplained mismatches on staging data
18. Ship Today with source labels
19. Ship registration readiness and hold hand-off
20. Ship sharing with advisor and revoke
21. Ship the AI gateway with course policy
22. Write and pass the red-team suite
23. Ship advisor caseload (consented shares)

24. Ship registrar desk read views
25. Ship institution console: roles, cohorts, kill switch, audit
26. Wire error tracking and uptime checks
27. Wire SSO-failure and SIS-lag alerts
28. Time a restore drill
29. Run axe in CI on pilot routes
30. Manual screen-reader pass on pilot paths
31. Draft the ACR
32. Run a 5-student usability test of Today
33. Fix the top 5 usability findings
34. Staff training for advisors and registrar
35. Dry run with test accounts
36. Final go/no-go with the sponsor
37. Production cutover C1–C11
38. Launch to the pilot cohort
39. Run day-1 and week-1 support
40. Week-1 review with the sponsor
41. Midpoint review and case-study permission
42. Build the 40-account target list
43. Book 10 discovery calls
44. Publish pilot, pricing and trust pages
45. Extend finance model to 36 months
46. Results report at end of term
47. Annual conversion proposal
48. Hire the founding engineer on trigger
49. Start pilot #2 through the implementation factory
50. Publish the case study

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_AI_DIFFERENTIATION_PLAN.md`

AI differentiation plan

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Safer and more useful than general chat, not just more conversational.

Every answer can show

- Context used

- Sources
- Policy applied
- Model/provider selected
- Uncertainty
- Official versus guidance
- Action the user can take
- When a human should be involved

AI trust UI

Answer · source citations · institution/course policy · context used · confidence and limits · suggested next actions · ask an advisor/instructor/office · give feedback · report a problem.

Deterministic policy engine

Prerequisites, co-requisites, credit limits, registration windows, holds, degree requirements, residency, transfer equivalencies, academic standing, grade rules, regrade policy, graduation, payment-plan eligibility, feature/role/consent eligibility, retention, AI policy. **The AI can explain a rule. The policy engine decides it.**

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_COMPETITIVE_COMPLETION_AUDIT.md`

Competitive completion audit

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

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The decisive advantage is not more features. It is being the easiest to adopt, safest to operate, clearest to use, fastest to implement and most credible to buy.

Core loop

Identity → Path → Action → Learning → Support → Evidence → Progress → Opportunity. Every feature must strengthen at least one node.

Coherence test (release gate for any new feature)

- Who uses it?
- What problem does it solve?

- What source is authoritative?
- What data does it need?
- What action does it create or complete?
- What policy governs it?
- How does it connect to Path, Action Center, Support and Career?
- What happens when it fails?
- What happens when data is stale?
- How is it supported?
- How is it measured?
- How is it rolled back? If the answers are unclear, the feature is not ready.

Audit by area

Area	Current evidence	Benchmark (5)	Customer impact	Priority	Required capability	Test / metric
Daily student experience	ui_kits/student, every-screen, templates/platform-shell	Beats email+LMS+calendar+portal+AI chat combined	Daily return, action completion	P0	Today, Action Center, return loop	Usability test 5 students; first action ≥70%
Product coherence	One design system, 673 screens, one shell	One intuitive system	Fewer dead ends	P0	Coherence test on every feature (below)	Release checklist enforces it
Mobile/native quality	ui_kits/mobile (tab bar)	Native-feeling, reliable	Students judge on phone	P0	Fast shell, offline-safe workspace, deep links, quick capture, low-bandwidth	Lighthouse mobile, offline sync tests
Course Studio and learning	Partly designed (staff kit)	Connected learning environment	Faculty adoption	P1	Course Studio, LTI to LMS	Faculty workflow e2e
Academic records / registrar	Registrar desk designed; SIS stays official	Deterministic, auditable workflows	Correctness	P0	Policy engine for prerequisites, holds, credit limits, windows	Rule tests per policy
Governed AI	Gateway logic + AIResponse	Policy-bound, source-aware	Safety + usefulness	P0	AI trust UI: context, sources, policy, model, uncertainty, action, human	Red-team suite
Institutional trust	Trust Center page, policies, contracts	Evidence-backed procurement	Shorter procurement	P0	Procurement room, HECVAT Lite + Full, questionnaire library, AI provider registry	Reviewer can answer 10 questions unaided
Security/privacy/accessibility	Policies, test plans	Continuous controls	Risk	P0	Evidence register, VDP, ACR	Controls with evidence
Integration factory	Designed workflow	Repeatable interoperability	Implementation speed	P0	LTI wizard, OneRoster import, SSO/SCIM guide, test harness	Connector certification
Migration factory	Designed workflow + cutover	Reusable migration product	Replacement confidence	P1	Mapping studio, reconciliation, rollback automation	0 unexplained mismatches
Reliability/SLO/incidents	Handbook + runbooks	SLO-driven ops	Uptime	P0	Monitoring, status page, alerts	Restore drill time
Implementation and CS	Runbook, support plan	Repeatable implementation	Weeks not months	P0	Implementation factory: questionnaire, tenant templates, role bundles, launch kit	Days signature-to-launch

Area	Current evidence	Benchmark (5)	Customer impact	Priority	Required capability	Test / metric
GTM and pilot conversion	GTM plan, price book	Predictable conversion	Revenue	P1	Pipeline, MAP, results report	Pilot-to-annual
Finance and unit economics	Finance model	Predictable economics	Survival	P1	36-month model, AI cost per workflow	Gross margin
Developer platform/marketplace	Designed workflow	Documented APIs, partners	Ecosystem	P3	API standard, sandbox, certification	Certified apps
Global readiness	US assumptions	Configurable international	Expansion	P3	i18n, calendars, grading, residency	Strings externalized
Research and outcome proof	Results template	Verified evidence	Credibility	P1	Measurement protocol, evidence register	Measures met
Brand and category authority	Brand system, site	Recognized infrastructure brand	Trust	P2	Case study, research, transparent status	References
Company operations	docs/business, /ops	Systems not heroics	Repeatability	P1	Operating cadence, decision log	Cadence held
Organizational maturity	Solo founder	Owners, cadence, resilience	Continuity	P1	Key-person plan, revenue-triggered hires	Owners per function

Top 25 gaps

1. Insurance not bound
2. DPA not signed
3. HECVAT not submitted
4. No ACR
5. No production code for pilot paths
6. RLS untested
7. No monitoring
8. SIS connector not built
9. No reconciliation run
10. AI red-team not run
11. No mobile build
12. No implementation factory assets
13. No procurement room
14. No status page
15. No policy engine
16. No usability test
17. Measures not signed
18. No case study
19. No 36-month model

20. Founder single point of failure
21. No KB/help center
22. No event taxonomy
23. No API standard implemented
24. US-only data model
25. No decision log

What not to do

- Build everything as a separate module
- Make every dashboard dense
- Hide complex policy behind AI
- Collect data just in case
- Make high-impact recommendations opaque
- Overpromise replacement before migration proof
- Make configuration need custom engineering
- Let tenants fork the product
- Use student data for advertising or surveillance
- Let compliance become static PDFs
- Ship without support, monitoring and rollback
- Depend on one AI provider
- Build a closed ecosystem without export
- Scale paid acquisition before pilot conversion works
- Pursue every segment at once

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_COMPETITIVE_MOAT_PLAN.md`

Competitive moat plan

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

Top 25 moats

1. Daily student workspace students prefer over their tool stack
2. Source authority and freshness on every fact
3. Education graph of relationships, not just records
4. Governed AI that is course-, policy- and source-aware

5. Zero student records to AI providers, proven by tests
6. Migration factory that makes replacement safer than staying
7. Reconciliation engine with rollback on every domain
8. Consent and sharing model students trust
9. Tenant isolation proven per table in CI
10. Trust Center with evidence, not claims
11. One design system across product, site and ops
12. Implementation factory: signature to launch in weeks
13. Pilot-to-annual playbook with signed measures
14. Outcome evidence from real cohorts
15. Interoperability with LTI, OneRoster, Edu-API, SIS adapters
16. Developer platform with certification and scoped installs
17. Marketplace governed by the same consent model
18. Company runs on Semester: nobody leaves the product
19. Accessibility as a product feature, not a checkbox
20. Long institutional relationships through renewal evidence
21. Deterministic policy engine: the AI explains a rule, the engine decides it
22. Implementation in weeks, not years
23. Procurement reviewer self-service (no chasing the team)
24. Mobile-first daily loop
25. Hardest to leave because it makes education clearer

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_ECOSYSTEM_AND_MARKETPLACE_PLAN.md`

Ecosystem and marketplace

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> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

- Developer portal, API standards (docs/platform/API_CONTRACT_STANDARD.md)
- OAuth/OIDC, service accounts, webhooks, event subscriptions, SDKs
- Sandbox tenants and test data
- Integration certification
- Marketplace, partner directory, tenant install approval, data-scope review
- Revenue sharing (12% planning), versioning/deprecation, partner support and incidents

Flywheel: more institutions → partner demand → integrations → platform value → institutional demand. Post-pilot priority (P3 now).

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_GLOBAL_PLATFORM_ROADMAP.md`

Global platform roadmap

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> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

- Internationalization, localization, RTL
- Time zones, academic calendars, term structures
- Currency/tax abstraction, regional payments
- Regional data residency, hosting, subprocessors
- Regional privacy and accessibility law
- Local identity systems
- Different credential and grading models
- Government reporting requirements
- Local support and implementation

Do not hardcode US higher-ed assumptions into the education graph. See docs/platform/GLOBAL_EXPANSION_ARCHITECTURE.md.

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_IMPLEMENTATION_FACTORY.md`

Implementation factory

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> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

Sales hand-off → tenant template → SSO → roster/data mapping → policy configuration → admin training → user communication → controlled launch → adoption monitoring → pilot review → annual conversion.

Accelerators

- Institution onboarding questionnaire
- Tenant templates by segment
- Prebuilt policies and role bundles
- Course/program mapping templates
- LTI setup wizard
- OneRoster import wizard
- SSO/SCIM setup guide
- Integration test harness
- Data mapping studio

- Reconciliation dashboard
- Admin training academy
- Launch communications generator
- Pilot dashboard
- Implementation checklist and go-live gate
- Common support playbooks
- Rollback and offboarding automation

Promise: powerful enough for a university, straightforward enough to launch a useful workflow in weeks, not years.

Existing: docs/launch/ (runbook, cutover, support), templates/role-onboarding/, workflow runner (Institution implementation).

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_MIGRATION_FACTORY.md`

Migration factory

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

See docs/platform/INTEGRATION_AND_MIGRATION_FACTORY.md and the 17-step Domain migration workflow in ui_kits/workflow-runner. Replacement only with reconciliation evidence and institutional approval.

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_MOBILE_EXCELLENCE_PLAN.md`

Mobile excellence plan

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

- Fast mobile shell
- Offline-safe student-owned workspace
- Push notifications with explicit preference controls
- Deep links from email, calendar, QR codes, announcements
- Native-feeling gestures, never gesture-only critical functions
- Mobile-first Action Center
- Quick capture: tasks, notes, assignments, photos/documents where permitted
- Fast course/resource access; campus QR flows
- Location only with explicit opt-in and clear benefit
- Low-bandwidth and reduced-data modes
- Accessible mobile controls

- Minimum safe offline data; clear sync state and conflict recovery

Never cache on device unnecessarily: official grades, financial records, sensitive support details, secrets, privileged institutional data.

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_OUTCOME_PROOF_PROGRAM.md`

Outcome proof program

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

Build

- Outcome metric catalog
- Research governance
- Baseline methodology and cohort definition
- Pilot measurement protocol
- Experiment registry and survey system
- Student confidence, action-completion and support-friction measures
- Faculty workload and implementation measures
- Case-study approval workflow
- Research partnership program
- Whitepaper pipeline
- Customer evidence register

Proof hierarchy

Product usage → workflow completion → student-reported clarity → staff efficiency → pilot outcome → annual conversion → expansion → independent research → sector authority.

Do not jump from a few happy quotes to broad outcome claims.

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_PLATFORM_MATURITY_SCORECARD.md`

Competitive scorecard (quarterly)

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

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Dimension	0 means	5 means	Now
Student daily value	Rarely useful	Preferred daily education workspace	2
Product coherence	Disconnected modules	One intuitive system	2
Mobile quality	Desktop port	Native-feeling, reliable mobile	1
Learning quality	Content container	Connected learning with evidence	1
AI quality	Generic chat wrapper	Policy-bound, source-aware intelligence	2
Academic authority	Informal planning	Deterministic, auditable official workflows	1
Institutional trust	Marketing claims	Evidence-backed procurement readiness	1
Security/privacy	Reactive	Continuous controls and governance	1
Accessibility	Patchwork	Embedded design/release discipline	2
Integration	One-off integrations	Repeatable interoperability factory	1
Migration	Manual project work	Reusable migration product	1
Reliability	Best effort	SLO-driven, incident-ready	1
Customer success	Reactive support	Repeatable implementation and renewal	1
Commercial maturity	Ad hoc pricing	Predictable unit economics and deal governance	2
Developer ecosystem	Closed product	Documented APIs, marketplace, partners	0
Global readiness	Local assumptions	Configurable international architecture	0
Outcome proof	Anecdotes	Verified measurable evidence	1
Brand trust	Unknown	Recognized education infrastructure brand	1
Organizational maturity	Founder heroics	Owners, cadence, systems, resilience	1

Average now: 1.16 / 5. Detailed 24-dimension scorecard: docs/platform/PLATFORM_READINESS_SCORECARD.md.

`docs/strategy/SEMESTER_TRUST_ADVANTAGE_PLAN.md`

Trust advantage plan

Semester strategy · 2026-10-05 · Source: uploads/anything else to finish semester and make it the m.pdf. Design-stage evidence only; scores rise with repo, test and release evidence.

> Semester wins when students prefer it daily, institutions trust it operationally, and partners prefer building on it.

Build

- Public Trust Center (ui_kits/company-site #/trust)
- Controlled procurement room
- HECVAT Lite readiness and Full evidence roadmap

- Security questionnaire library
- Data-flow and architecture diagrams (ui_kits/architecture)
- Subprocessor and AI provider registries
- Accessibility roadmap and statement
- DPA workflow, SLA/support policy
- Status page and incident communication policy
- Vulnerability disclosure program
- Data export/deletion and tenant offboarding processes

A procurement reviewer answers unaided

- What data does Semester use, and not collect?
- Where does data go?
- Which AI providers receive what data?
- How are roles and permissions controlled?
- How can we turn off a feature?
- What happens in an incident?
- How does data leave Semester?
- How is accessibility supported?
- How do we migrate or offboard?

How to run Semester

Everything the company does — business, sales, marketing, product, engineering, security, success, support and people — with owners, cadence and the evidence that shows it is done. A planning document, not legal, tax or financial advice.

1. What Semester is, in one paragraph

Semester is the student action platform: one daily workspace that turns a student's semester into the next clear step, with the source of every fact shown beside it. It works alongside a school's official systems, sells to universities through paid one-term pilots, and keeps student records out of AI providers. Today it is a solo-founder LLC, bootstrapping, with one paid university pilot signed.

2. The operating system on one page

FUNCTION	OWNER NOW	WEEKLY OUTPUT	LIVES IN
Company & legal	Founder + counsel	Open legal items reviewed	Business workspace → Launch checklist
Finance	Founder + accountant	Cash, burn, invoices	Bookkeeping system + 12-month model
Sales	Founder	Pipeline review, next steps per account	CRM (any) + Go-to-market tab
Marketing	Founder	One proof-backed piece shipped	Company site + claims register
Product	Founder	Prioritised backlog, one decision logged	DECISIONS.md, Atlas, Role lens
Engineering	Founder + contractors	Shipped PRs, green gate list	GitHub, CI, CLAUDE.md
Security & privacy	Founder	Access review, alerts triaged	Evidence register, Trust Center
Customer success	Founder	Pilot KPIs, check-in notes	Pilot checklist, mutual action plan
Support	Founder	Tickets closed, SLA met	Support queue (console)
People	Founder	Contractor capacity vs. plan	Hiring plan

3. Weekly operating cadence

DAY	RITUAL	TIME	OUTPUT
Monday	Plan the week: top 3 company outcomes	45 min	Written in DECISIONS.md / notes
Monday	Pipeline + pilot KPI review	30 min	Next step and date per account
Wednesday	Engineering review: shipped, blocked, risks	30 min	Updated backlog
Thursday	Pilot check-in with champion	30 min	Notes + actions
Friday	Metrics, cash, risk register	45 min	One-page weekly brief
Monthly	Close books, access review, claims review	2 h	P&L, access log, approved claims
Quarterly	Strategy + roadmap reset, tabletop exercise	Half day	New 90-day plan, IR record

4. Business: legal, finance, insurance

ITEM	DO	EVIDENCE
Entity	Keep the LLC; plan the Delaware C-corp conversion before any priced round	Counsel memo
IP	Company owns everything; founder + contractor assignments on file	Signed assignments
Tax + banking	EIN, state registrations, business bank, approval rules	Registrations, bank account
Bookkeeping	Monthly close checklist, expense policy, tax calendar	Monthly P&L, balance sheet, cash flow
Model	36-month driver model: pilots → annual, cost per active user, runway	Spreadsheet with scenarios
Pricing	Pilot quoted; platform $18 / enrolled student / yr, $30k floor (planning)	Approved price book + discount rules
Insurance	Cyber + E&O before real student records; general liability	Certificates sent to the university
Contracts	MSA, order form, DPA/FERPA addendum, SLA, NDA	Versioned, counsel-reviewed templates

5. Sales: from target to annual contract

STAGE	EXIT CRITERIA	KPI
Target	Tier-1 list, named champion	Accounts researched
Discovery	Pain, owner, budget, timeline confirmed	Qualification rate
Demo	Champion agrees success metrics	Demo → design rate
Pilot design	Scope, data, integrations signed off	Design → proposal
Security/legal	HECVAT, DPA, VPAT path agreed	Days in review
Proposal	Mutual action plan with decision date	Proposal → signature
Pilot	Activation + weekly KPIs	KPI attainment
Conversion	Results deck → annual order form	Pilot → annual rate
Expansion	New department or cohort; reference	Net revenue retention

6. Marketing: what to say and how to prove it

ASSET	PURPOSE	RULE
Company site	Home, Pilot, Pricing, Trust, Company	Status map: use now / in a pilot / later
Pilot one-pager + institution deck	Book design sessions	Scope + what stays official
Trust Center	Answer security and accessibility first	Status, never certifications not held
Case study (after pilot)	Prove outcomes	Measured baseline, method, sponsor approval
Founder posts / talks	Category voice	Claims register before publishing
Email list	Institution leaders only	Opt-in, one-click unsubscribe
Voice	Plain, specific, calm	Say “AI-assisted, source-linked”; never “revolutionise”, “guaranteed”, “compliant”
FTC	Testimonials, endorsements, statistics	Consent, disclosure, evidence for every claim

7. Product

PRACTICE	HOW
North star	Students who complete their next action each week
Spine	Five destinations: Today · My Path · Search · Plan · Me; seven areas, 64 screens
Trust	Every fact labelled official / connected / yours / AI-assisted
Decisions	One decision per PR, numbered, in DECISIONS.md
Discovery	Weekly: one student and one staff conversation
Roadmap	Pilot obligations first, then what moves the conversion metric
Design system	This project: tokens, 49 components, templates; never raw values

8. Engineering

AREA	STANDARD
Stack	Vite + React (app), Next.js + Supabase (workflow lab), Vercel hosting
Gate	npx tsc -b · npm run lint · npm test · npm run build · design-system:check
Data	Postgres + RLS per tenant; migrations reviewed; no service key in the browser
Integrations	LTI 1.3, OneRoster, SIS read; SAML / Shibboleth SSO
Read models	Outbox → projections with version + freshness; capability-checked RPCs
AI	Gateway: scope, policy, routing, citations, logs; student records never sent
Quality	Contract tests for tokens, contrast, targets, motion; revert-to-red proof
Release	Feature flags per tenant, staged rollout, rollback plan
Observability	Error + uptime monitoring, audit log, alert runbook

9. Security, privacy and accessibility

CONTROL	MINIMUM BEFORE LAUNCH
Identity	MFA on admin, code, cloud, finance, CRM, support, production
Access	Least privilege, quarterly review, contractor offboarding
Data	Encryption in transit/at rest, backups, tested restore with RTO/RPO
Vendors	Subprocessor list (Vercel, Supabase), vendor register
Incidents	IR plan, tabletop, breach notification path per DPA
Procurement	HECVAT Full, answer library, DPA/SLA path
Accessibility	WCAG 2.2 AA target, ACR/VPAT, manual test protocol, statement

10. Customer success and support

PRACTICE	STANDARD
Onboarding	Admin setup, SSO, invitations, baseline recorded
Severity	P0 outage · P1 data issue · P2 degraded · P3 question
Response	P0 1 h · P1 4 h · P2 1 business day · P3 2 business days (pilot target)
Cadence	Weekly KPI check-in; mid-pilot review; results review before decision date

PRACTICE	STANDARD
Feedback	Tagged, linked to backlog, answered

11. People

WHEN	ROLE	TRIGGER
Now	Fractional counsel, insurance broker, bookkeeper	Pilot obligations
After pilot launch	Implementation / support contractor	Support > founder capacity
After 2nd paid customer	First full-time engineer	Two institutions live
After 3–5 customers	Founding sales / CS hire	Pipeline > founder capacity

12. Company scorecard

METRIC	WHY
Cash + runway (months)	Survival
Pilot KPI attainment	Conversion readiness
Pilot → annual conversion	Commercial proof
Qualified pipeline (accounts)	Next customers
Weekly active students + next-action completion	Product value
P0/P1 incidents, SLA met	Trust
Open P0 launch items	Readiness

13. Path to a real company

STAGE	DONE WHEN
Now → launch	Six pilot blockers closed: insurance ×2, DPA mapping, HECVAT, SSO, VPAT
Pilot running	Weekly KPIs, onboarding live, support SLA met
First renewal	Results deck, annual order form signed
Repeatable	2–3 institutions; price book; references
Raise or keep bootstrapping	Decide with pilot results; convert to C-corp if raising
Team	First engineer, then sales/CS; operating cadence unchanged

What to finish before real student records arrive

Prepared for the founder, team, counsel/accountant, institution buyers and investors. Status is inferred from repository documents where evidence exists and from founder answers otherwise; “Not confirmed — verify” marks items neither could confirm. This is a planning document, not legal or financial advice — have counsel, an accountant and an insurance broker review the items they own.

1. Situation

FACT	VALUE
entity	LLC (home state)
stage	Pre-seed, no revenue, bootstrapping
team	Solo founder; contractors with signed IP assignments
pilot	Paid university pilot signed — DPA/FERPA addendum, HECVAT Full, VPAT/ACR, SAML SSO, cyber + E&O insurance required; real student records; dates not decided
hosting	Vercel + Supabase; AI never sees student records
budget	$5k–$20k setup budget

Six launch blockers. The signed paid pilot requires cyber + E&O insurance, a DPA/FERPA mapping, HECVAT Full, SAML SSO and a VPAT/ACR before real student records arrive. 23 P0 items remain open in total. Pilot start and renewal-decision dates are not set — agree them in a mutual action plan first.

2. Gap analysis — open P0 items

AREA	GAP	BLOCKS	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Formation	EIN, state/local tax registrations	Before invoicing the pilot	Not started	Not confirmed — verify
Formation	Dedicated business bank + payments account	Before pilot invoice	Not started	Not confirmed — verify
Insurance	Cyber liability	Pilot contract requires it	Not started	Required by pilot; not held

AREA	GAP	BLOCKS	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Insurance	Professional / E&O	Pilot contract requires it	Not started	Required by pilot; not held
Contracts	Data Processing Addendum / FERPA addendum	Before real student records	In review	Pilot has DPA/FERPA addendum — confirm obligations mapped
Privacy	Privacy Policy + Terms of Service	Before student sign-in	Draft	docs/legal-drafts/
Privacy	Subprocessor list (Vercel, Supabase, AI provider)	DPA requires it	Not started	Hosting: Vercel + Supabase
Privacy	Data inventory + data-flow map (student records)	Before real data	In progress	database/DATA_CLASSIFICATION_REGISTER.md
Privacy	Retention + deletion schedule	DPA / HECVAT	Not started	—
Privacy	AI boundary: student records never reach an AI provider — enforce + document	HECVAT, DPA	In progress	Policy decided; needs a test + doc
Security	HECVAT Full completed	University security review	Not started	Required by pilot
Security	University SSO (SAML / Shibboleth)	Pilot launch	Not started	Required by pilot
Security	Access-control + least-privilege policy	HECVAT	In progress	database/TENANT_ISOLATION_MATRIX.md, RLS
Security	Incident response plan + tabletop	HECVAT	Draft	docs/INCIDENT-RECOVERY-PLAYBOOK.md
Security	Backup + disaster-recovery runbook (tested)	HECVAT	Draft	docs/sre/
Accessibility	VPAT / ACR (WCAG 2.1 AA)	Pilot contract requires it	Not started	a11y tests exist; no ACR
Finance	Bookkeeping + accounting system	Before pilot invoice	Not started	—
Finance	Pilot invoice + revenue recognition	Pilot start	Not started	Paid pilot
Sales	Pilot success plan + baseline metrics	Pilot start	Not started	Pilot dates not decided

AREA	GAP	BLOCKS	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Sales	Mutual action plan with named decision date	Pilot start	Not started	Renewal date not decided
Customer success	Onboarding plan for pilot users	Pilot start	Not started	—
Customer success	Support intake, severity levels, response times	Pilot start	Not started	—
Customer success	Weekly pilot check-in + KPI review	Pilot start	Not started	—

3. Master checklist

Formation

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
1	LLC formed in home state, operating agreement signed	Founder	P0	Done	Before any contract
2	EIN, state/local tax registrations	Founder + accountant	P0	Not started	Before invoicing the pilot
3	Dedicated business bank + payments account	Founder	P0	Not started	Before pilot invoice
4	Corporate records folder + contract repository	Founder	P1	Not started	Before diligence
5	Cap table (single-member LLC; record any promised equity)	Founder	P1	Not started	Before advisors/hires
6	IP assignment from founder + every contractor	Founder + counsel	P0	Done	Before code ships to customer
7	Trademark / name clearance for “Semester”	Counsel	P1	Not started	Before public launch
8	Decision: convert LLC → Delaware C-corp	Founder + counsel	P2	Deferred	Before priced equity round

Insurance

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
9	Cyber liability	Founder + broker	P0	Not started	Pilot contract requires it
10	Professional / E&O	Founder + broker	P0	Not started	Pilot contract requires it
11	General liability	Founder + broker	P1	Not started	Campus presence

Contracts

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
12	Pilot agreement (signed)	Founder	P0	Done	—
13	Data Processing Addendum / FERPA addendum	Counsel	P0	In review	Before real student records
14	Master Services Agreement + SaaS terms	Counsel	P1	Draft	Before annual conversion
15	Order form + SOW template	Founder	P1	Not started	Annual proposal
16	Service Level Agreement / support policy	Founder	P1	Draft	Annual conversion
17	Mutual NDA	Counsel	P2	Not started	New prospects

Privacy

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
18	Privacy Policy + Terms of Service	Counsel	P0	Draft	Before student sign-in
19	Subprocessor list (Vercel, Supabase, AI provider)	Founder	P0	Not started	DPA requires it
20	Data inventory + data-flow map (student records)	Founder	P0	In progress	Before real data
21	Retention + deletion schedule	Founder	P0	Not started	DPA / HECVAT
22	AI boundary: student records never reach an AI provider — enforce + document	Founder	P0	In progress	HECVAT, DPA

Security

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
23	HECVAT Full completed	Founder	P0	Not started	University security review
24	Security questionnaire answer library	Founder	P1	Not started	HECVAT, RFPs
25	University SSO (SAML / Shibboleth)	Engineering	P0	Not started	Pilot launch
26	Access-control + least-privilege policy	Founder	P0	In progress	HECVAT
27	Incident response plan + tabletop	Founder	P0	Draft	HECVAT
28	Backup + disaster-recovery runbook (tested)	Engineering	P0	Draft	HECVAT
29	Vulnerability management + dependency scanning	Engineering	P1	In progress	HECVAT
30	Logging + monitoring policy	Engineering	P1	In progress	HECVAT
31	Evidence register mapped to controls	Founder	P1	In progress	HECVAT
32	Penetration-test plan	Founder	P2	Not started	After first renewal
33	Trust Center page (verified controls only)	Founder	P1	Not started	Procurement

Accessibility

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
34	VPAT / ACR (WCAG 2.1 AA)	Founder	P0	Not started	Pilot contract requires it
35	Accessibility statement + feedback route	Founder	P1	Not started	Public launch

Finance

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
36	Bookkeeping + accounting system	Founder + accountant	P0	Not started	Before pilot invoice

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
37	Pilot invoice + revenue recognition	Founder	P0	Not started	Pilot start
38	12-month model: burn, runway, scenarios	Founder	P1	Not started	Bootstrapped planning
39	Unit costs: infra + AI cost per active user	Founder	P1	Not started	Pricing
40	Pricing memo: pilot → department → institution	Founder	P1	Draft	Annual proposal

Sales

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
41	Ideal customer profile + tier-1 account list	Founder	P1	Not started	Second pilot
42	Discovery + demo scripts by persona	Founder	P1	Not started	Second pilot
43	Pilot success plan + baseline metrics	Founder + champion	P0	Not started	Pilot start
44	Mutual action plan with named decision date	Founder + champion	P0	Not started	Pilot start
45	Results deck + annual conversion proposal	Founder	P1	Not started	Before renewal decision
46	Security/procurement response kit	Founder	P1	Not started	Second pilot

Customer success

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
47	Onboarding plan for pilot users	Founder	P0	Not started	Pilot start
48	Support intake, severity levels, response times	Founder	P0	Not started	Pilot start
49	Weekly pilot check-in + KPI review	Founder	P0	Not started	Pilot start
50	QBR / renewal process	Founder	P1	Not started	Mid-pilot

Operations

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
51	Weekly operating cadence + decision log	Founder	P1	In progress	Ongoing
52	Risk register (owner, mitigation, review)	Founder	P1	In progress	Ongoing
53	Public claims approval register	Founder	P1	In progress	Any marketing

Hiring

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
54	Contractor onboarding/offboarding (access, IP, NDA)	Founder	P1	Not started	Next contractor
55	First hire profile + trigger	Founder	P2	Not started	Second paid customer

Fundraising

#	ITEM	OWNER	PRI	STATUS	LAUNCH GATE
56	Fundraising readiness checklist	Founder	P2	Deferred	When raising

4. 90-day roadmap

Days 1–30 · Make the pilot legal to run

1. Bind cyber + E&O insurance (contract requirement)
2. EIN, state tax registration, business bank, bookkeeping
3. Map every DPA/FERPA obligation to a control and an owner
4. Publish subprocessor list: Vercel, Supabase (+ AI provider, with "no student records" boundary)
5. Data inventory + data-flow map for student records
6. Retention + deletion schedule
7. Test that student records never reach an AI provider; document it

Days 31–60 · Pass the university reviews

1. Complete HECVAT Full from docs/trust + evidence register
2. Ship SAML / Shibboleth SSO with the university IdP
3. VPAT / ACR against WCAG 2.1 AA (use existing a11y tests as evidence)
4. Incident-response tabletop; record it
5. Restore-from-backup test; record RTO/RPO
6. Privacy Policy + Terms reviewed by counsel

Days 61–90 · Launch and prove the pilot

1. Agree pilot start + renewal decision dates in a mutual action plan
2. Baseline the success metrics with the champion
3. Onboarding + support intake with severity levels
4. Weekly check-in and KPI review
5. Draft the results deck and annual conversion proposal

5. Pilot / contract checklist

OBLIGATION	OWNER	STATUS	EVIDENCE
EIN, state/local tax registrations	Founder + accountant	Not started	Not confirmed — verify
Dedicated business bank + payments account	Founder	Not started	Not confirmed — verify
Cyber liability	Founder + broker	Not started	Required by pilot; not held
Professional / E&O	Founder + broker	Not started	Required by pilot; not held

OBLIGATION	OWNER	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Pilot agreement (signed)	Founder	Done	Paid pilot signed
Data Processing Addendum / FERPA addendum	Counsel	In review	Pilot has DPA/FERPA addendum — confirm obligations mapped
Privacy Policy + Terms of Service	Counsel	Draft	docs/legal-drafts/
Subprocessor list (Vercel, Supabase, AI provider)	Founder	Not started	Hosting: Vercel + Supabase
Data inventory + data-flow map (student records)	Founder	In progress	database/DATA_CLASSIFICATION_REGISTER.md
Retention + deletion schedule	Founder	Not started	—
AI boundary: student records never reach an AI provider — enforce + document	Founder	In progress	Policy decided; needs a test + doc
HECVAT Full completed	Founder	Not started	Required by pilot
Security questionnaire answer library	Founder	Not started	docs/trust/ (66 files) as source
University SSO (SAML / Shibboleth)	Engineering	Not started	Required by pilot
Access-control + least-privilege policy	Founder	In progress	database/TENANT_ISOLATION_MATRIX.md, RLS
Incident response plan + tabletop	Founder	Draft	docs/INCIDENT-RECOVERY-PLAYBOOK.md
Backup + disaster-recovery runbook (tested)	Engineering	Draft	docs/sre/
Vulnerability management + dependency scanning	Engineering	In progress	codeql.yml, supply-chain.yml, hawkscan.yml
Logging + monitoring policy	Engineering	In progress	production-smoke.yml
Evidence register mapped to controls	Founder	In progress	EVIDENCE-REGISTER.md
VPAT / ACR (WCAG 2.1 AA)	Founder	Not started	a11y tests exist; no ACR
Bookkeeping + accounting system	Founder + accountant	Not started	—
Pilot invoice + revenue recognition	Founder	Not started	Paid pilot

OBLIGATION	OWNER	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Pricing memo: pilot → department → institution	Founder	Draft	PUBLIC-CLAIMS register: prices “planned”
Ideal customer profile + tier-1 account list	Founder	Not started	—
Discovery + demo scripts by persona	Founder	Not started	—
Pilot success plan + baseline metrics	Founder + champion	Not started	Pilot dates not decided
Mutual action plan with named decision date	Founder + champion	Not started	Renewal date not decided
Security/procurement response kit	Founder	Not started	—
Onboarding plan for pilot users	Founder	Not started	—
Support intake, severity levels, response times	Founder	Not started	—
Weekly pilot check-in + KPI review	Founder	Not started	—
QBR / renewal process	Founder	Not started	—

6. Risk register

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	IMPACT	MITIGATION	OWNER
Pilot starts without required insurance	High	High	Bind cyber + E&O in days 1–30; send certificate to the university	Founder
HECVAT Full not complete → security review stalls	High	High	Start from docs/trust; answer only verified controls; book a review call	Founder
SAML SSO not ready for launch	Medium	High	Prioritise SSO in days 31–60; test with the university IdP early	Engineering
Student record exposure / breach	Low	Critical	RLS + tenant isolation tests, least privilege, IR plan, AI boundary test	Founder
VPAT gaps found late	Medium	Medium	Run ACR early; fix blockers before launch; disclose known gaps	Founder
No decision date → pilot drifts, no conversion	High	High	Mutual action plan with named economic buyer and decision date	Founder

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	IMPACT	MITIGATION	OWNER
Solo-founder capacity	High	Medium	Use budget for counsel/broker/accountant; contractors with IP + NDA; defer P2	Founder
Claims outrun evidence in marketing	Medium	Medium	Public claims register; no "secure/compliant" without evidence	Founder

7. Hiring plan

WHEN	ROLE	TYPE	TRIGGER
Now	Fractional counsel (DPA, MSA, privacy)	Contract	Pilot obligations
Now	Insurance broker	Contract	Cyber + E&O
Now	Bookkeeper / accountant	Contract	First invoice
After pilot launch	Implementation / support contractor	Contract	Pilot support load > founder capacity
After second paid customer	First full-time engineer	Hire	Two institutions live

8. Fundraising readiness (deferred — bootstrapping)

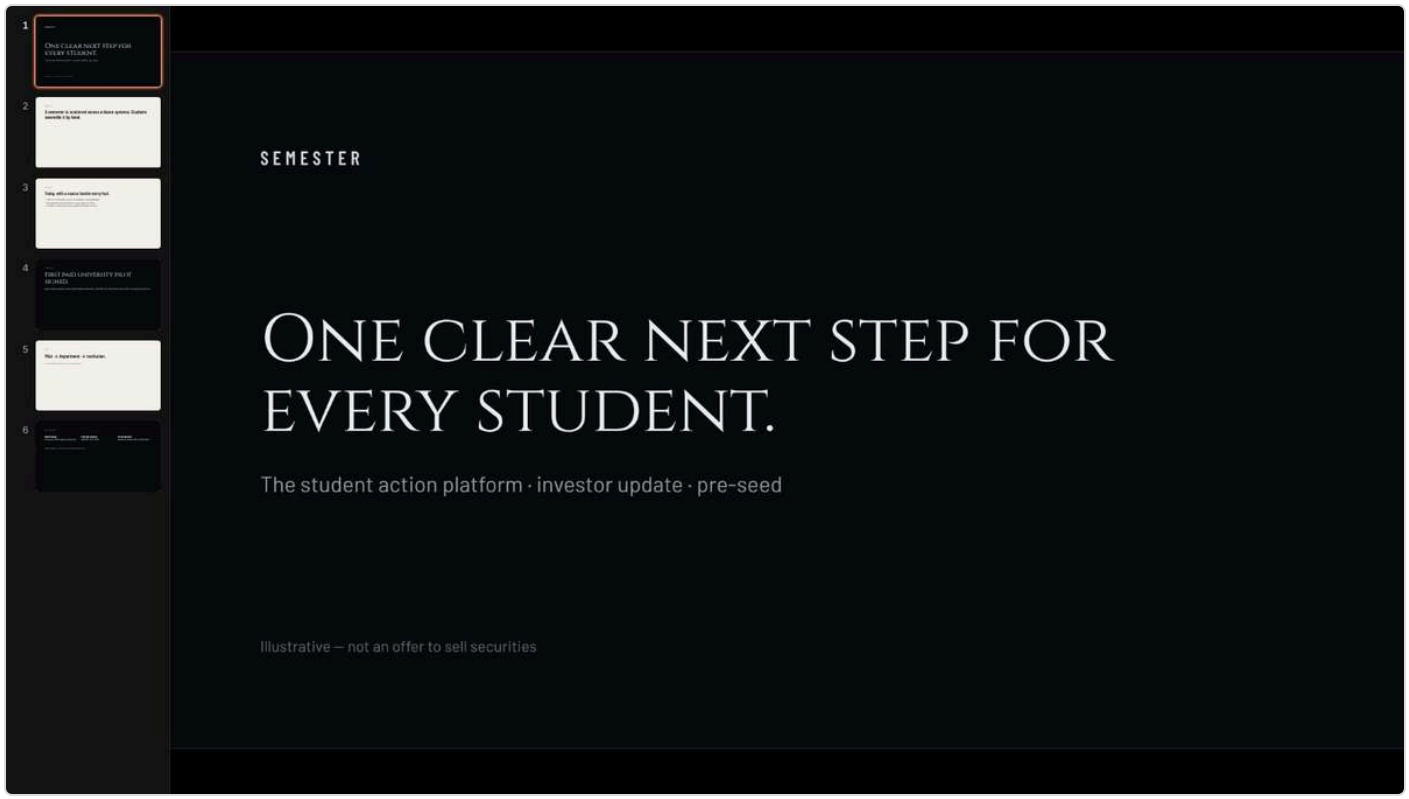
ITEM	STATE
Decide raise vs. bootstrap after pilot results	Deferred
Convert LLC → Delaware C-corp before a priced round	Deferred
Clean cap table + IP chain	Ready (IP signed)
Data room: contracts, security, financials	Not started
Investor deck from pilot results	Draft (this kit)
12-month model with scenarios	Not started

9. What was not covered

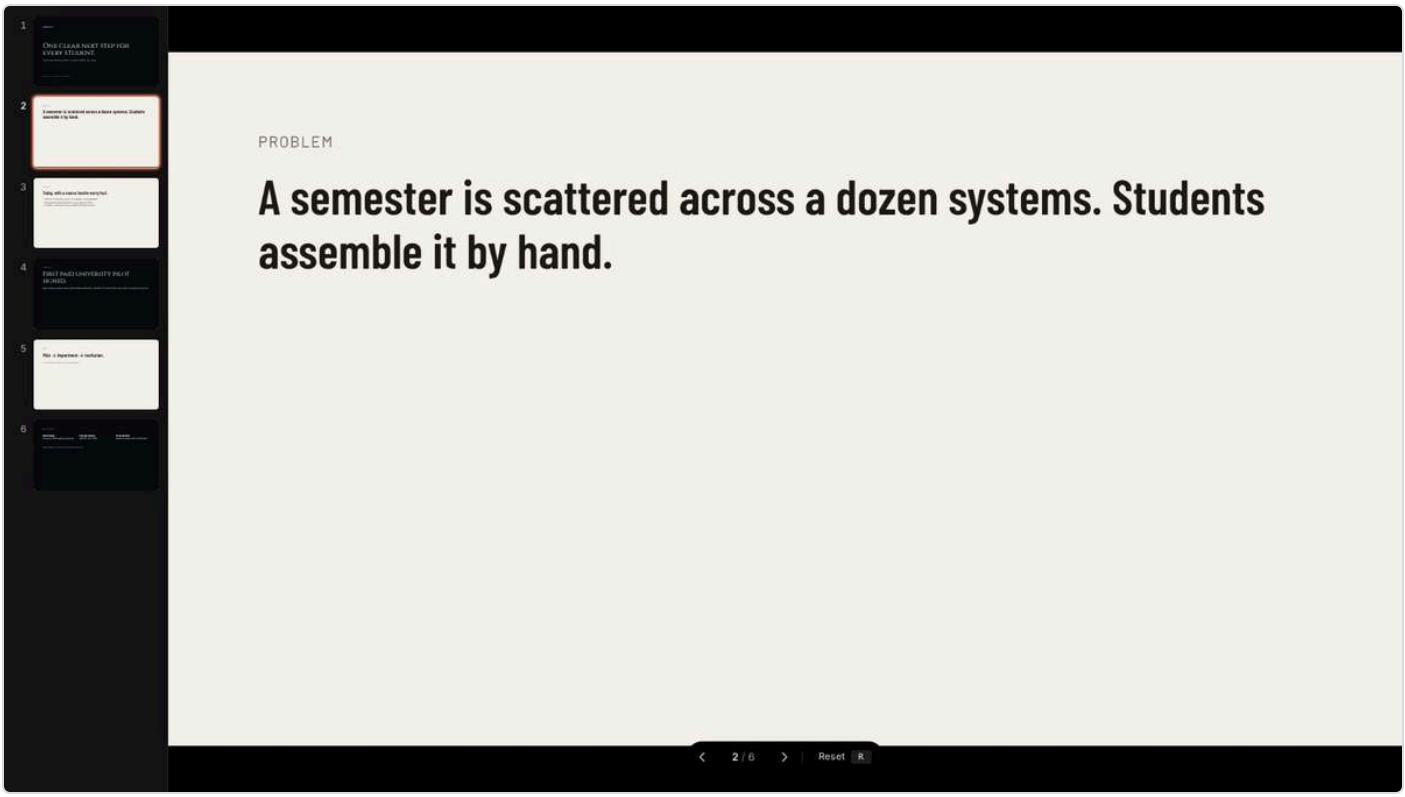
- State-specific registrations for the home-state LLC — confirm with the accountant.
- Exact insurance limits — take them from the pilot contract.
- HECVAT answers — complete only from verified controls; never claim certifications not held.

Investor deck

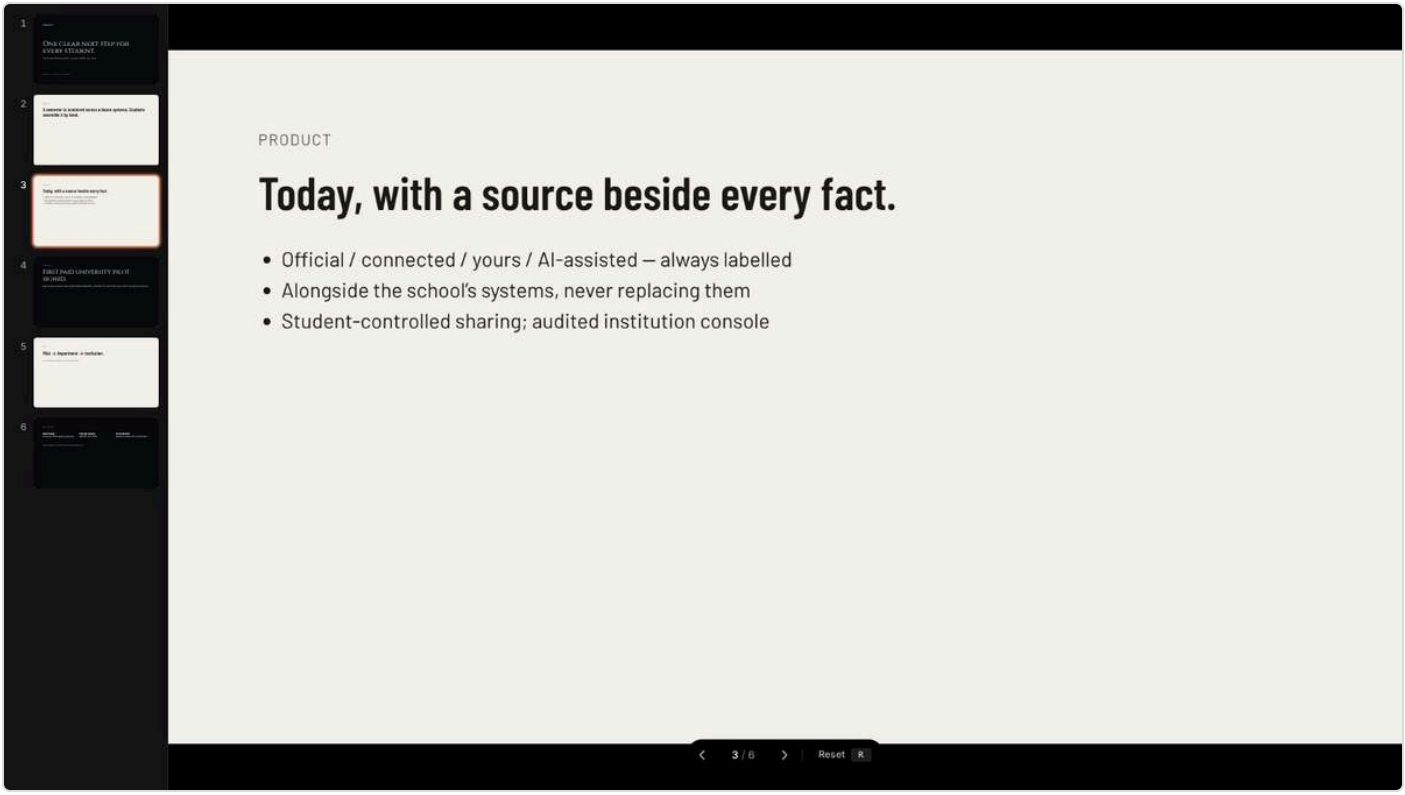
Every slide, rendered from the deck template. **6 screens.**



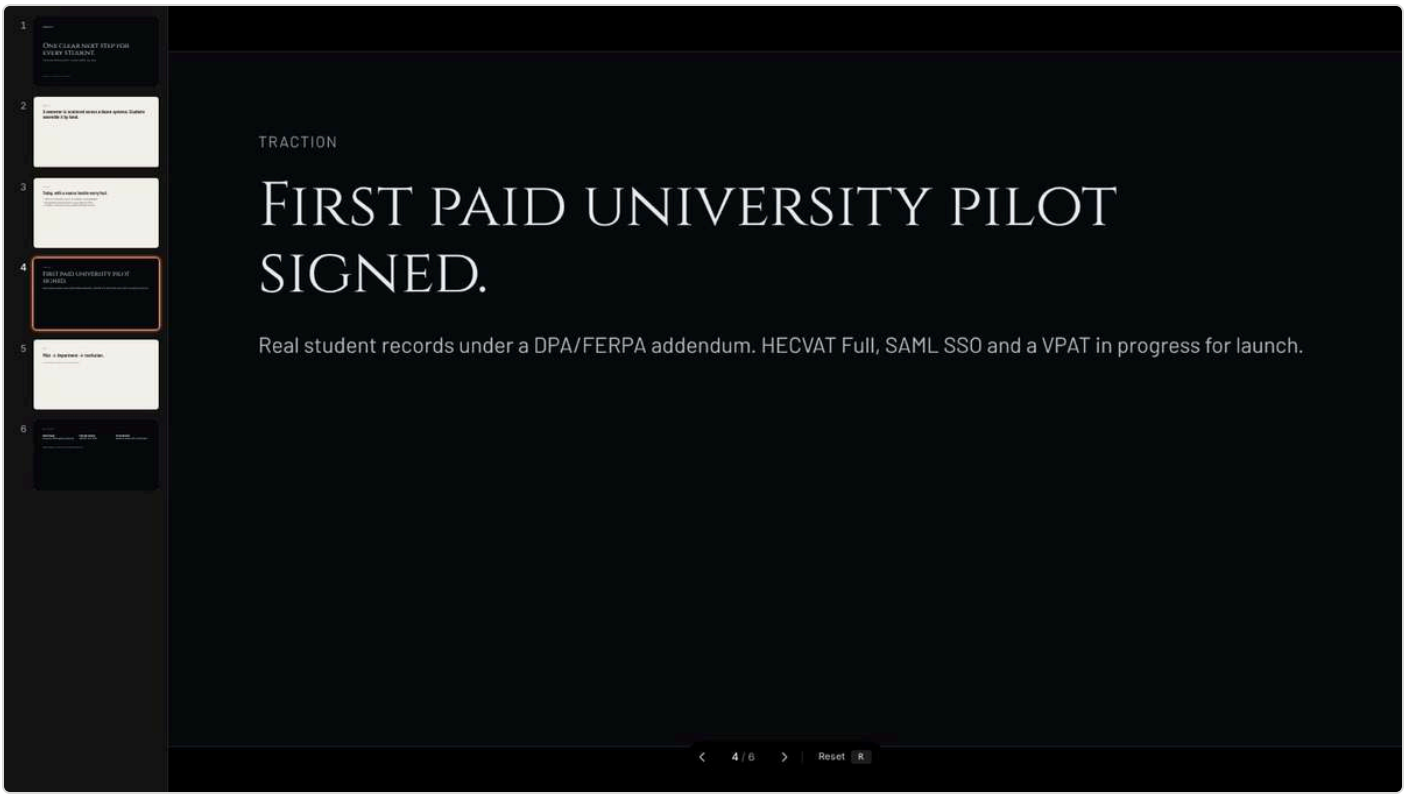
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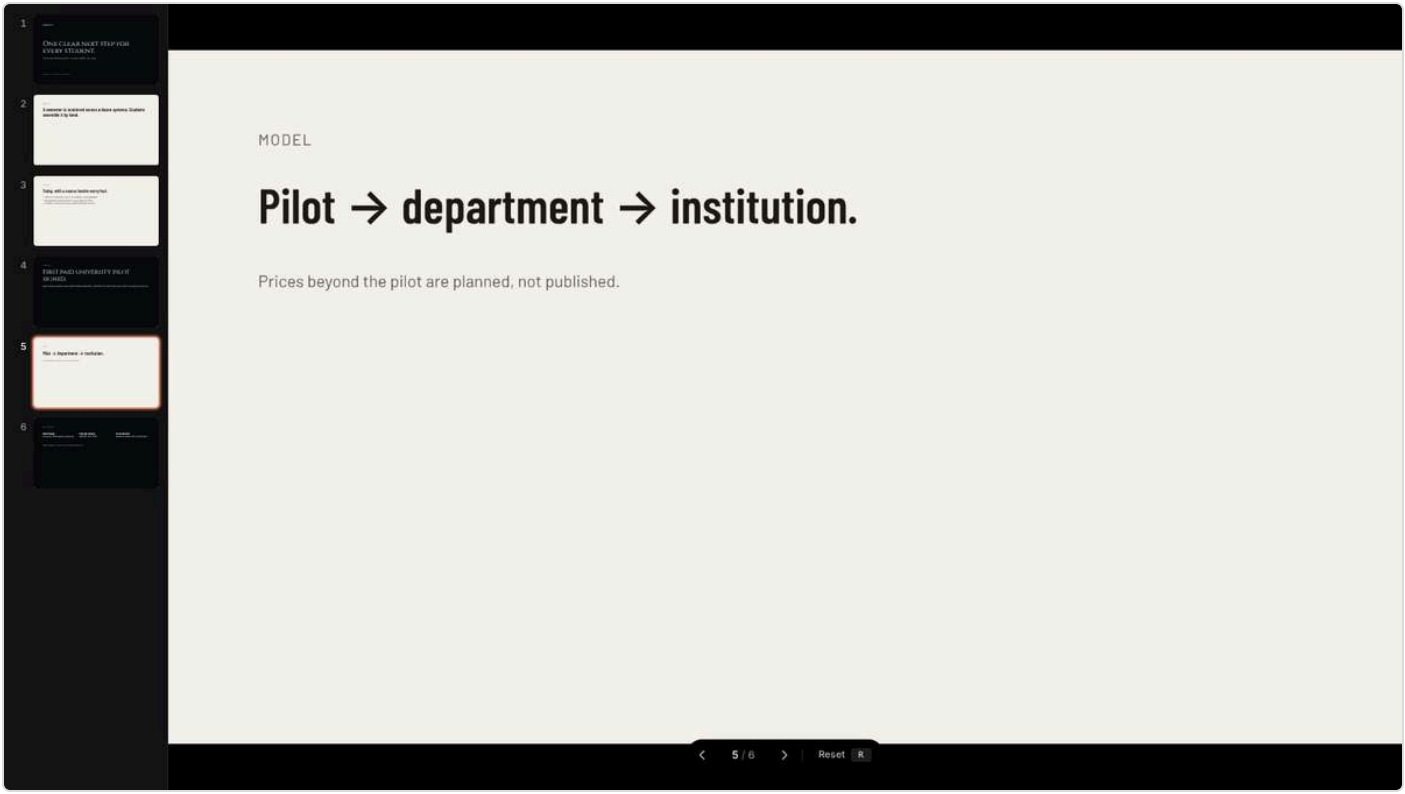
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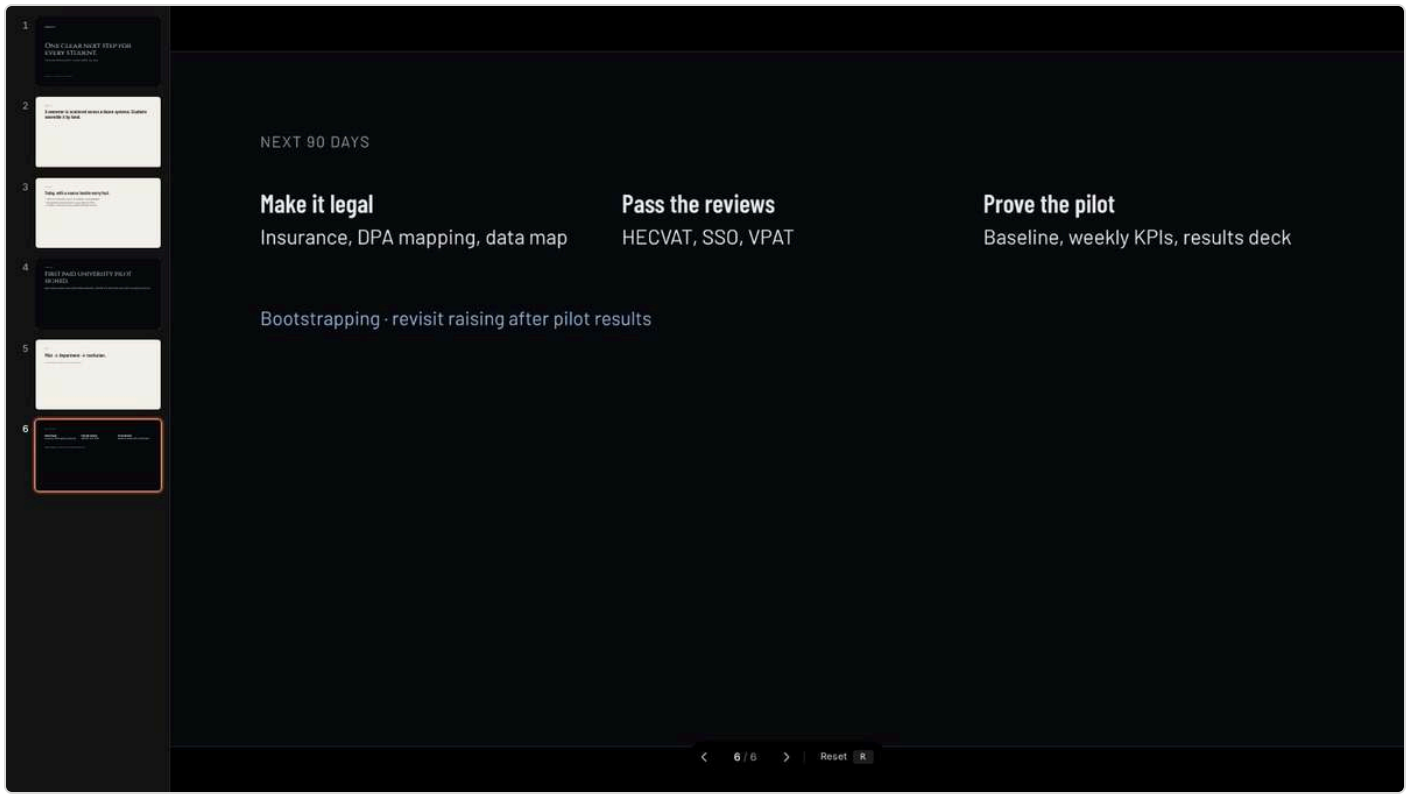
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Slide 4



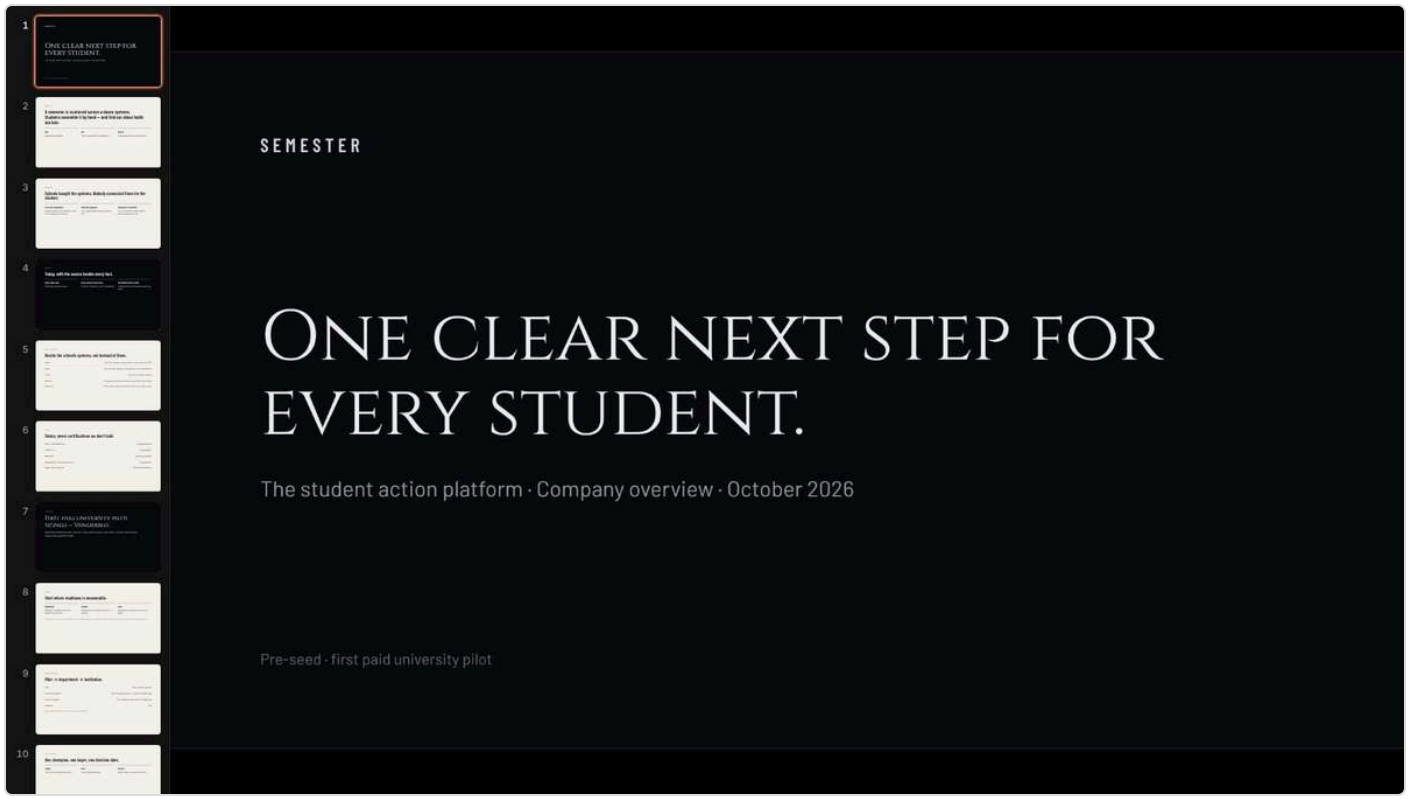
Slide 5


NEXT 90 DAYS
Make it legal
Insurance, DPA mapping, data map
Pass the reviews
HECVAT, SSO, VPAT
Prove the pilot
Baseline, weekly KPIs, results deck
Bootstrapping · revisit raising after pilot results
6 / 6
Reset
R

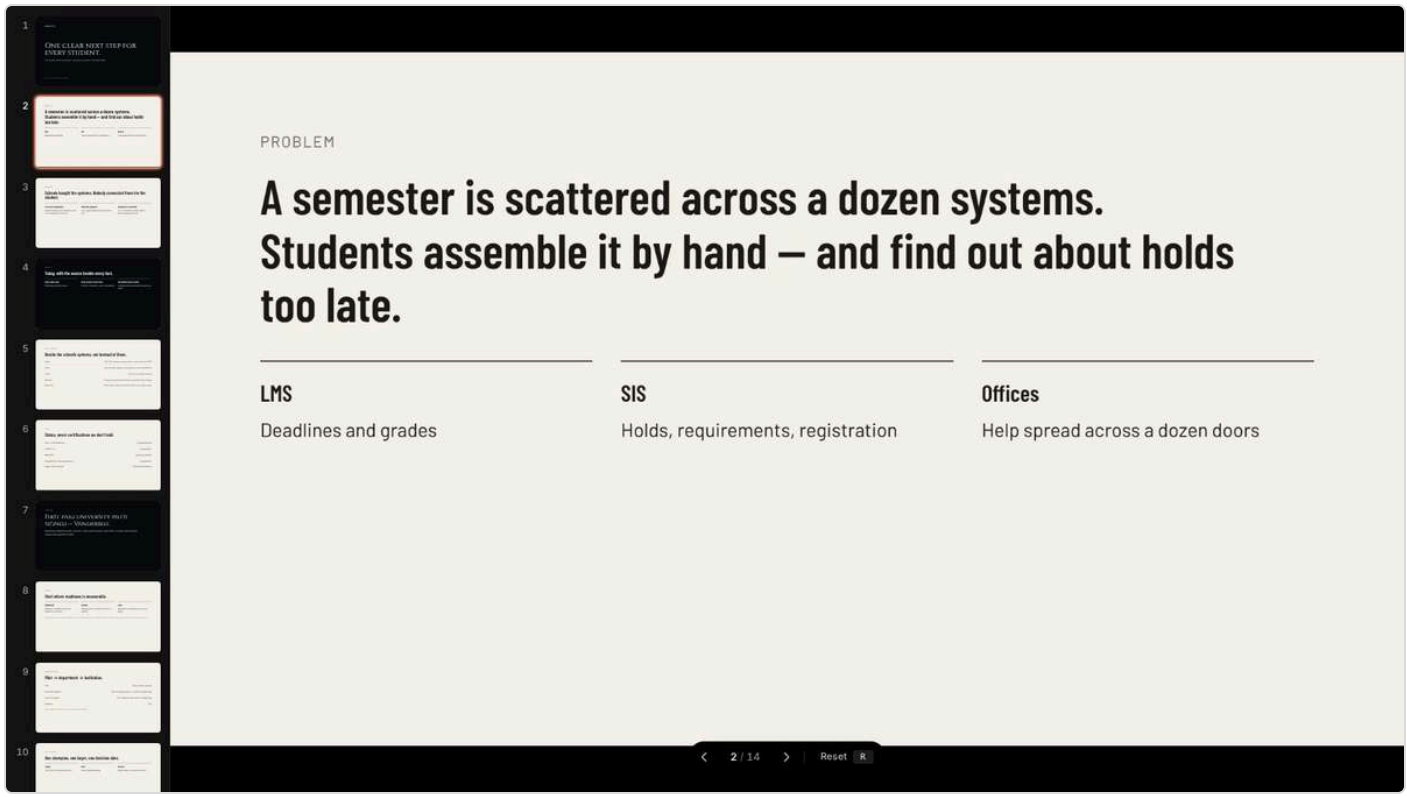
Slide 6

Company deck

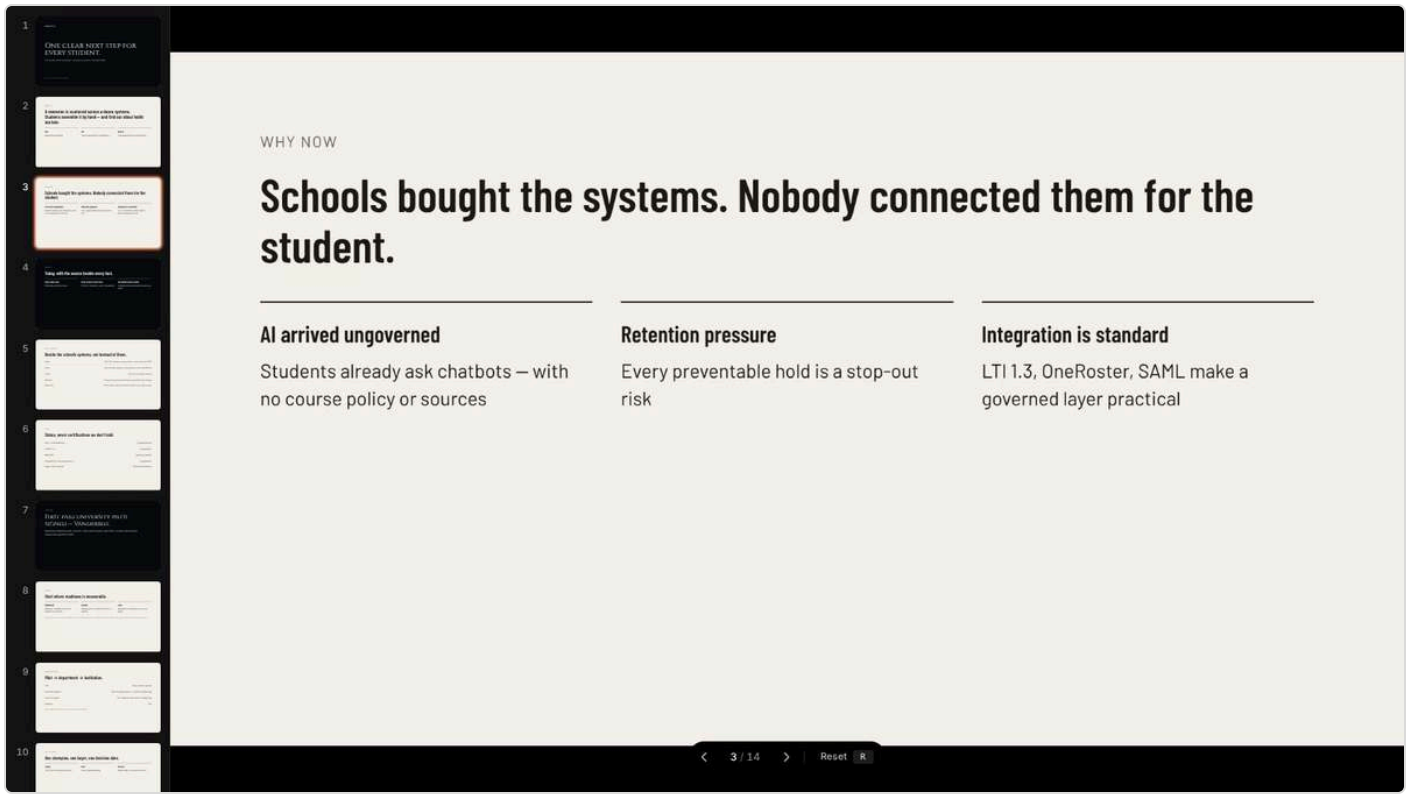
Every slide, rendered from the deck template. **14 screens.**



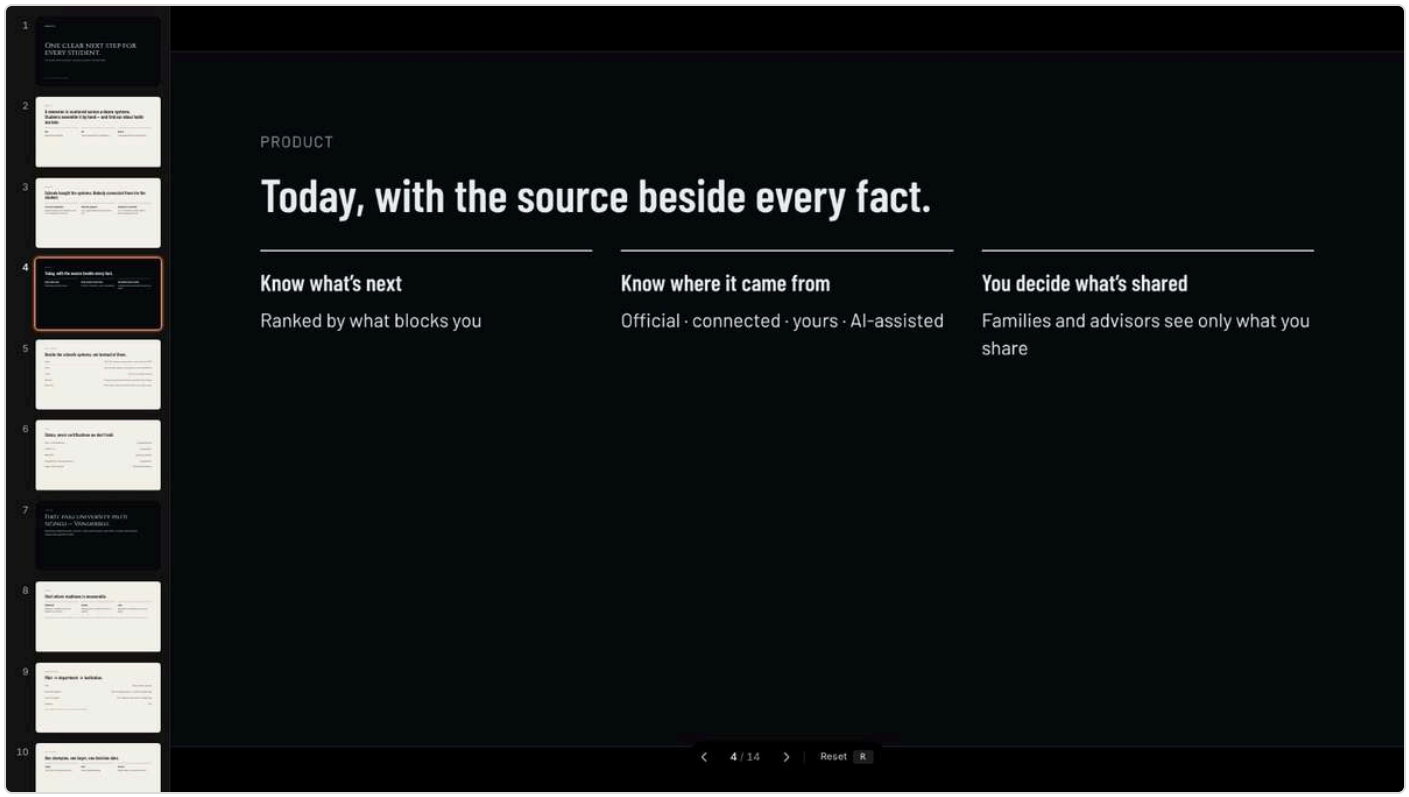
Slide 1



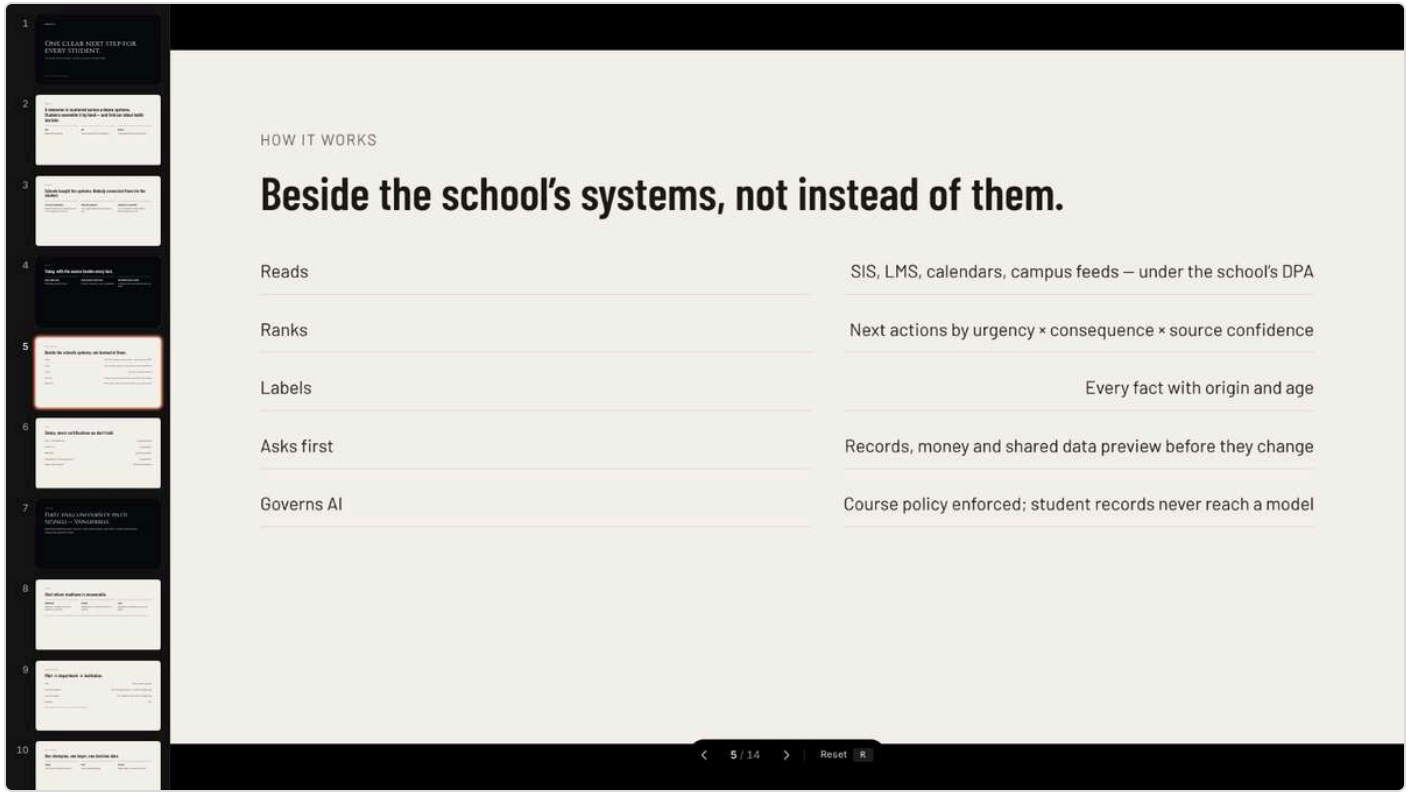
Slide 2



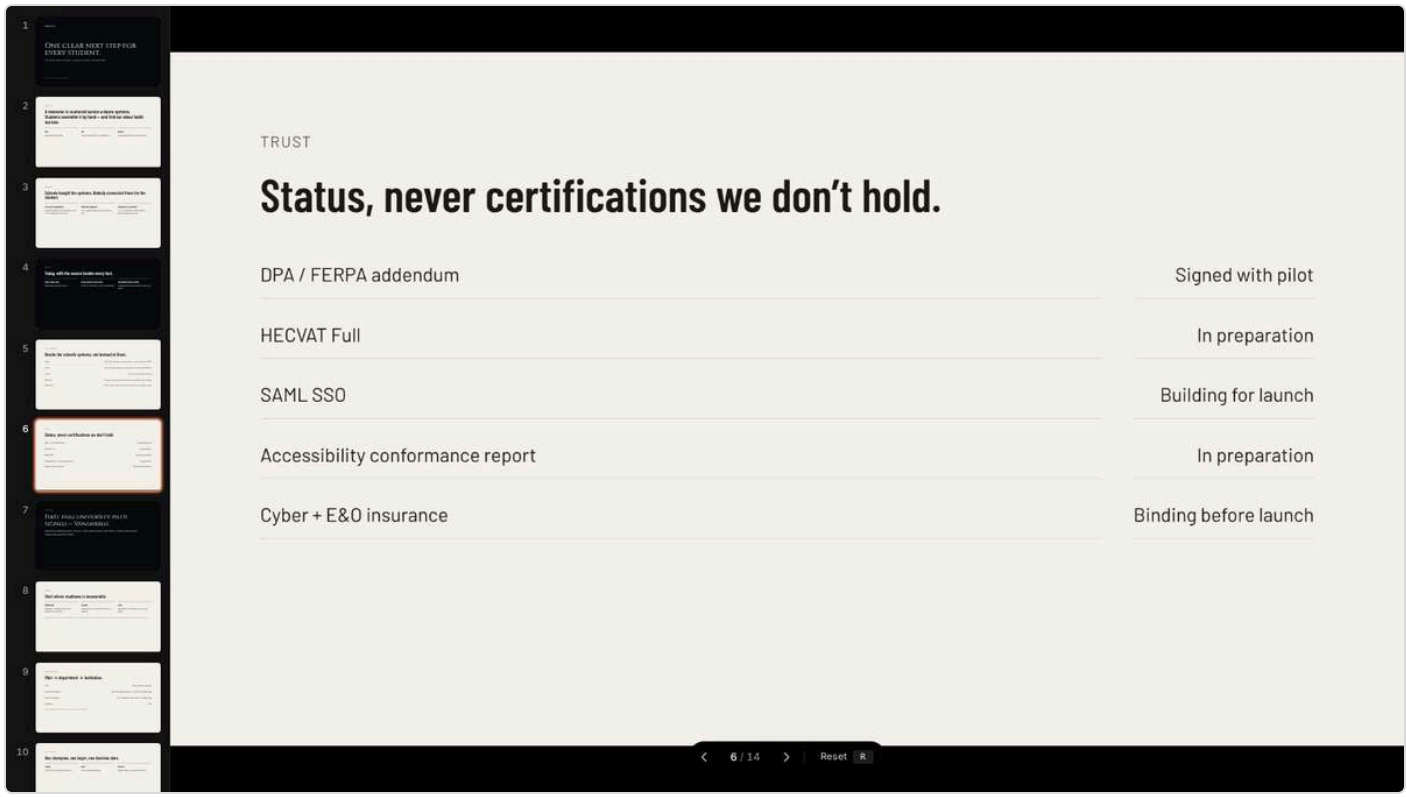
Slide 3



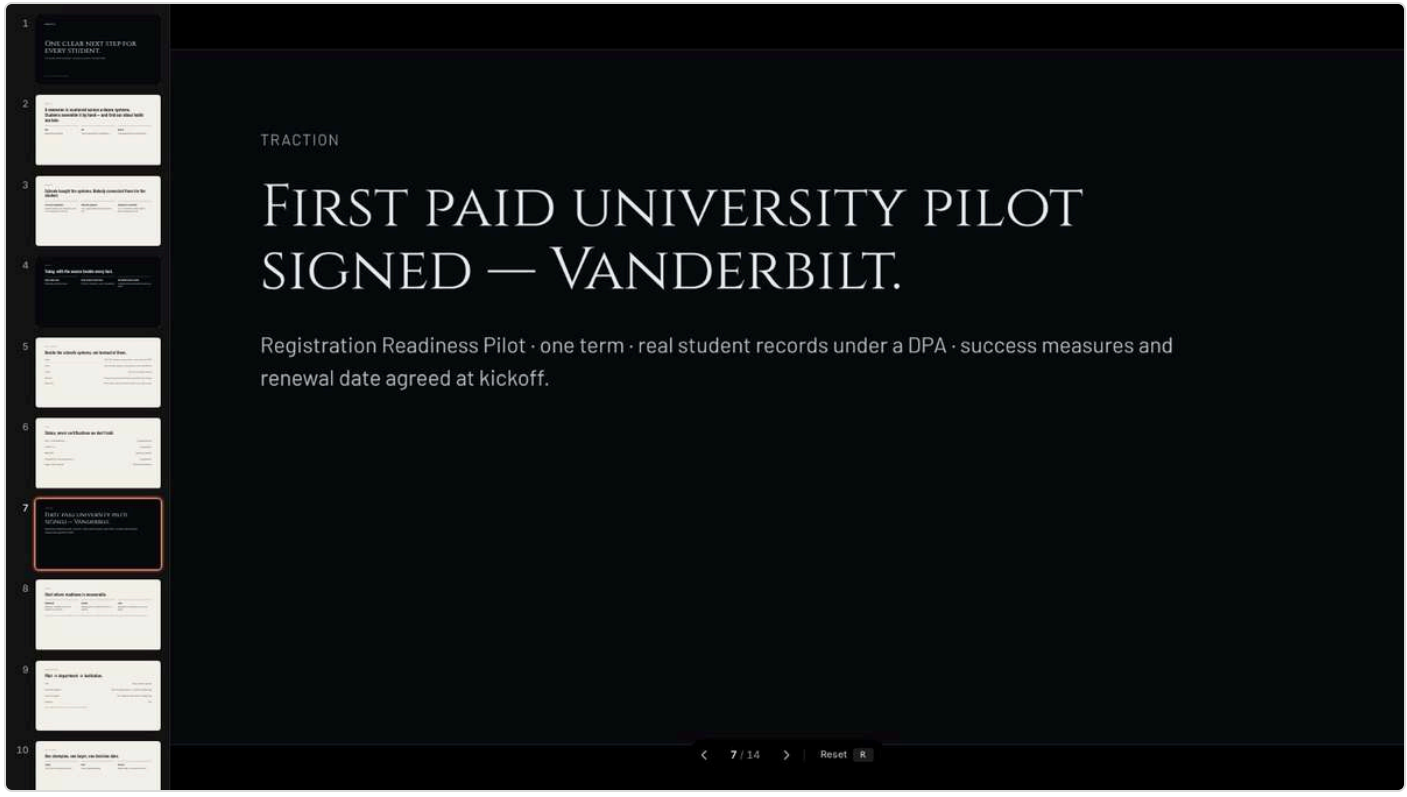
Slide 4



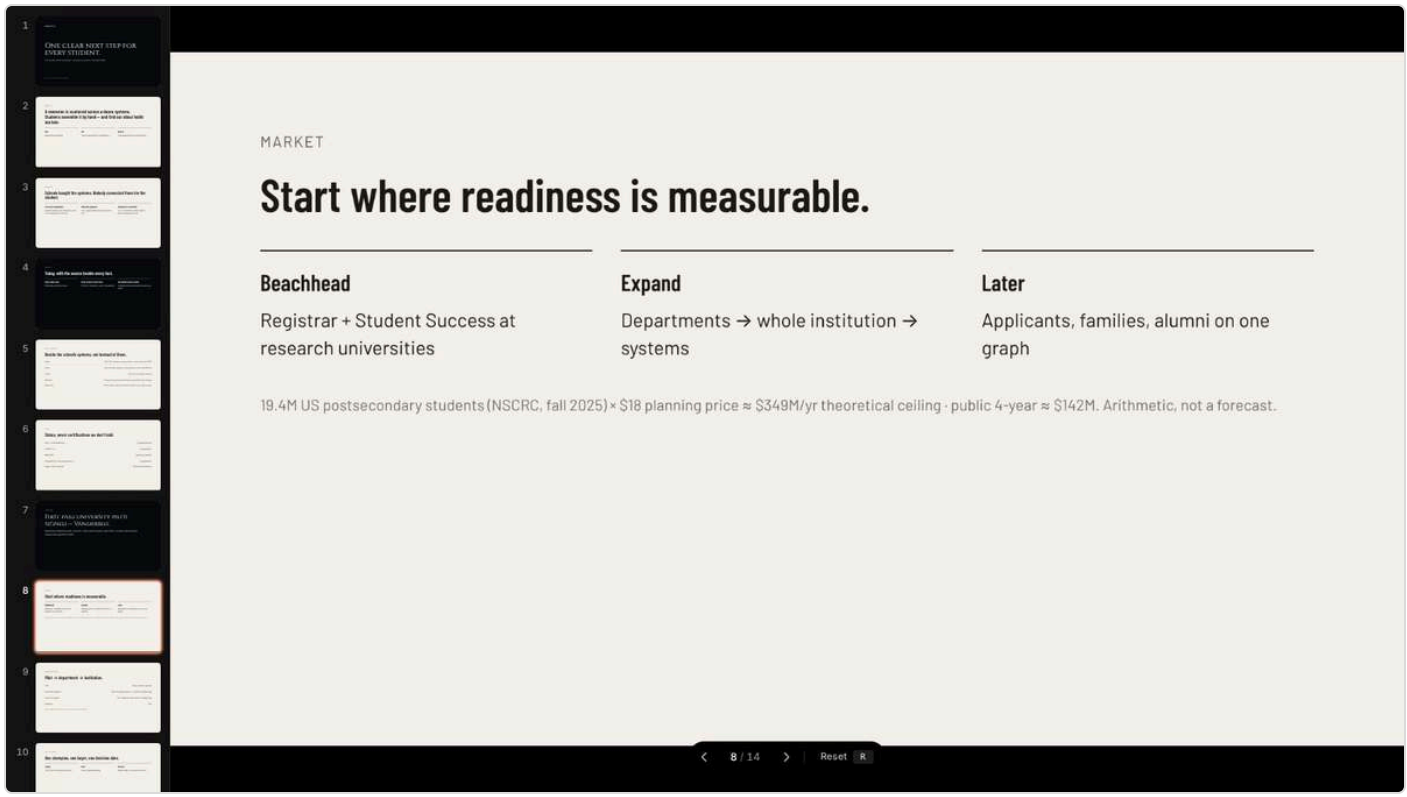
Slide 5



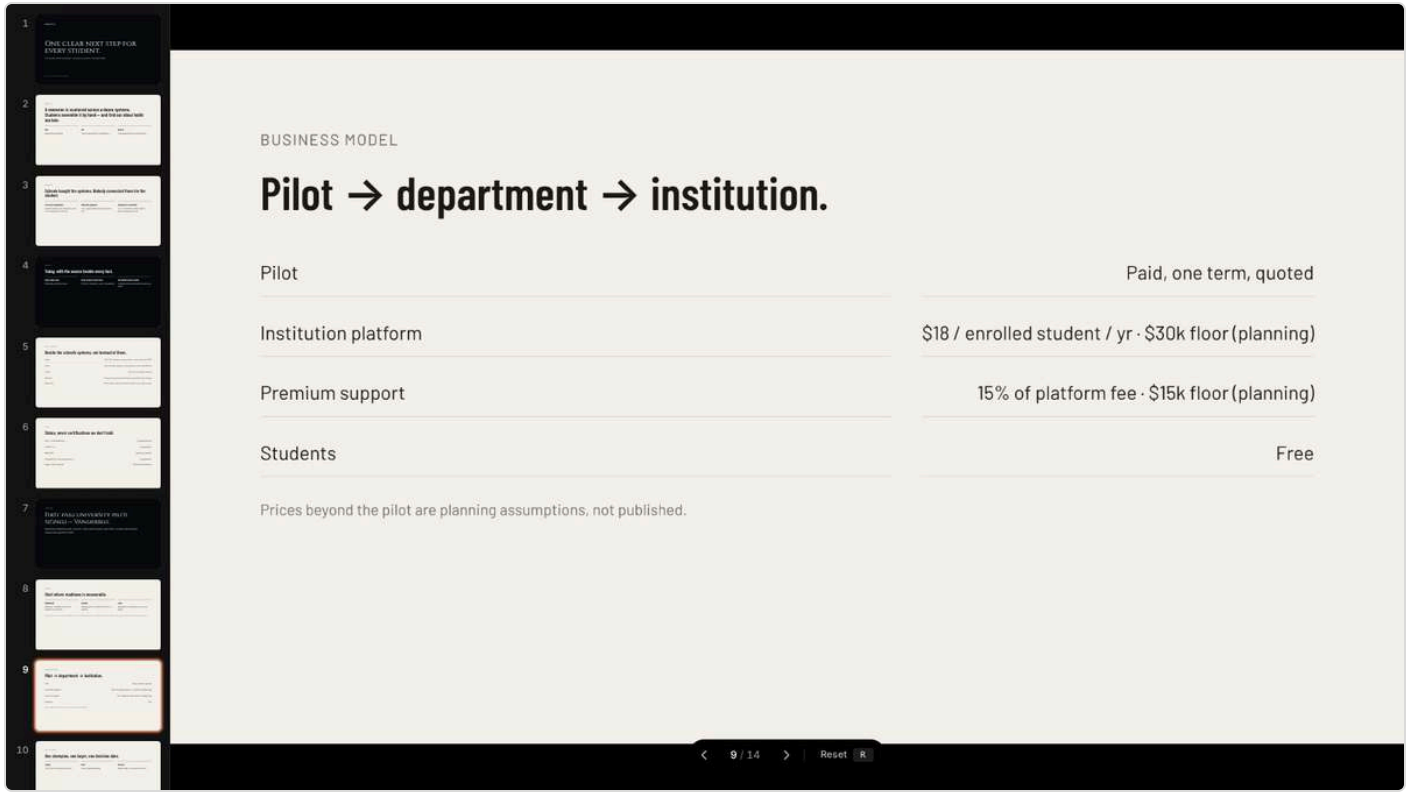
Slide 6



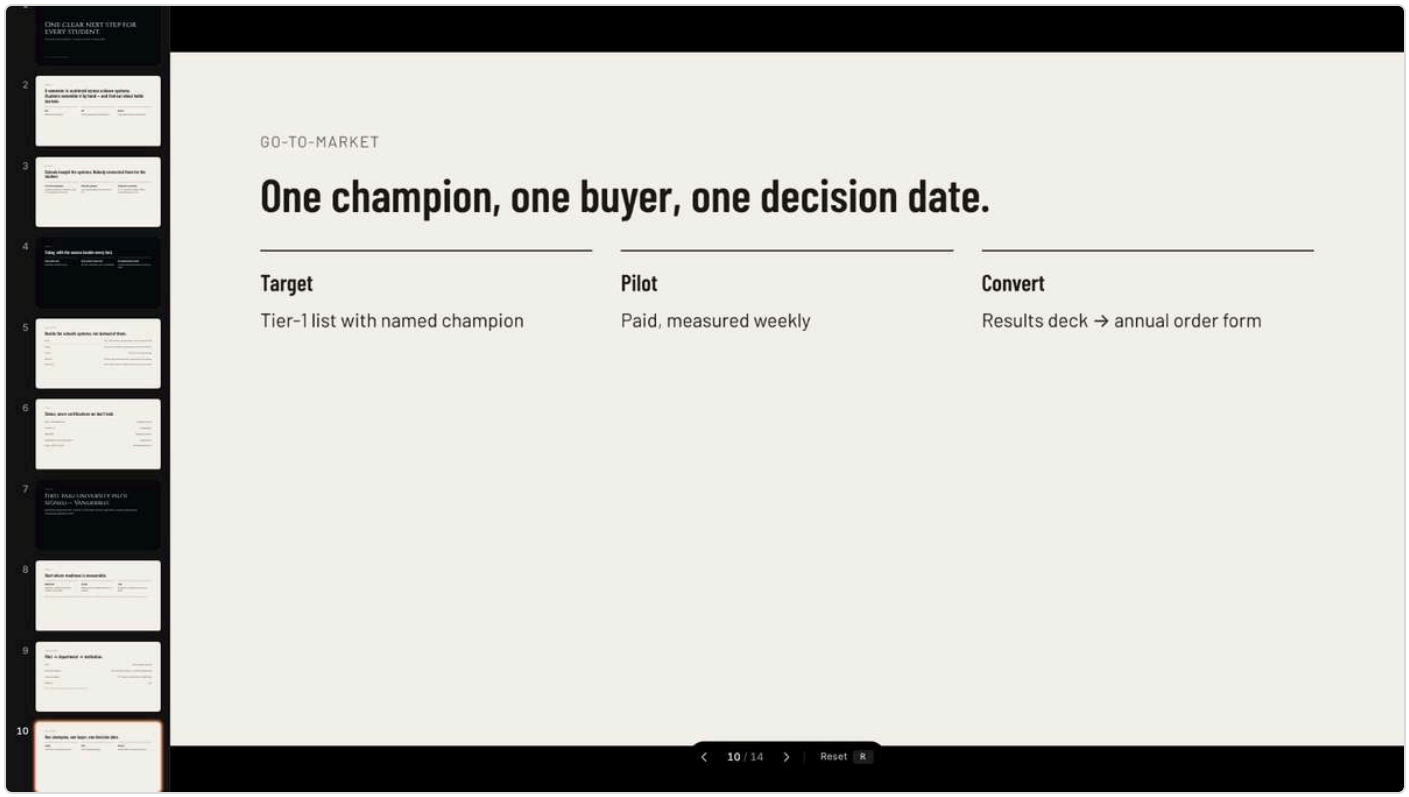
Slide 7



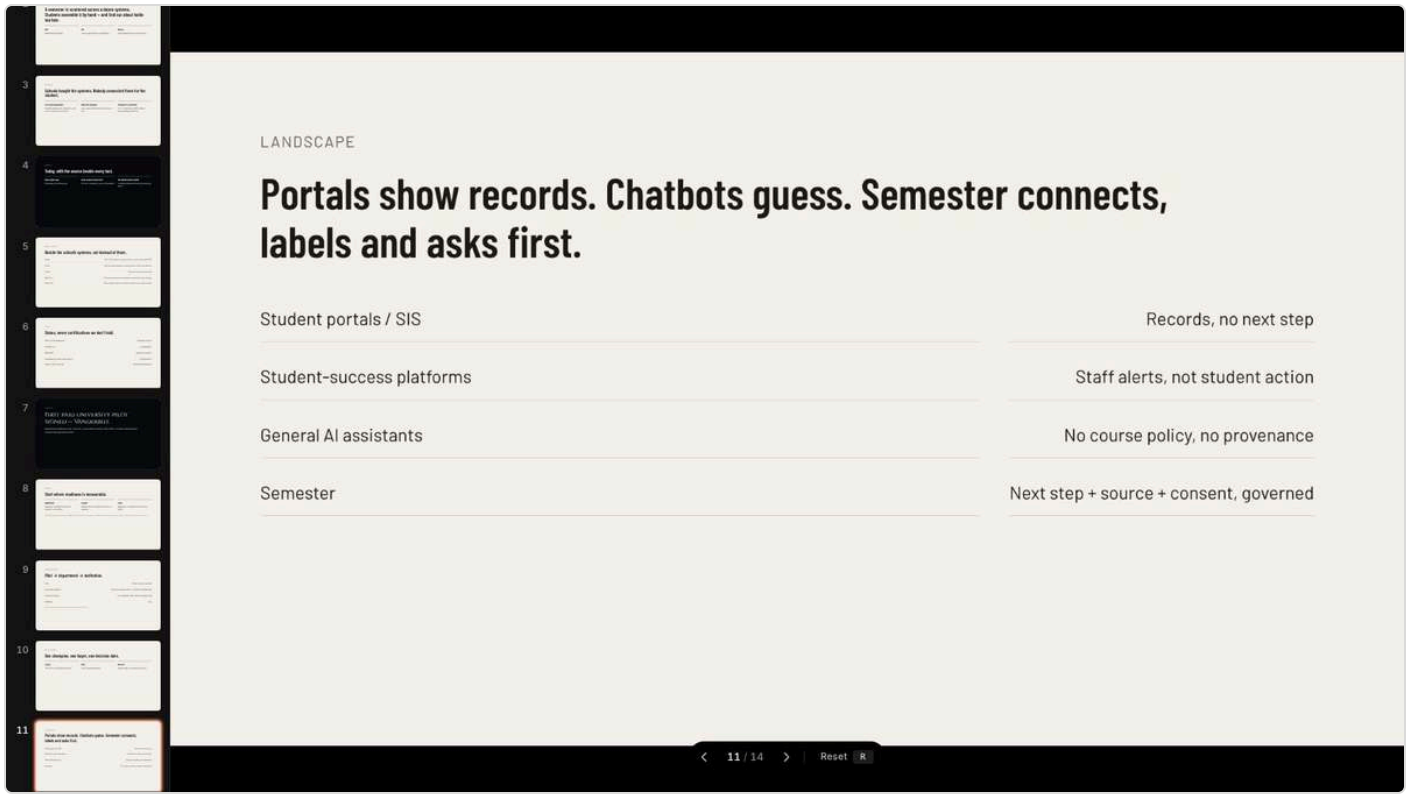
Slide 8



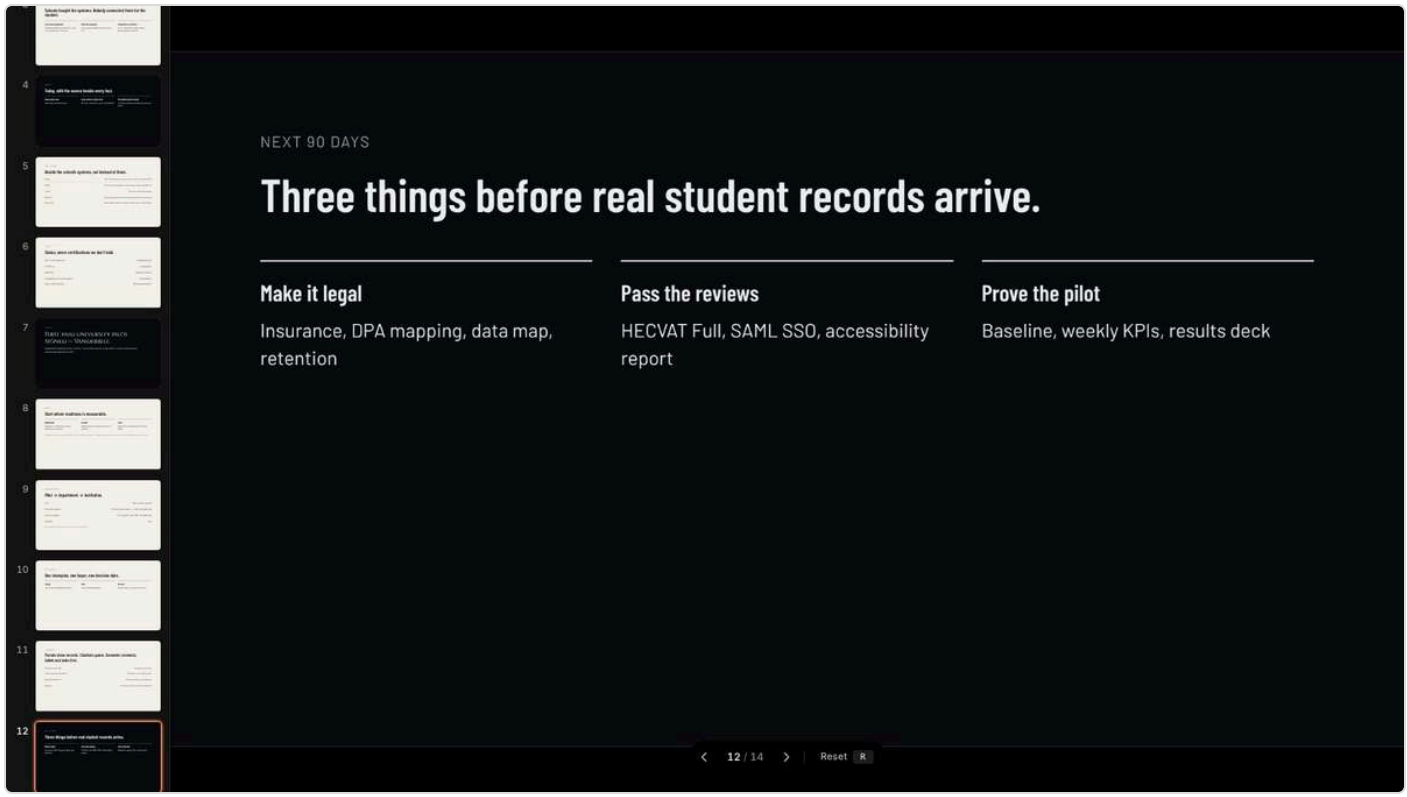
Slide 9



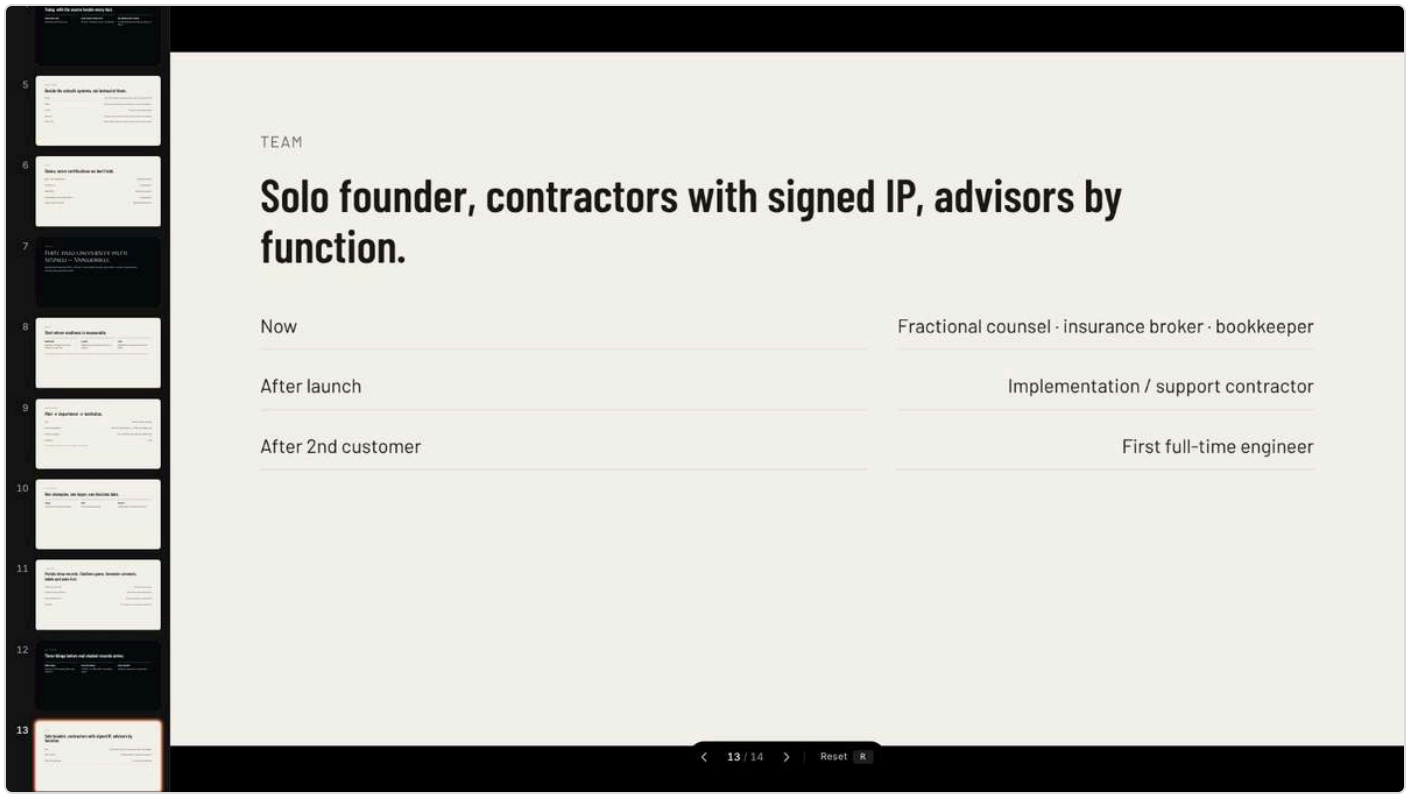
Slide 10



Slide 11



Slide 12



Slide 13

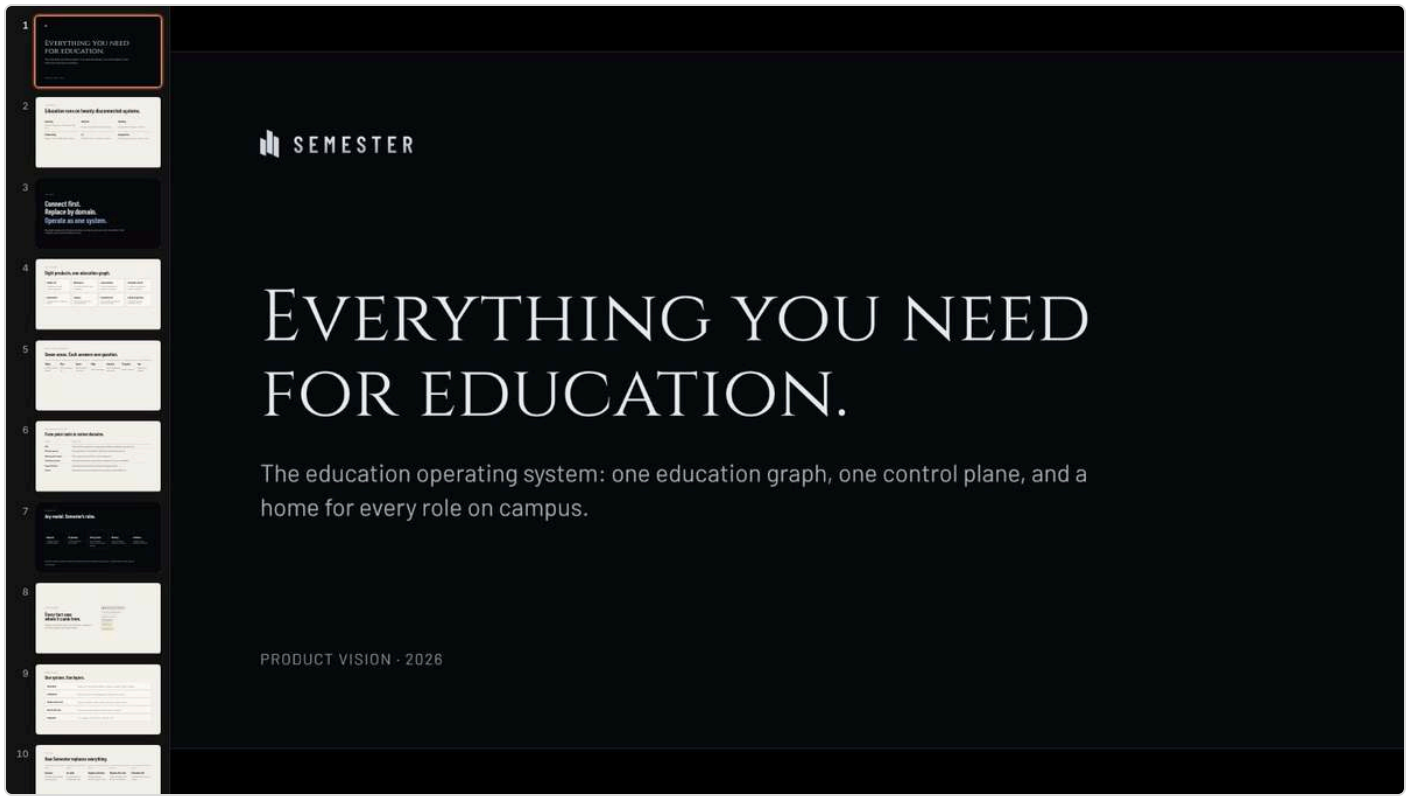

6
7
8
9
10
11
12
13
14
EVERY STUDENT, ONE CLEAR NEXT STEP.
hello@semester.example · Bootstrapping today; raising decision after pilot results
14 / 14
Reset R

Slide 14

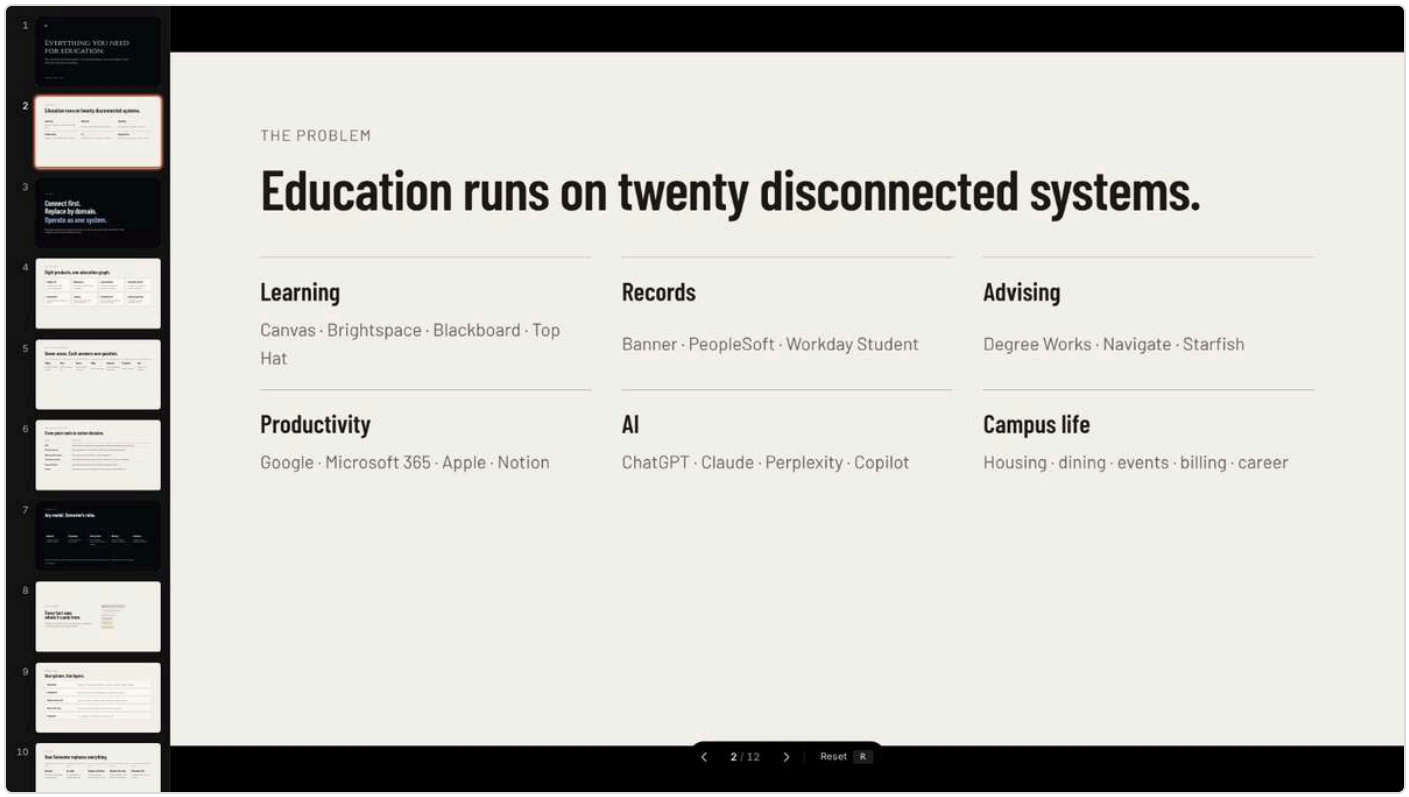
COMPANY · DECK

Vision deck

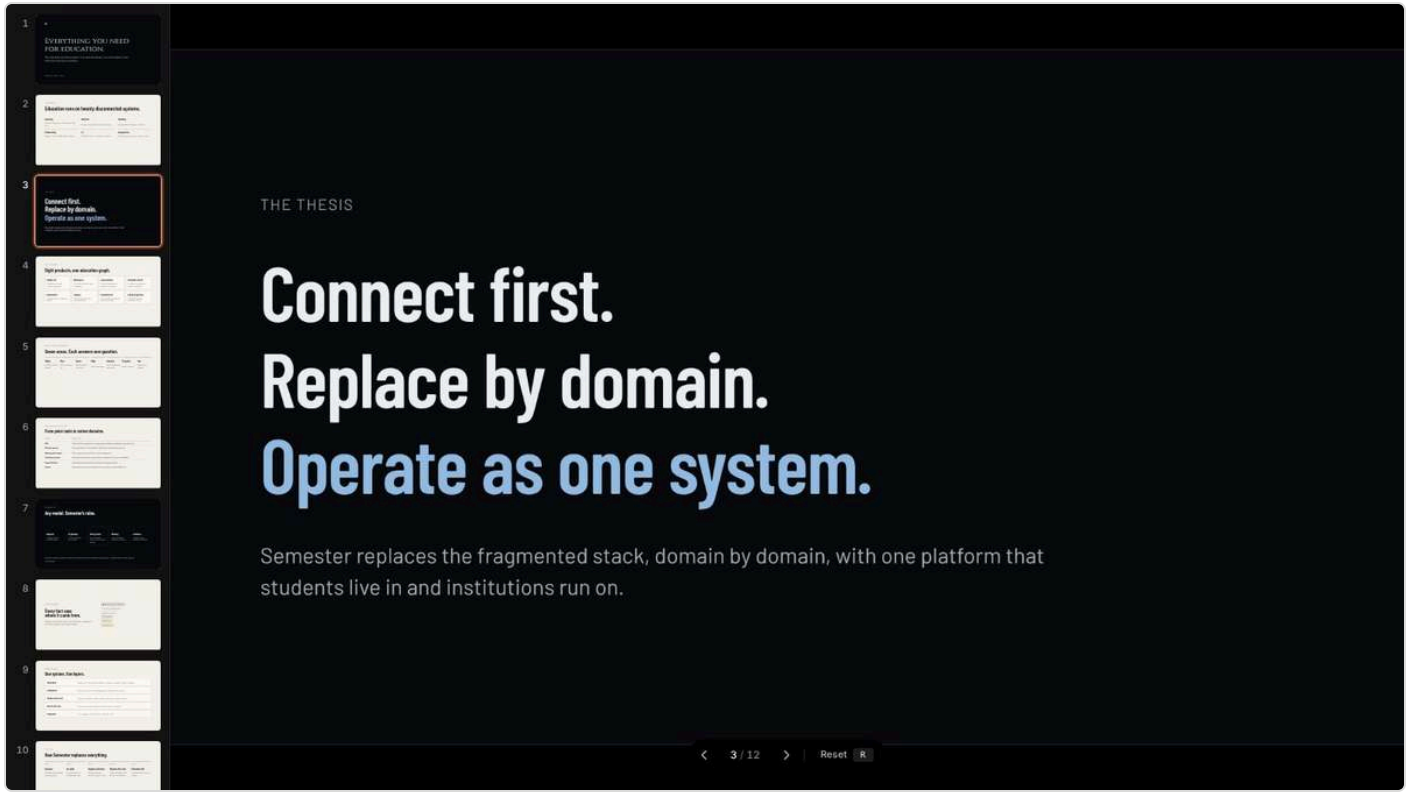
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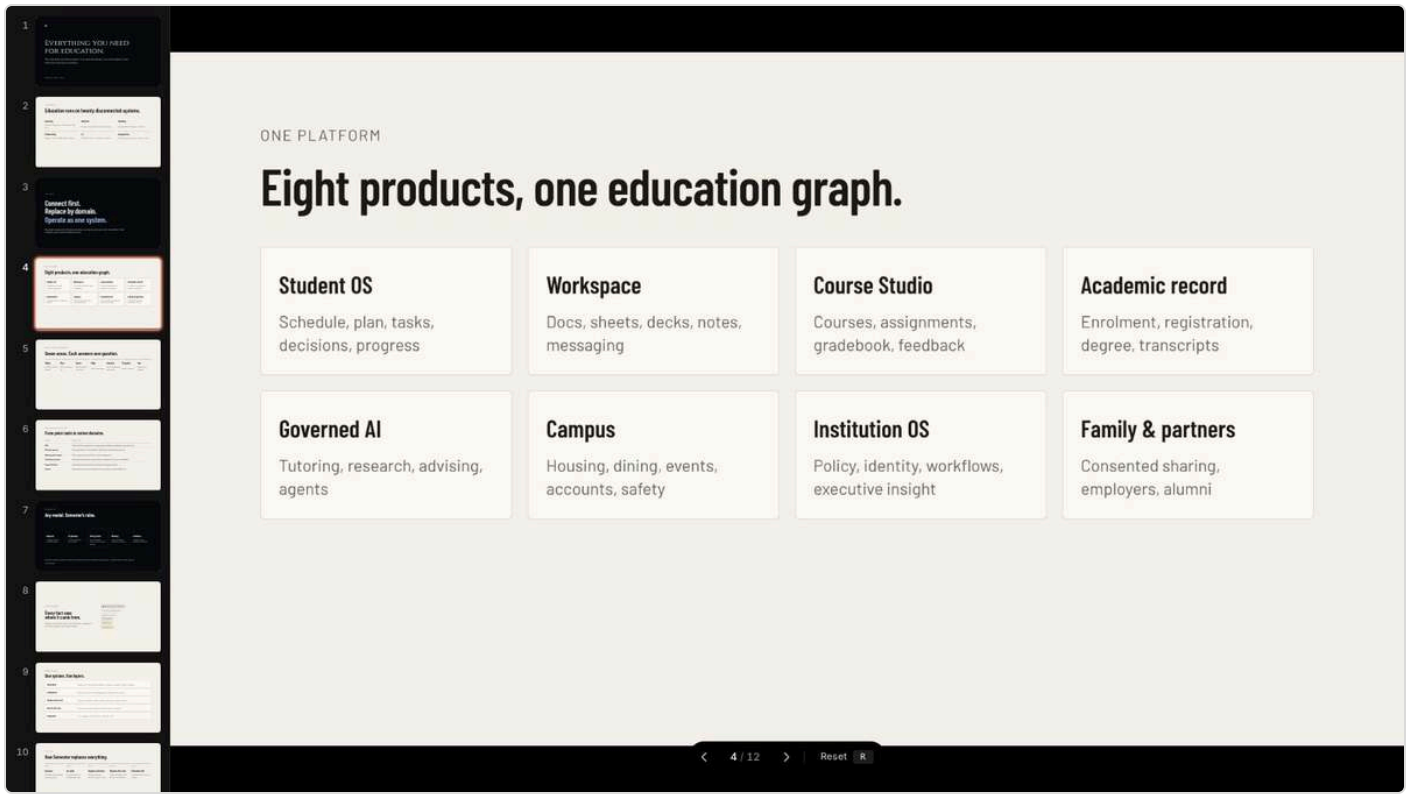
Slide 1



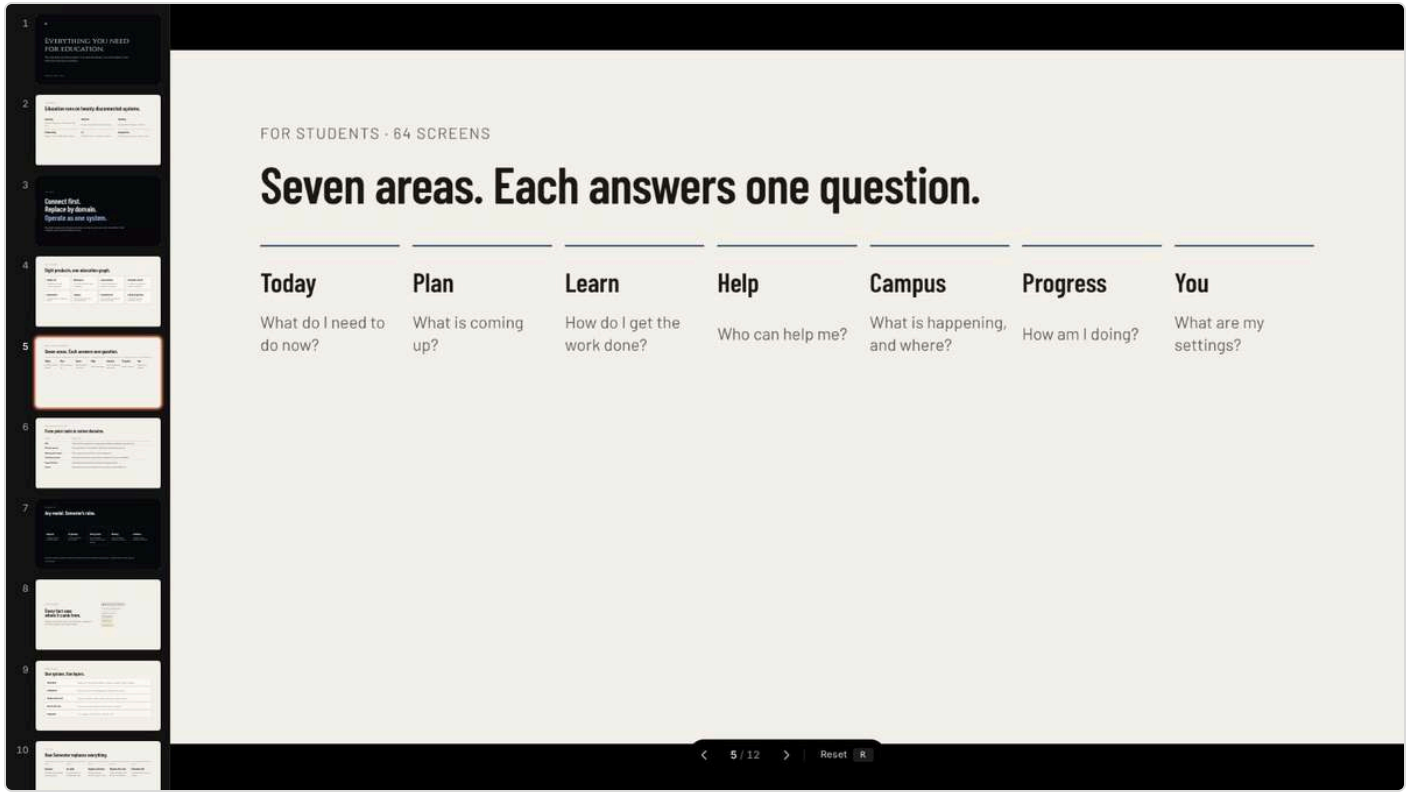
Slide 2



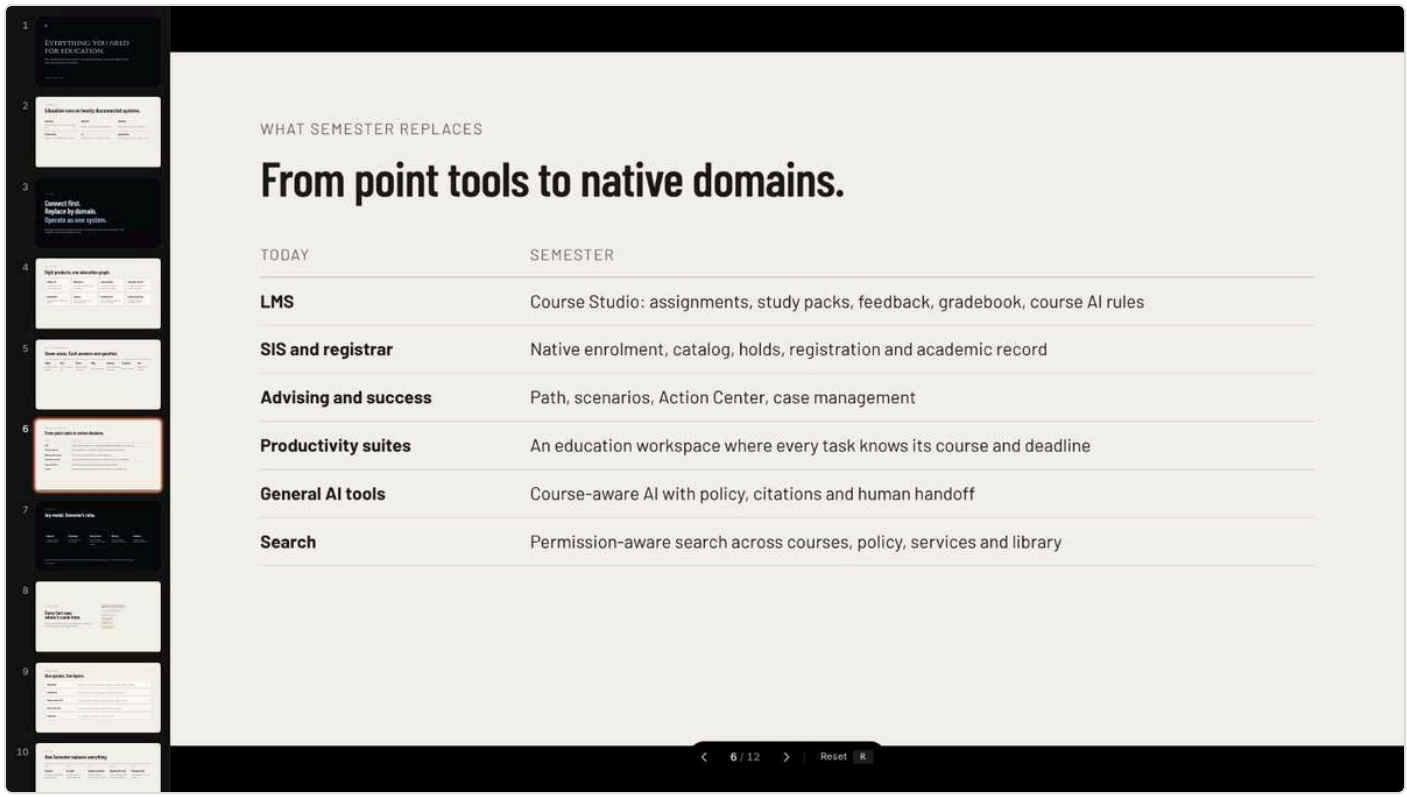
Slide 3



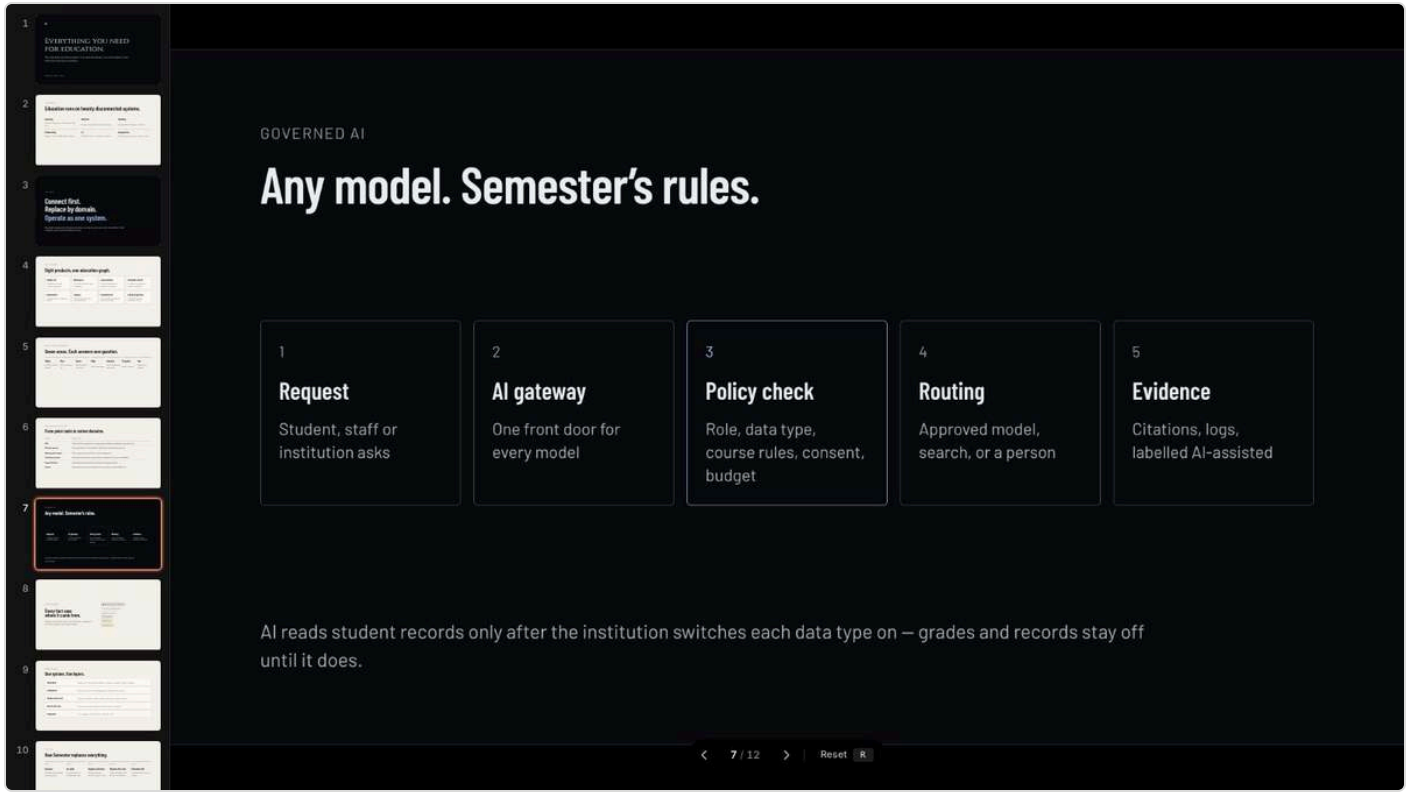
Slide 4



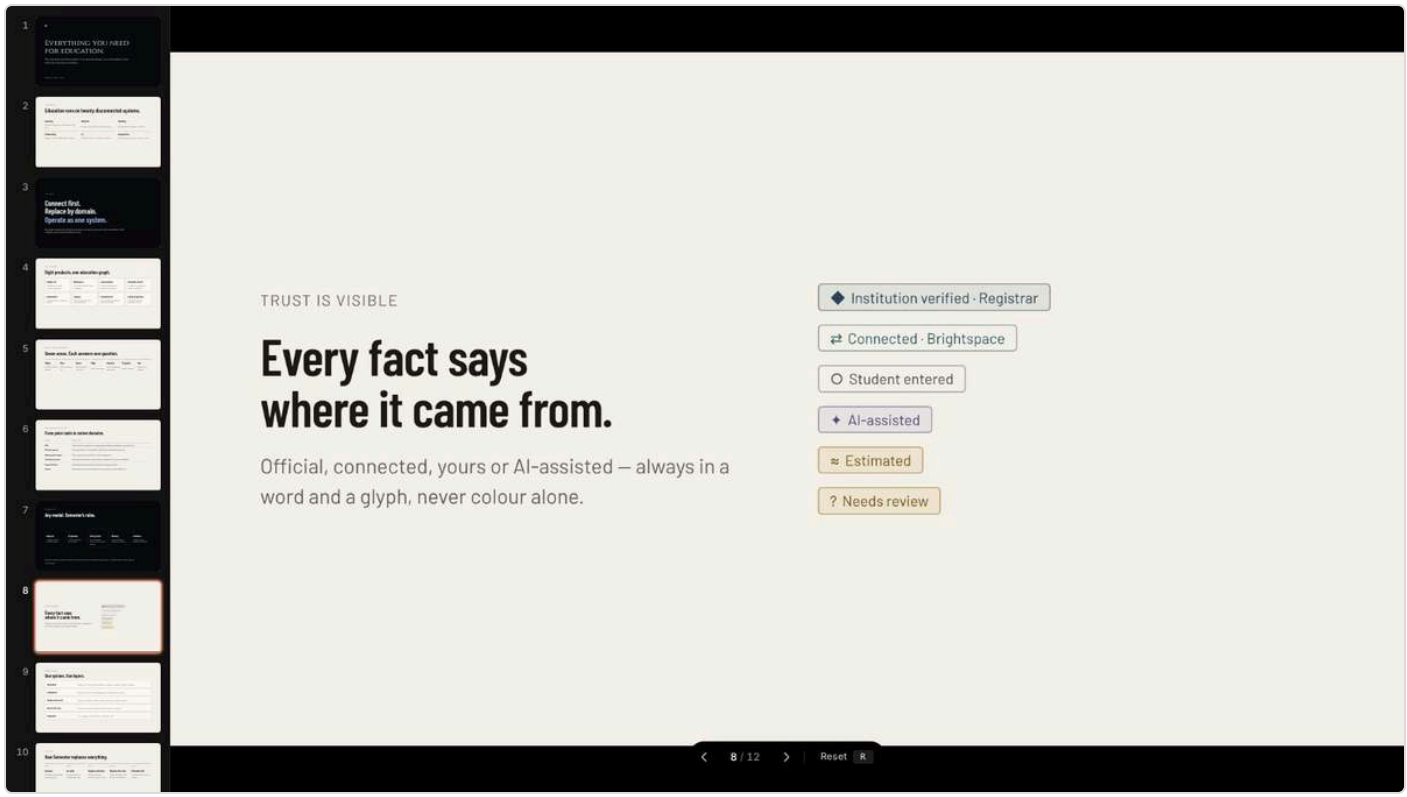
Slide 5



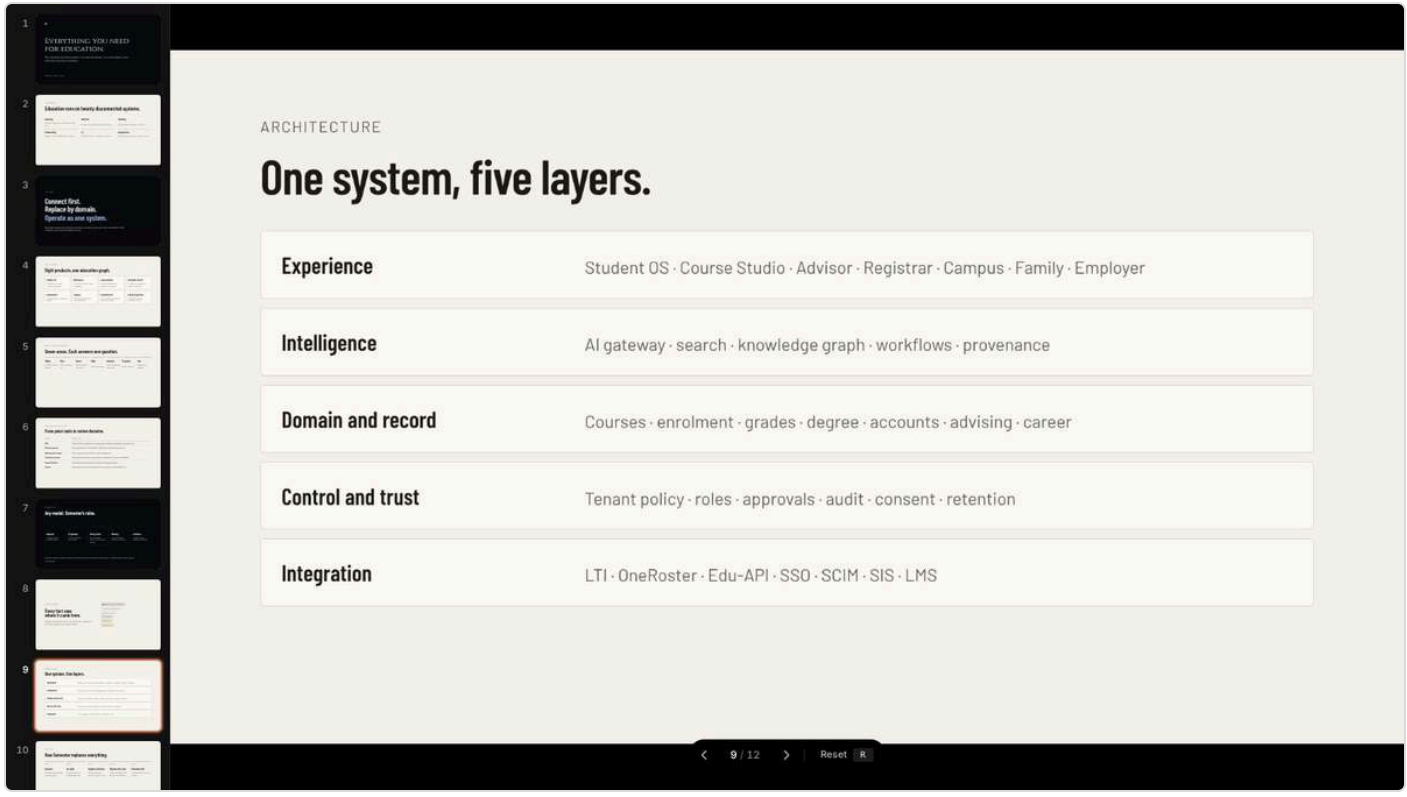
Slide 6



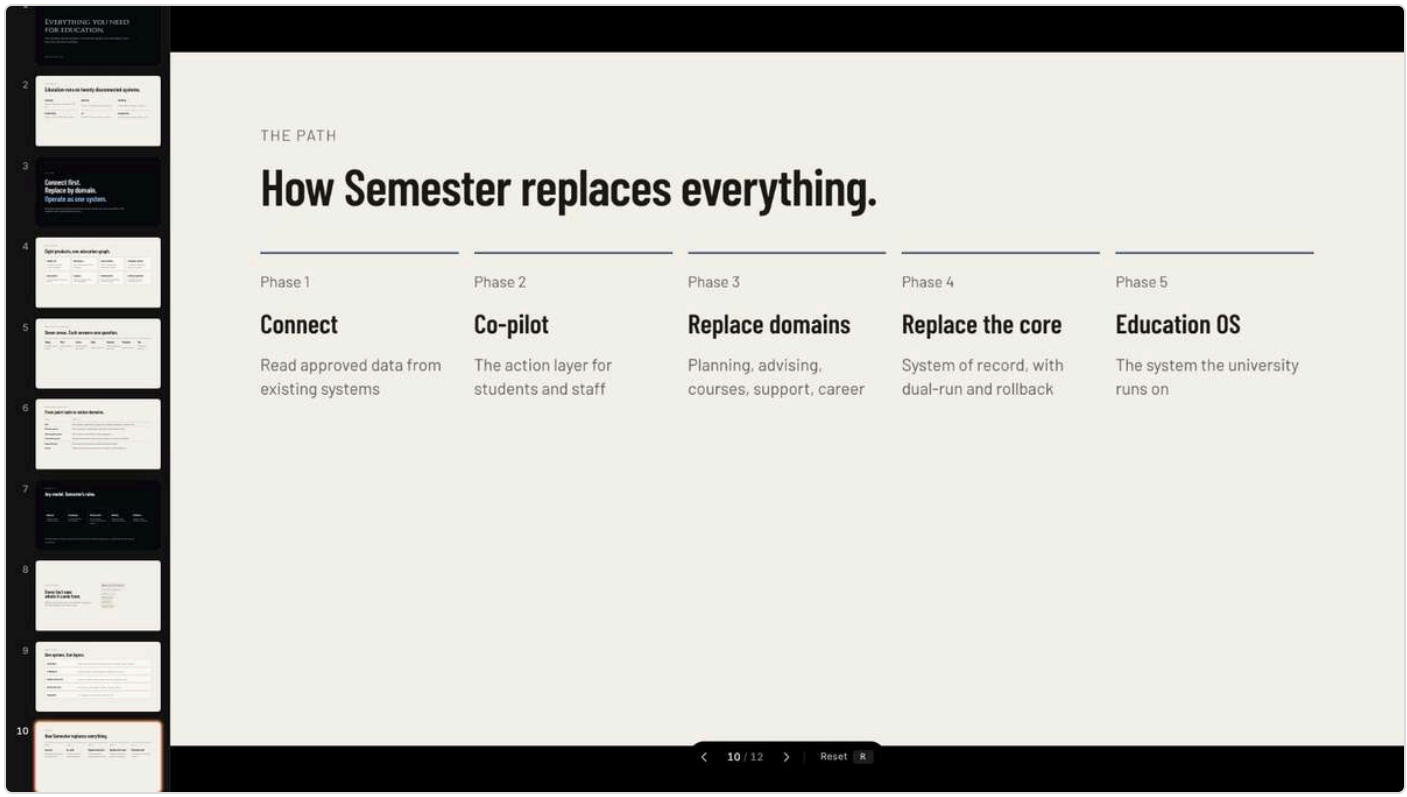
Slide 7



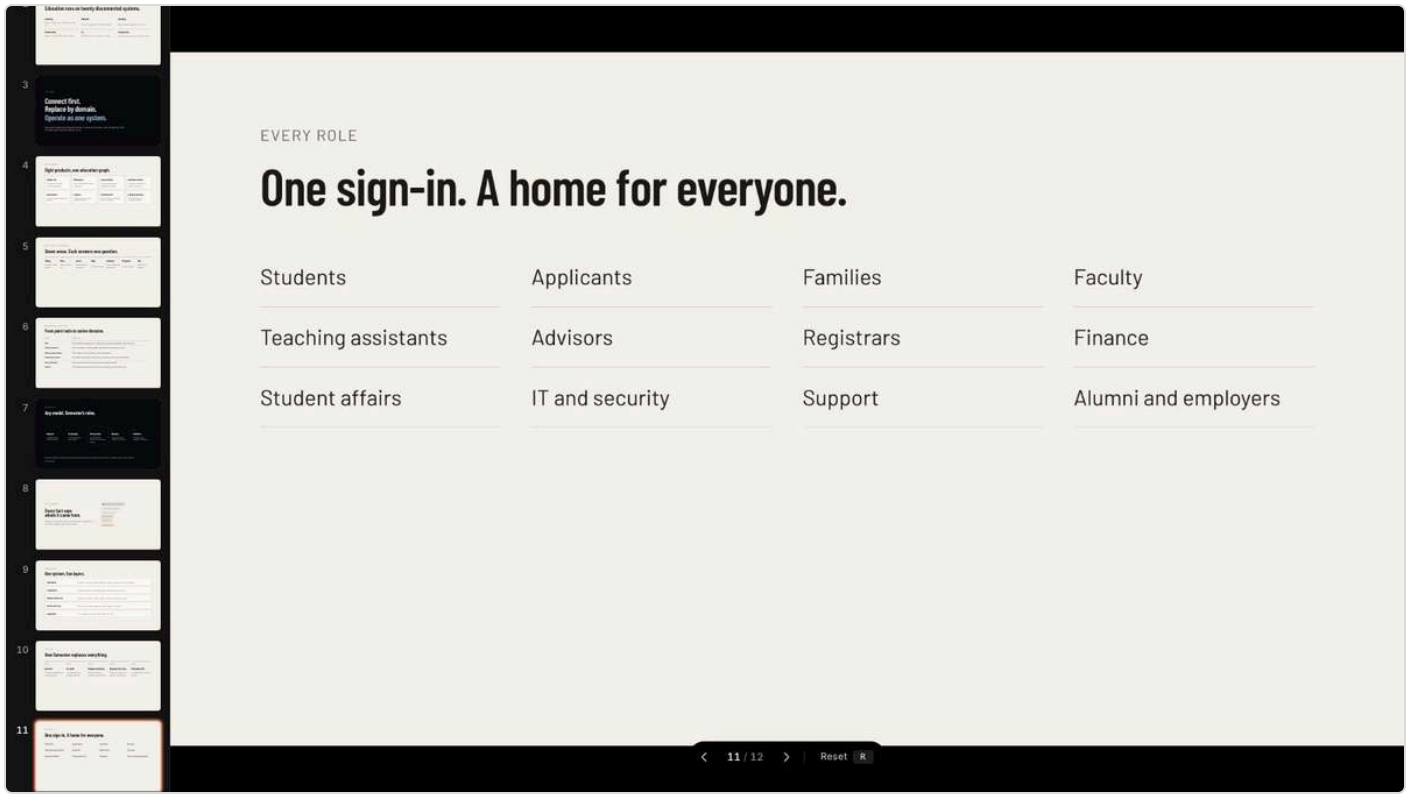
Slide 8



Slide 9



Slide 10



Slide 11


Connect first.
Replace by domain.
Operate as one system.
4
5
6
7
8
9
10
11
12
ONE SYSTEM. EVERY ROLE.
EVERY YEAR OF EDUCATION.
semester · the education operating system
12 / 12
Reset R

Slide 12

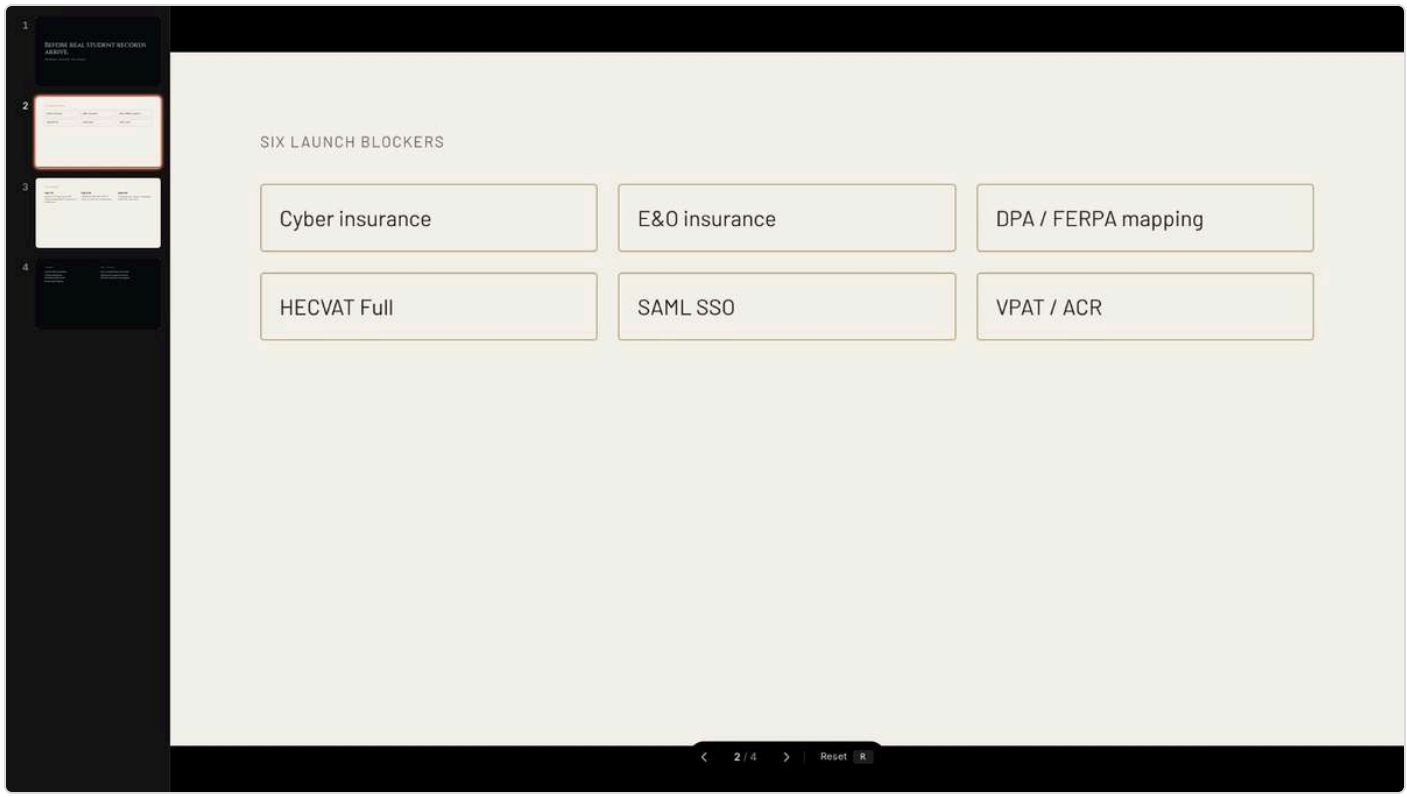
COMPANY · DECK

Internal plan deck

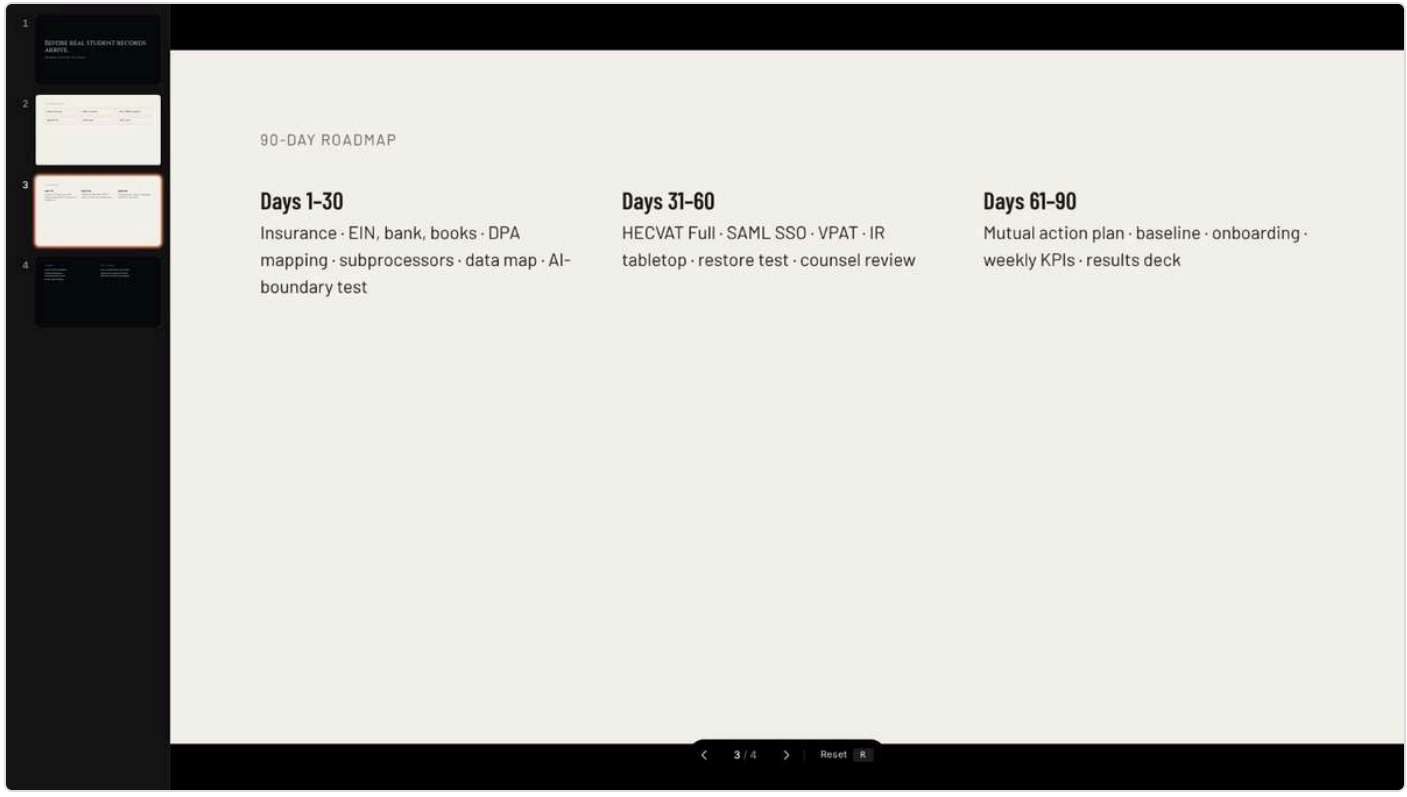
Every slide, rendered from the deck template. **4 screens.**



Slide 1



Slide 2



Slide 3


1
BEFORE REAL STUDENT RECORDS ARRIVE.
2
3
4
TOP RISKS
Launch without insurance
HECVAT stalls review
No decision date → drift
Solo-founder capacity
HIRE / CONTRACT
Now: counsel, broker, accountant
After launch: support contractor
After 2nd customer: first engineer
4 / 4
Reset R

Slide 4